Lives of the Bible

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A Small-Group Study of 170 People in Scripture

VOLUME II

The New Testament

MANOJ RAMACHANDRAN

Lives of the Bible: A Small-Group Study of 170 People in Scripture. Volume II: The New Testament.

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Scripture quotations are from the King James Version (KJV).

Dates are approximate. Later tradition and debated views are labelled as such and are not presented as Scripture.

Free printable handouts for every chapter: mramachandran.github.io/sermon_notes

How to use this book

Lives of the Bible is a small-group study of 170 people in Scripture, from Adam to the early church. This volume covers the new testament.

One person, four pages

Every chapter follows the same pattern, so a group always knows what to expect:

1. **Overview.** Who they were, key facts at a glance, and a key verse.
2. **Timeline.** The main moments of their life, each with its reference.
3. **Key activities.** What they actually did, numbered and referenced.
4. **Across Scripture.** Every Old and New Testament passage that mentions them, plus four discussion questions.

Direct references are kept separate from thematic echoes, and later tradition is labelled so it is never passed off as Scripture.

Using it in a group

One chapter fits one meeting of about 45 minutes. Lined space for group notes is left on the pages wherever it fits.

Scripture

Quotations are from the King James Version. Dates are approximate and follow common scholarly estimates.

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117 Zechariah and Elizabeth

An old priest and his wife who waited on God for years and became the parents of John the Baptist.

After the long years since Malachi, God speaks first to an ordinary priest and his wife, blameless in his sight, yet old and childless. While Zechariah served in the temple, the angel Gabriel promised them a son who would prepare the way for the Lord. Zechariah doubted and was struck silent. Elizabeth welcomed her relative Mary and called Mary's unborn child "my Lord." Theirs is a story of faithfulness in the long wait.

At a glance

Names	Zechariah, "the Lord has remembered"; KJV Zacharias, Elisabeth
Family	Priest of Abijah's course; she of "the daughters of Aaron" (Luke 1:5)
Son	John the Baptist (Luke 1:13, 57–63)
Relative	Mary, Elizabeth's "cousin," meaning kinswoman (Luke 1:36)
When	c. 7–4 BC, "in the days of Herod, the king of Judaea"
Key places	The temple; their home in the hill country of Judah (Luke 1:39)
Main passages	Luke 1:5–25, 39–80

"And they were both righteous before God, walking in all the commandments and ordinances of the Lord blameless."

Luke 1:6, KJV

The life of Zechariah and Elizabeth

Dates are approximate (BC). They depend on Jesus' birth, c. 6–4 BC, since John was about six months older.

c. 7–5 BC
Old age

Chosen to burn incense

Zechariah's priestly division is on duty, and the lot falls to him to offer incense in the temple. The people pray outside while he stands alone before the altar of incense. *Luke 1:5–10*

c. 7–5 BC
In the temple

Gabriel's promise

An angel says their prayer is heard: Elizabeth will bear a son named John, filled with the Holy Ghost, who will turn many to God. Zechariah asks for a sign and is struck mute. *Luke 1:11–23*

c. 7–5 BC
Five months

Elizabeth conceives

Back home, Elizabeth becomes pregnant and keeps herself hidden for five months. She praises God for taking away her reproach among the people. *Luke 1:24–25*

c. 7–5 BC
Sixth month

Mary's visit

Mary arrives from Nazareth. At her greeting the baby leaps in Elizabeth's womb, and Elizabeth, filled with the Holy Ghost, blesses Mary. Mary stays about three months. *Luke 1:36, 39–56*

c. 6–4 BC
Eighth day

"His name is John."

Neighbours expect the boy to be named after his father. Elizabeth says he will be called John, and Zechariah writes the same on a tablet. His tongue is loosed at once. *Luke 1:57–64*

c. 6–4 BC
After the naming

Zechariah's song

Filled with the Holy Ghost, Zechariah blesses God for redeeming his people and foretells that his son will go before the Lord to prepare his ways. *Luke 1:65–80*

Key activities

Luke gives no ages. He says only that both were "well stricken in years" (Luke 1:7). Scripture says nothing of them after John's birth.

1. **Lived blameless lives.** Both walked in all God's commandments, even while their prayers for a child went unanswered. *Luke 1:6–7*
2. **Served faithfully in the temple.** Zechariah went up to Jerusalem when his course was on duty and did the work given by lot. *Luke 1:8–10*
3. **Prayed for years.** The angel's first words were that Zechariah's prayer had been heard. *Luke 1:13*
4. **Doubted and was silenced.** Zechariah asked how he could know this, since he and his wife were old. He could not speak until the promise came true. *Luke 1:18–22*
5. **Gave God the credit.** Elizabeth hid herself and said, "Thus hath the Lord dealt with me," for he had taken away her reproach. *Luke 1:24–25*
6. **Blessed Mary.** Elizabeth cried out, "Blessed art thou among women, and blessed is the fruit of thy womb," and called Mary "the mother of my Lord." *Luke 1:41–45*
7. **Obeyed in naming John.** Both parents held to the name God gave, against family custom. *Luke 1:59–63*
8. **Prophesied.** Zechariah's song, often called the Benedictus, praises God's mercy and calls John "the prophet of the Highest." *Luke 1:67–79*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name them. Tradition (Protevangelium of James, 2nd century, not Scripture): Zechariah was killed for hiding the infant John.

Old Testament

1 Chronicles 24:1–19	Twenty-four priestly courses; the eighth is Abijah's
Malachi 3:1; 4:5–6	The messenger and "Elijah," applied to their son
Echo: Genesis 18:9–14; 1 Samuel 1:1–20	Other childless couples given a son

New Testament

Luke 1:5–80	The only account of their lives
Luke 3:2	"John the son of Zacharias"
Matthew 23:35	"Zacharias son of Barachias," most think not John's father

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How does Luke describe Zechariah and Elizabeth before any miracle happens (Luke 1:6–7)?
2. *Understand:* Zechariah and Mary both asked the angel a question (Luke 1:18, 34). Why might one question lead to silence and the other not?
3. *Apply:* Elizabeth and Zechariah served God faithfully through years of unanswered prayer. What prayer have you been waiting on, and how do you keep serving meanwhile?
4. *Apply:* Elizabeth welcomed Mary and strengthened her faith. Who could you encourage this week, and how?

118 Mary, mother of Jesus

The woman of Nazareth who said yes to God, raised his Son, stood at the cross, and prayed with the first church.

Mary was an ordinary Jewish woman of Nazareth, engaged to Joseph, when Gabriel told her she would conceive by the Holy Ghost and bear the Son of God. She asked one honest question and then gave herself to God's plan. Her life held great joy and deep pain: a birth in Bethlehem, flight to Egypt, and later the cross. Scripture shows her pondering what she did not yet understand, pointing others to her Son, and praying with his followers after he rose. Christians honour her in different ways, but all can learn from her trust and faithfulness.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Miriam*, like Moses' sister; Greek *Maria*
Family	Betrothed, then married, to Joseph (Matthew 1:18–25)
Children	Jesus; also "brethren" and sisters (Matthew 13:55–56)
Relative	Elizabeth, mother of John the Baptist (Luke 1:36)
When	Jesus born c. 6–4 BC; Mary living c. AD 30 (Acts 1:14)
Key places	Nazareth, Bethlehem, Egypt, Cana, Jerusalem
Key people	Joseph, Elizabeth, Simeon, the disciple Jesus loved
Last mention	Praying with the disciples before Pentecost (Acts 1:14)

"Behold the handmaid of the Lord; be it unto me according to thy word."

Luke 1:38, KJV

The life of Mary, mother of Jesus

Dates are approximate (BC or AD). Scripture does not give Mary's age at any point.

c. 7–5 BC
In Nazareth

Gabriel's message

The angel tells Mary she will bear Jesus, the Son of the Highest. She asks how, hears of the Holy Ghost, and consents. *Luke 1:26–38*

c. 7–5 BC
Hill country of Judah

Visits Elizabeth

Elizabeth blesses her, and Mary answers with a song of praise, often called the Magnificat. *Luke 1:39–56*

c. 6–4 BC
Bethlehem

Gives birth to Jesus

She lays her firstborn son in a manger. Shepherds come, and Mary keeps these things in her heart. *Luke 2:1–20*

c. 6–4 BC
Forty days old

The temple

They offer the poor family's two birds. Simeon warns that a sword will pierce her own soul. *Luke 2:21–39; Leviticus 12:2–8*

c. 6–4 BC
Under Herod

Flight to Egypt

After the wise men's visit, Joseph takes Mary and Jesus to Egypt, then settles in Nazareth. *Matthew 2:1–23*

Jesus aged 12

Lost and found

After three days' searching they find Jesus in the temple, about his Father's business. *Luke 2:41–51*

c. AD 28–30
Jesus' ministry

Cana and after

At Cana she tells the servants to do whatever Jesus says. Later she and his brothers seek him. *John 2:1–12; Mark 3:31–35*

c. AD 30 or 33
Cross and upper room

Faithful to the end

Jesus entrusts her to the disciple he loved. After the ascension she prays with the apostles. *John 19:25–27; Acts 1:14*

Key activities

Christians differ over Mary's later role. Roman Catholic and Orthodox Christians honour her in ways many Protestants do not. This chapter follows what the text says.

1. **Believed God's word.** Told she would bear God's Son, she answered, "Behold the handmaid of the Lord." Elizabeth called her blessed because she believed. *Luke 1:38, 45*
2. **Asked an honest question.** She asked, "How shall this be, seeing I know not a man?" and was answered, "For with God nothing shall be impossible." *Luke 1:34–37*
3. **Sang of God's mercy.** Her song praises God who scatters the proud, lifts the lowly, fills the hungry, and remembers his promise to Abraham. *Luke 1:46–55*
4. **Faced hardship and possible disgrace.** She conceived before her marriage was completed and gave birth far from home, with "no room for them in the inn." *Matthew 1:18–19; Luke 2:4–7*
5. **Pondered in her heart.** Twice Luke says she treasured up what she saw and heard, even when she did not understand it. *Luke 2:19, 51*
6. **Kept the Law.** She and Joseph circumcised Jesus, presented him in the temple, and went up to Jerusalem every year for Passover. *Luke 2:21–24, 41*
7. **Fled as a refugee.** She went with Joseph to Egypt to save the child from Herod. *Matthew 2:13–15*
8. **Pointed others to Jesus.** At Cana she said, "Whatsoever he saith unto you, do it." *John 2:5*
9. **Stood by the cross.** She was near the cross with other women when most of the disciples had fled. *John 19:25; Mark 14:50*
10. **Prayed with the church.** She continued in prayer with the apostles, the women and Jesus' brothers in Jerusalem. *Acts 1:14*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links. Christians differ on whether Jesus' "brethren" were Mary's children, Joseph's, or cousins; stories of her later life and assumption are later tradition, not Scripture.

Old Testament

Isaiah 7:14	"A virgin shall conceive," fulfilled in Mary (Matthew 1:22–23)
Echo: 1 Samuel 2:1–10	Hannah's song, strongly echoed in Mary's
Echo: Genesis 3:15	The promised seed, fulfilled in her Son (Galatians 4:4)

New Testament

Matthew 1:16–25; 2:11–21	Joseph's wife and mother of the child Jesus
Luke 1:26–56; 2:1–52	The fullest account of her story
Mark 3:31–35; 6:3	She seeks Jesus; he is "the son of Mary"
John 2:1–12; 19:25–27	At the first sign and at the cross
Acts 1:14	Her last mention by name

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Mary say to Gabriel, and what did she ask (Luke 1:34, 38)?
2. *Understand:* Simeon warned that a sword would pierce Mary's soul (Luke 2:35). Where in her story do you see that happen?
3. *Apply:* Mary "pondered" what she did not understand. What is one thing God is doing in your life that you need to ponder rather than rush to explain?
4. *Apply:* "Whatsoever he saith unto you, do it." What is one thing Jesus has said that you will obey this week?

119 Joseph of Nazareth

The quiet, just man who took Mary as his wife, named her Son, and protected him.

Joseph was a descendant of King David who worked with his hands in Nazareth. Engaged to Mary, he learned she was expecting a child that was not his. Matthew calls him "a just man," and he planned to end the engagement quietly. Then an angel spoke to him in a dream, and he obeyed at once. Joseph speaks no recorded word, yet his actions say a great deal. He took Mary home, named the child Jesus, fled to Egypt to escape Herod, and raised Jesus as his own. His life shows faith that listens, obeys and protects without seeking attention.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yoseph*, "he will add" or "may he add"
Family	"Joseph, thou son of David" (Matt 1:20); husband of Mary
Trade	"The carpenter's son" (Matt 13:55); builder or craftsman
When	c. 7–4 BC for the birth stories; last seen when Jesus was twelve
Key places	Nazareth, Bethlehem, Egypt, Jerusalem
Key people	Mary, mother of Jesus; Herod the Great; Simeon and Anna
Main passages	Matthew 1:18–2:23; Luke 1:27; 2:1–51

"Then Joseph being raised from sleep did as the angel of the Lord had bidden him, and took unto him his wife."

Matthew 1:24, KJV

The life of Joseph of Nazareth

Dates are approximate (BC or AD). Scripture gives no age for Joseph and does not record his death.

c. 7–5 BC
In Nazareth

The first dream

Joseph learns Mary is with child and decides to end the engagement privately. An angel tells him in a dream not to fear, because the child is of the Holy Ghost. He takes Mary as his wife. *Matthew 1:18–25*

c. 6–4 BC
Bethlehem

The census and the birth

Because he is of David's house, Joseph travels with Mary to Bethlehem to be registered. There Jesus is born, and Joseph gives him the name Jesus. *Luke 2:1–7; Matthew 1:25*

c. 6–4 BC
Forty days

In the temple

Joseph and Mary present Jesus to the Lord. They marvel at Simeon's words, and Simeon blesses them. *Luke 2:22–35*

c. 6–4 BC
By night

Flight into Egypt

After the wise men leave, an angel warns Joseph in a dream to flee because Herod will seek the child. Joseph rises that night and takes the family to Egypt. *Matthew 2:13–15*

c. 4 BC
After Herod dies

Home to Nazareth

Told in a dream that Herod is dead, Joseph returns. Hearing that Archelaus rules Judaea, he is afraid and, warned again, settles in Nazareth in Galilee. *Matthew 2:19–23*

Jesus aged 12

The last scene

On the yearly Passover trip, Joseph and Mary lose Jesus and search for three days before finding him in the temple. *Luke 2:41–51*

Key activities

Scripture records no words spoken by Joseph. Many infer that he died before Jesus' public ministry, since he never appears in it, but the text does not say.

1. **Chose mercy.** Before the dream, he planned to end the engagement quietly rather than shame Mary. *Matthew 1:19*
2. **Obeyed the first dream.** He took Mary as his wife and did not come together with her until the child was born. *Matthew 1:20–25*
3. **Named the child.** As the angel said, he called him "JESUS: for he shall save his people from their sins." *Matthew 1:21, 25*
4. **Went to Bethlehem.** He travelled with Mary to the city of David to be taxed, as the emperor's decree required. *Luke 2:4–5*
5. **Kept the Law of Moses.** He and Mary presented Jesus in the temple and offered two birds. *Luke 2:22–24*
6. **Protected his family.** Warned in dreams, he fled to Egypt, returned after Herod's death, and chose Nazareth for safety. *Matthew 2:13–23*
7. **Led the family in worship.** Every year he and Mary went up to Jerusalem for Passover. *Luke 2:41–42*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links. Tradition, not Scripture: some early writings make Joseph an older widower with children.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 7:12–16	Joseph gives Jesus his legal place in David's line
Hosea 11:1	"Out of Egypt," fulfilled in Jesus' return (Matthew 2:15)
Echo: Genesis 37:5–11; 45:5	Like Jacob's Joseph: dreams, Egypt, preserving life

New Testament

Matthew 1:16; Luke 3:23	Both genealogies run through Joseph; they differ
Luke 4:22; John 1:45; 6:42	Jesus called "the son of Joseph"
Matthew 13:55	"Is not this the carpenter's son?"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Joseph decide to do before the angel spoke to him (Matthew 1:19)?
2. *Understand:* Matthew calls Joseph "a just man." How does his plan show both justice and mercy?
3. *Apply:* Joseph obeyed quickly, even at night. What makes it hard for you to act promptly on what you know God wants?
4. *Apply:* Joseph protected those in his care without being noticed. Who could you quietly serve or protect this month?

120 Simeon and Anna

Two faithful people in the temple who had waited long, and knew the Saviour when they saw him.

When Mary and Joseph brought the forty-day-old Jesus to the temple, two people were waiting there. Simeon was a righteous and devout man in Jerusalem. The Holy Ghost had shown him he would not die before he saw the Lord's Christ. Led by the Spirit into the temple that day, he took the baby in his arms and blessed God, for he had seen God's salvation. Anna was an elderly prophetess, a widow for most of her long life, who never left the temple but worshipped with fasting and prayer night and day. She came in at that moment, gave thanks, and told everyone who was waiting for redemption. Together they show what patient, hopeful waiting on God looks like.

At a glance

Names	Simeon, "hearing" or "he has heard"; Anna, a form of Hannah, "grace" or "favour"
Simeon	"just and devout, waiting for the consolation of Israel" (Luke 2:25)
Anna	A prophetess, daughter of Phanuel, of the tribe of Asher (Luke 2:36)
When	c. 6–4 BC, forty days after Jesus' birth
Key place	The temple in Jerusalem
Key people	Mary, mother of Jesus; Joseph of Nazareth
Main passages	Luke 2:22–38

"Lord, now lettest thou thy servant depart in peace, according to thy word: For mine eyes have seen thy salvation."

Luke 2:29–30, KJV

The life of Simeon and Anna

Dates are approximate (BC). Luke gives no age for Simeon, and Anna's age can be read two ways.

Anna's youth

Married, then widowed

Anna lives with her husband seven years after her marriage. Then he dies, and she remains a widow for the rest of her long life. *Luke 2:36–37*

The long years

Waiting in the temple

Anna does not depart from the temple, serving God with fastings and prayers night and day. In Jerusalem, Simeon waits for the consolation of Israel, and the Holy Ghost is upon him. *Luke 2:25, 37*

Earlier

Simeon's promise

The Holy Ghost reveals to Simeon that he will not see death before he has seen the Lord's Christ, God's promised anointed King. *Luke 2:26*

c. 6–4 BC
Forty days

Simeon holds the child

Led by the Spirit into the temple as Jesus is presented, Simeon takes him in his arms and blesses God. He then blesses the parents and warns Mary of sorrow to come. *Luke 2:27–35*

c. 6–4 BC
That same hour

Anna gives thanks

Anna comes in at that very moment. She gives thanks to the Lord and speaks of the child to all who look for redemption in Jerusalem. *Luke 2:38*

Group notes

Key activities

Luke 2:37 says Anna was "a widow of about fourscore and four years." This may mean she was 84, or that she had been a widow for 84 years, which would make her over 100.

1. **Waited with hope.** Simeon looked for the consolation of Israel, trusting the promise God had given him. *Luke 2:25*
2. **Followed the Spirit's leading.** Simeon came "by the Spirit" into the temple at the very time Jesus was brought in. *Luke 2:27*
3. **Recognised the Saviour.** He took the baby in his arms and called him God's salvation, "A light to lighten the Gentiles, and the glory of thy people Israel." *Luke 2:28–32*
4. **Spoke a hard truth.** Simeon told Mary the child was set for the fall and rising again of many in Israel, and "a sword shall pierce through thy own soul also." *Luke 2:34–35*
5. **Worshipped without ceasing.** Anna served God with fastings and prayers night and day. *Luke 2:37*
6. **Told others.** Anna gave thanks and spoke of Jesus to all who were looking for redemption. *Luke 2:38*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Simeon or Anna.

Old Testament

Isaiah 40:1	"Comfort ye, comfort ye my people," the hope Simeon awaited
Isaiah 49:6	"A light to the Gentiles," echoed by Simeon
Echo: 1 Samuel 1:9–18	Hannah, whose name Anna shares, prays at God's house
Echo: Genesis 46:30	Jacob content to die once he has seen Joseph

New Testament

Luke 2:22–38	The only account of them
Luke 24:21	Disciples hoped Jesus would "have redeemed Israel"
1 Timothy 5:5	A widow praying "night and day," as Anna did
Tradition	Simeon as a very old man or a priest; Luke says neither

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What had the Holy Ghost promised Simeon (Luke 2:26)?
2. *Understand:* Simeon calls Jesus a light to the Gentiles and the glory of Israel. Why is it important that Jesus came for both?
3. *Apply:* Anna waited and prayed for decades, and Simeon held on to God's promise. What helps you keep hoping in God while you wait?
4. *Apply:* Anna told others about Jesus as soon as she met him. Who is one person you could tell about what God has done for you?

121 The Magi

Wise men from the east who followed a star, worshipped the child Jesus, and went home another way.

Matthew tells of "wise men from the east" who arrived in Jerusalem asking for the newborn King of the Jews. They had seen his star and come to worship him, and their question alarmed Herod. Micah's prophecy pointed them to Bethlehem, where they bowed down and gave the child gold, frankincense and myrrh. Warned in a dream, they went home another way. Matthew does not say how many there were, name them, or call them kings; those details are later tradition. Foreigners were among the first to worship Jesus, while Jerusalem's scholars are not said to have gone.

At a glance

Name	Greek *magoi*, KJV "wise men"; source of our word "magic"
Who they were	Probably star scholars; Matthew says only "from the east"
How many	Not stated; the idea of three comes from the three gifts
When	c. 6–4 BC, some time after the birth, under Herod the Great
Key places	"The east," Jerusalem, Bethlehem
Key people	Herod the Great; Mary, mother of Jesus; the chief priests and scribes
Main passage	Matthew 2:1–12

"Where is he that is born King of the Jews? for we have seen his star in the east, and are come to worship him."

Matthew 2:2, KJV

The life of The Magi

Dates are approximate (BC). Herod's order about boys "two years old and under" suggests the visit came some months after the birth.

In the east

They see the star

The wise men see a star they link to the birth of the King of the Jews. They set out on a long journey to find and worship him. *Matthew 2:1–2*

c. 6–4 BC
Jerusalem

They ask for the King

They arrive in Jerusalem asking where the newborn King is. Herod is troubled, and all Jerusalem with him. The chief priests and scribes point to Bethlehem from the prophet Micah. *Matthew 2:1–6; Micah 5:2*

c. 6–4 BC
Before Herod

A secret meeting

Herod calls the wise men privately and finds out exactly when the star appeared. He sends them to Bethlehem, asking them to report back so that he may worship too. *Matthew 2:7–8*

c. 6–4 BC
Bethlehem

They worship the child

The star goes before them and stops over the place. Rejoicing greatly, they enter the house, fall down and worship Jesus, and open their gifts. *Matthew 2:9–11*

c. 6–4 BC
The journey home

Another way

Warned by God in a dream not to return to Herod, they depart into their own country by another way. *Matthew 2:12*

Group notes

Key activities

Christians and scholars differ on what the star was: a miracle, a comet, a new star, or a meeting of planets, such as a conjunction of Jupiter and Saturn in 7 BC. Matthew does not explain it.

1. **Watched and responded.** They noticed a sign in the heavens and acted on it, travelling far to find the King. *Matthew 2:1–2*
2. **Asked openly.** They came to the capital and asked plainly for the newborn King of the Jews. *Matthew 2:2*
3. **Were guided by Scripture.** The prophet's words about Bethlehem showed them where to go next. *Matthew 2:4–6, 9*
4. **Rejoiced.** When they saw the star again, "they rejoiced with exceeding great joy." *Matthew 2:10*
5. **Worshipped the child.** They found him with Mary his mother, fell down and worshipped him. *Matthew 2:11*
6. **Gave costly gifts.** They "presented unto him gifts; gold, and frankincense, and myrrh." *Matthew 2:11*
7. **Obeyed God's warning.** They did not return to Herod but went home another way. *Matthew 2:12*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name the Magi.

Old Testament

Micah 5:2	A ruler from Bethlehem, quoted to Herod (Matthew 2:6)
Numbers 24:17	"A Star out of Jacob," which many link with the star
Isaiah 60:3, 6; Psalm 72:10–11	Kings bring gold and incense; shaped the "kings" idea

New Testament

Matthew 2:1–16	The only account of them
Acts 8:9; 13:6–8	The same word family for Simon and Elymas the sorcerers
Tradition	Names Caspar, Melchior and Balthasar (c. 6th century) and Epiphany; not Scripture

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What three gifts did the wise men bring (Matthew 2:11)?
2. *Understand:* The wise men travelled far to worship, while the scribes in Jerusalem knew the prophecy but are not said to have gone. What does this contrast suggest?
3. *Apply:* The wise men gave their best to Jesus. What could you offer him this week, in time, money or talent?
4. *Apply:* They went home "another way." How has meeting Jesus changed the direction of your life?

122 Herod the Great

The brilliant, ruthless king who rebuilt the temple and tried to kill the newborn King of the Jews.

Herod the Great ruled Judaea for Rome for more than thirty years. A gifted builder and shrewd politician, he rebuilt the temple on a grand scale. He was also deeply suspicious and cruel. The Jewish historian Josephus records that he executed one of his wives and three of his own sons when he feared plots against his throne. So when wise men arrived asking for the newborn "King of the Jews," Herod was troubled. He pretended he wanted to worship the child, then ordered the killing of Bethlehem's baby boys. Soon afterward he died. Herod's story shows the fear of a man clinging to power, set against the quiet arrival of the true King.

At a glance

Name	Herod, called "the Great" by later writers to set him apart from his sons
Family	From Idumea (Edom), son of Antipater. Sons included Archelaus, Herod Antipas and Philip
Reign	King of Judaea under Rome, 37–4 BC; named king by the Roman Senate in 40 BC
Death	c. 4 BC, at Jericho, after a painful illness (Josephus)
Building	The Jerusalem temple, Caesarea, Masada, the Herodium and more
Key people	The Magi; Joseph of Nazareth; Mary, mother of Jesus
Main passages	Matthew 2:1–22; Luke 1:5

"When Herod the king had heard these things, he was troubled, and all Jerusalem with him."

Matthew 2:3, KJV

The life of Herod the Great

Dates are approximate (BC). Most scholars date his death to 4 BC. A minority prefer 1 BC.

40 BC
Named king

Rome's choice

With help from Mark Antony and Octavian, the Roman Senate declares Herod king of Judaea. He has to fight for three years to take his kingdom. *Josephus, Antiquities 14*

37 BC
Jerusalem taken

Reign begins

With Roman troops, Herod captures Jerusalem and becomes king in fact. He marries Mariamne, from the old Jewish royal family, to strengthen his claim. *Josephus, Antiquities 14*

c. 20/19 BC
18th year

Temple rebuilding begins

Herod starts a vast rebuilding of the temple and its courts. Work continues long after his death; in Jesus' day it had been "forty and six years" in building. *John 2:20; Josephus, Antiquities 15*

c. 6–4 BC
Wise men arrive

Troubled

Magi ask for the newborn King of the Jews. Herod gathers the chief priests and scribes, meets the wise men secretly, and sends them to Bethlehem. *Matthew 2:1–8*

c. 6–4 BC
Bethlehem

The killing of the boys

Seeing that the wise men have mocked him by not returning, Herod in great anger orders every boy two years old and under in and around Bethlehem killed. *Matthew 2:16–18*

c. 4 BC
At Jericho

Death

Herod dies, and an angel tells Joseph in Egypt that those who sought the child's life are dead. His kingdom is divided among his sons. *Matthew 2:19–22; Josephus, Antiquities 17*

Key activities

Only Matthew records the killing of the infants. Bethlehem was a small town, so many scholars think the number of boys was small. Josephus does not mention it, though it fits the cruelty he describes.

1. **Built on a grand scale.** He rebuilt the temple, whose stones impressed even Jesus' disciples. *Mark 13:1; John 2:20*
2. **Was troubled by a rival.** News of a born King of the Jews alarmed him, and all Jerusalem with him. *Matthew 2:2–3*
3. **Consulted Scripture for the wrong reason.** He asked the chief priests and scribes where the Christ would be born, planning to find him. *Matthew 2:4–6*
4. **Deceived the wise men.** He said, "that I may come and worship him also." *Matthew 2:7–8*
5. **Killed the innocent.** In anger he had the boys of Bethlehem "from two years old and under" killed. *Matthew 2:16*
6. **Failed to stop God's plan.** Joseph had already fled with the child to Egypt, and Herod died soon after. *Matthew 2:13–15, 19–20*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Herod the Great.

Old Testament

Jeremiah 31:15	"Rachel weeping," fulfilled in Bethlehem (Matthew 2:17–18)
Micah 5:2	The prophecy the scribes quoted to Herod
Echo: Exodus 1:22–2:10	Pharaoh kills baby boys, but Moses is saved
Echo: Psalm 2:2	Rulers set "against the LORD, and against his anointed"

New Testament

Matthew 2:1–22	The main account
Luke 1:5	"In the days of Herod, the king of Judaea"
Luke 3:1; Mark 6:14–29	His sons; Antipas killed John the Baptist
Acts 12:1–23	His grandson Agrippa I kills James and is struck down
Tradition	Saying attributed to Augustus: better Herod's pig than his son; unconfirmed

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Herod react when he heard about the newborn King (Matthew 2:3, 16)?
2. *Understand:* Herod knew the Scriptures' answer but used it to harm, not to worship. How can people know facts about God yet oppose him?
3. *Apply:* Herod feared losing control. Where are you tempted to hold on to control rather than trust God?
4. *Apply:* The families of Bethlehem suffered real loss. How can your group care for someone who is grieving now?

123 John the Baptist

The voice in the wilderness who prepared the way for Jesus and pointed to him as the Lamb of God.

John was the son of the aged priest Zechariah and Elizabeth, born in answer to prayer. He appeared by the Jordan as a prophet in the style of Elijah, dressed in camel's hair. Crowds came to hear his blunt call to repent and be baptized. John baptized Jesus and then pointed his own followers to him. He never tried to keep the spotlight: "He must increase, but I must decrease." His courage cost him his life when he rebuked Herod Antipas for taking his brother's wife. Jesus said no one born of women was greater than John.

At a glance

Name	John, from Hebrew *Yochanan*, "the Lord is gracious"
Family	Son of Zechariah and Elizabeth; relative of Jesus (Luke 1:36)
When	Born c. 6–4 BC; ministry from c. AD 28–29 (Luke 3:1–3)
Key places	Wilderness of Judaea; the Jordan; Bethabara (John 1:28)
Key people	Jesus, Herod Antipas, Andrew, the Pharisees and Sadducees
Death	Beheaded by order of Herod Antipas (Matthew 14:10)
Role	Forerunner of the Christ (Isaiah 40:3; Malachi 3:1)
New Testament	All four Gospels and Acts

"Behold the Lamb of God, which taketh away the sin of the world."

John 1:29, KJV

The life of John the Baptist

Dates are approximate (BC or AD). Luke dates the start of John's ministry to the fifteenth year of Tiberius, c. AD 28–29.

c. 7–5 BC
Before birth

Promised

Gabriel tells Zechariah his son will go before the Lord in the spirit and power of Elijah. *Luke 1:13–17*

c. 6–4 BC
Eighth day

Named John

His parents insist on the name John, and the hand of the Lord is with him. *Luke 1:57–66*

Youth

In the deserts

John grows strong in spirit and lives in the deserts until he appears to Israel. *Luke 1:80*

c. AD 28–29
15th year of Tiberius

The word of God comes

John preaches a baptism of repentance around the Jordan, and crowds come. *Luke 3:1–18; Matthew 3:1–12*

c. AD 28–29
At the Jordan

Baptizes Jesus

John protests but obeys. The Spirit descends like a dove, and a voice speaks from heaven. *Matthew 3:13–17*

Soon after

Points to the Lamb

He calls Jesus the Lamb of God, and two of his disciples, one of them Andrew, follow Jesus. *John 1:19–40*

Early in Jesus' ministry

Imprisoned

John rebukes Herod Antipas for taking Herodias, his brother's wife, and is imprisoned. *Luke 3:19–20; Matthew 11:2–6*

During Jesus' ministry

Beheaded

Prompted by Herodias, her daughter asks for John's head, and Herod grants it. *Matthew 14:3–12; Mark 6:17–29*

Key activities

Scholars debate whether John had links with the Essenes, a strict Jewish group in the Judaean desert. Scripture does not say.

1. **Leapt for joy before birth.** When Mary greeted Elizabeth, the unborn John leapt in the womb. *Luke 1:41, 44*
2. **Lived simply.** He wore camel's hair and a leather belt and ate locusts and wild honey. *Matthew 3:4*
3. **Called for repentance.** "Repent ye: for the kingdom of heaven is at hand." *Matthew 3:2*
4. **Baptized many.** People from Jerusalem, Judaea and the Jordan region were baptized by him, confessing their sins. *Matthew 3:5–6*
5. **Challenged the proud.** He called the Pharisees and Sadducees a "generation of vipers" and told them to bear fruit worthy of repentance. *Matthew 3:7–10*
6. **Gave practical advice.** Share coats and food; tax collectors, take no more than is due; soldiers, do no violence and be content with wages. *Luke 3:10–14*
7. **Refused the spotlight.** He said he was not the Christ and was unworthy to untie his shoes. *John 1:19–27*
8. **Baptized Jesus.** He said, "I have need to be baptized of thee," but did as Jesus asked. *Matthew 3:13–15*
9. **Pointed to the Lamb.** He twice called Jesus "the Lamb of God," and let his disciples leave to follow him. *John 1:29, 35–37*
10. **Rejoiced to decrease.** He called himself the friend of the bridegroom: "He must increase, but I must decrease." *John 3:26–30*
11. **Rebuked a king.** He told Herod, "It is not lawful for thee to have her." *Matthew 14:3–4*
12. **Brought his doubt to Jesus.** From prison he asked, "Art thou he that should come, or do we look for another?" *Matthew 11:2–6*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name John.

Old Testament

Isaiah 40:3	"The voice of him that crieth in the wilderness," applied to John
Malachi 3:1; 4:5–6	The messenger and Elijah; Jesus says John is "Elias" (Matt 11:14)
Echo: 2 Kings 1:8; Judges 13:4–5	Elijah's leather belt; Samson set apart from birth

New Testament

Matthew 11:7–19; Luke 7:24–35	Jesus praises John as more than a prophet
John 1:6–8	Sent "to bear witness of the Light"
John 1:21	Not Elijah in person, but in his "spirit and power" (Luke 1:17)
Acts 13:24–25; 19:1–7	Believers in Ephesus who knew only John's baptism
Josephus, Antiquities 18	Also records John's preaching and death

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did John tell the crowds, tax collectors and soldiers (Luke 3:10–14)?
2. *Understand:* Why might John later send to ask if Jesus was the one (Matthew 11:2–6)?
3. *Apply:* "He must increase, but I must decrease." What credit could you hand to Jesus this week?
4. *Apply:* What concrete change would repentance mean in your work, money or relationships?

124 Jesus of Nazareth

The Word made flesh, who lived among us, died for sinners, rose again, and reigns as Lord.

Jesus of Nazareth stands at the centre of the whole Bible, which looks forward to him, back to him, and ahead to his return. Born to Mary in Bethlehem and raised in Nazareth, at about thirty he began to preach that the kingdom of God was at hand. For a few short years he taught, healed, welcomed outsiders, forgave sins and trained twelve disciples. Pontius Pilate had him crucified in Jerusalem. On the third day he rose, and after forty days he ascended. Christians confess him as fully God and fully human, the Saviour of the world.

At a glance

Name	Greek *Iesous*, Hebrew *Yeshua*, "the Lord saves" (Matt 1:21)
Titles	Christ ("anointed one"), Son of God, Son of man, Lord, Emmanuel
Family	Son of Mary; legal son of Joseph; of David's line (Matthew 1:1)
When	Born c. 6–4 BC; crucified c. AD 30 (some prefer AD 33)
Key places	Bethlehem, Nazareth, Capernaum and Galilee, Jerusalem
Key people	John the Baptist, the Twelve, Mary Magdalene, Caiaphas, Pontius Pilate
Main passages	Matthew, Mark, Luke and John; Acts 1:1–11

"And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth."

John 1:14, KJV

The life of Jesus of Nazareth

Dates approximate. John mentions at least three Passovers, so many think the ministry lasted about three years.

c. 6–4 BC
Bethlehem

Born of Mary

Conceived by the Holy Ghost, he is laid in a manger; shepherds and wise men come to worship. *Matthew 1:18–2:12; Luke 2:1–38*

Age 12

In the temple

He stays behind, asking the teachers questions, about his Father's business. *Luke 2:41–52*

c. AD 28–29
About 30

Baptized and tempted

John baptizes him; then he answers the devil's temptations with Scripture. *Matthew 3:13–4:11; Luke 3:21–23*

Early ministry

Galilee

He preaches that the kingdom is at hand, calls fishermen, and heals many. *John 2:1–11; Mark 1:14–39*

The busy years

Crowds and conflict

He chooses twelve, teaches in parables and eats with sinners; leaders plot against him. *Mark 3:1–19; 6:30–44; Luke 15:1–2*

Caesarea Philippi

Confession and glory

Peter confesses him as the Christ; days later he is transfigured. *Matthew 16:13–17:9*

c. AD 30 or 33
Passover week

The cross

After the Last Supper and Gethsemane, he is tried, crucified and buried. *Matthew 21:1–27:66; John 18–19*

The third day to the fortieth

Risen and ascended

He appears to Mary Magdalene, the apostles and five hundred, then ascends. *Luke 24; John 20–21; Acts 1:3–12; 1 Corinthians 15:3–8*

Key activities

The Gospels are four portraits, not a diary, and sometimes order events differently. These are grouped by theme.

1. **Proclaimed the kingdom.** "The kingdom of God is at hand: repent ye, and believe the gospel." *Mark 1:14–15*
2. **Called disciples.** He called fishermen and a tax collector, and chose twelve to be sent out. *Mark 1:16–20; 2:14; 3:13–19*
3. **Taught with authority.** He taught love for enemies, secret prayer and trust in the Father. *Matthew 5–7*
4. **Told parables.** The sower, the good Samaritan and the lost son show what God's kingdom is like. *Matthew 13:1–23; Luke 10:25–37; 15:11–32*
5. **Healed and showed his power.** He healed the sick, cast out demons, calmed a storm and fed five thousand. *Mark 1:32–34; 4:35–41; John 6:1–14*
6. **Forgave sins.** He forgave a paralysed man, then healed him to show his authority. *Mark 2:1–12*
7. **Welcomed outsiders.** He came "to seek and to save that which was lost." *Luke 15:1–2; John 4:7–26; Luke 19:1–10*
8. **Raised the dead.** "I am the resurrection, and the life." *Mark 5:35–43; John 11:25, 38–44*
9. **Served his disciples.** He washed their feet and gave them the bread and the cup. *John 13:1–17; Luke 22:14–20*
10. **Surrendered in prayer.** "nevertheless not my will, but thine, be done." *Luke 22:39–46*
11. **Gave his life.** "Father, forgive them; for they know not what they do." *Luke 23:33–46; John 19:28–30*
12. **Sent his followers.** "Lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world." *Matthew 28:18–20*

Across Scripture

Key passages only (Luke 24:27). 25 December and the holy sites are later tradition.

Old Testament

Genesis 3:15	The woman's seed; many call it the first gospel promise
Genesis 12:3; 2 Samuel 7:12–16	"The son of David, the son of Abraham"
Isaiah 9:6–7; 53; Micah 5:2	The child, the wounded servant, the Bethlehem ruler
Psalm 22:1; 110:1	Quoted by Jesus on the cross and of David's Lord
Daniel 7:13–14	One "like the Son of man" receives the kingdom
Echo: 1 Corinthians 15:45; 5:7	The last Adam and our Passover

New Testament

Matthew – John; Acts 1:1–11	His life, death, rising and ascension
John 1:1–14; Philippians 2:5–11	The Word made flesh, in "the form of a servant"
1 Corinthians 15:3–8	Died, buried, rose, appeared: an early summary
Revelation 22:20	"Even so, come, Lord Jesus"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Peter answer, "But whom say ye that I am?" (Matthew 16:15–16)?
2. *Understand:* How does Mark 10:45 sum up Jesus' life?
3. *Apply:* Jesus welcomed people others avoided. Who could you welcome this week?
4. *Apply:* How would you answer "whom say ye that I am?" today, and how will it shape your week?

125 Peter

The fisherman who fell hard, was restored, and became a rock for the early church.

Simon was a Galilean fisherman when his brother Andrew brought him to Jesus, who named him Cephas, or Peter, "a stone." Peter speaks first, acts fast, and sometimes gets it badly wrong. He confessed Jesus as the Christ, then tried to talk him out of the cross. He promised to die with him, then denied him three times. Yet the risen Jesus restored him, and in Acts Peter preaches at Pentecost, heals in Jesus' name, and opens the gospel to the Gentiles. Two New Testament letters bear his name.

At a glance

Name	Simon; Cephas (Aramaic), Peter (Greek), "a stone" (John 1:42)
Family	Son of Jonas; brother of Andrew; married (Mark 1:30)
Home	Bethsaida; later Capernaum (John 1:44; Mark 1:21, 29)
Work	Fisherman, partner of James and John (Luke 5:10)
When	With Jesus c. AD 28–30; leader in Jerusalem into the AD 40s
Key people	Andrew, James, John, Cornelius, Paul
Main passages	Matthew 16; Luke 5; 22; John 21; Acts 1–15; 1–2 Peter
Death	Not in Scripture; tradition says Rome, c. AD 64–67

"And Simon Peter answered and said, Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God."

Matthew 16:16, KJV

The life of Peter

Dates approximate (AD); this study dates the crucifixion c. AD 30 (some prefer AD 33).

c. AD 27–28 — *By the Jordan*

Meets Jesus

Andrew brings his brother Simon to Jesus, who names him Cephas, a stone. *John 1:40–42*

c. AD 28 — *Sea of Galilee*

Leaves his nets

After a net-breaking catch at Jesus' word, he leaves everything to follow him. *Luke 5:1–11*

c. AD 29 — *Caesarea Philippi*

Confesses the Christ

Peter calls Jesus the Christ, then rebukes him for speaking of the cross. *Matthew 16:13–23*

c. AD 30 — *The high priest's courtyard*

Denies Jesus

Peter three times denies knowing him, then goes out and weeps bitterly. *Luke 22:31–34, 54–62*

c. AD 30 — *By the sea*

Restored by the risen Lord

Three times Jesus asks, "Lovest thou me?" and charges him to feed his flock. *John 21:1–19*

c. AD 30 — *Jerusalem*

Preaches at Pentecost

Filled with the Spirit, he preaches Christ; about three thousand are baptized. *Acts 2:1–41*

AD 44 — *Jerusalem*

Freed from prison

After Herod Agrippa I kills James, an angel leads the jailed Peter out. *Acts 12:1–17*

c. AD 49 — *Jerusalem*

Speaks at the council

Peter says God saves Gentiles and Jews alike by grace. *Acts 15:6–11*

Group notes

Key activities

After Acts 15 Peter drops out of the narrative; Scripture does not record his later travels or death.

1. **Left his nets.** "Depart from me; for I am a sinful man, O Lord." *Luke 5:4–11*
2. **Walked on the water.** Sinking in the wind, he cried, "Lord, save me." *Matthew 14:28–31*
3. **Spoke for the Twelve.** "Lord, to whom shall we go? thou hast the words of eternal life." *John 6:66–69*
4. **Confessed and then stumbled.** He rebuked Jesus for speaking of suffering: "Get thee behind me, Satan." *Matthew 16:16–23*
5. **Saw the Transfiguration.** He offered to build three tabernacles, not knowing what to say. *Mark 9:2–8*
6. **Drew his sword.** He cut off Malchus's ear, and Jesus told him to put the sword away. *John 18:10–11*
7. **Denied his Lord.** Three times in one night he said he did not know Jesus. *Mark 14:66–72*
8. **Was restored.** The risen Jesus appeared to him and later gave him a threefold charge to feed his sheep. *Luke 24:34; John 21:15–17*
9. **Preached and healed.** At the temple gate he told a lame man, "Silver and gold have I none," and raised him up in Jesus' name. *Acts 3:1–16*
10. **Stood before the council.** With the apostles he answered, "We ought to obey God rather than men." *Acts 4:1–20; 5:29*
11. **Welcomed Cornelius.** A vision at Joppa taught him that God is no respecter of persons, and he had a Roman centurion's household baptized. *Acts 10:1–48; 11:1–18*
12. **Wrote to scattered believers.** The letter of 1 Peter encourages Christians facing suffering to hope and to do good. *1 Peter 1:1–9*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Tradition: martyred in Rome under Nero, c. AD 64–67 (hinted in John 21:18–19); the upside-down cross is a later story.

Old Testament

Joel 2:28–32	Quoted at Pentecost (Acts 2:16–21)
Psalm 16:8–11; 110:1	Preached of Jesus' resurrection (Acts 2:25–35)
Psalm 118:22; Isaiah 28:16	The rejected corner stone (1 Peter 2:6–7)
Echo: Jonah 1:3	Jonah fled Gentiles from Joppa; Peter is sent from there

New Testament

Matthew 16:18	"Upon this rock": Peter, his confession, or Christ? Views differ
1 Corinthians 15:5	The risen Lord "was seen of Cephas"
Galatians 1:18; 2:7–14	Paul visits him, and later rebukes him at Antioch
1 Peter 5:1, 13; 2 Peter 1:16–18	"Babylon" often read as Rome; 2 Peter's authorship debated

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Jesus ask Peter three times by the sea (John 21:15–17)?
2. *Understand:* Why was the cross so hard for Peter to accept?
3. *Apply:* Peter wept but did not stay away. What helps you come back to God after failing?
4. *Apply:* God shows no partiality. Who outside your usual circle could you welcome this week?

126 Andrew

The brother who kept bringing people to Jesus.

Andrew was a fisherman from Bethsaida and the brother of Simon Peter. He first followed John the Baptist, and he was one of the first two men to follow Jesus. His first act as a disciple was to find his brother and say, "We have found the Messias." That pattern marks nearly every scene where John's Gospel names him. He brings Peter to Jesus. He brings a boy with five loaves to Jesus. He brings a question from some Greeks to Jesus. Andrew never preaches a sermon in Scripture, and he often stands in his famous brother's shadow. Yet his quiet habit of introducing others to Christ has made him a model for ordinary believers.

At a glance

Name	Greek *Andreas*, "manly"
Family	Brother of Simon Peter; son of Jonas (John 1:40–42)
Home	Bethsaida; later shared a house with Peter in Capernaum (John 1:44; Mark 1:29)
Work	Fisherman on the Sea of Galilee (Mark 1:16)
First teacher	A disciple of John the Baptist (John 1:35–40)
Main passages	John 1:35–42; 6:5–13; 12:20–22; Mark 1:16–18; 13:3
Later life	Not recorded in Scripture; see Tradition on page 4

"He first findeth his own brother Simon, and saith unto him, We have found the Messias, which is, being interpreted, the Christ."

John 1:41, KJV

The life of Andrew

Dates are approximate (AD). Jesus' ministry is dated c. AD 27/28–30 in this study. Scripture does not give Andrew's age.

c. AD 27–28
Beyond Jordan

Follows Jesus

Andrew hears John the Baptist call Jesus "the Lamb of God." He and another disciple follow Jesus and spend the rest of the day with him. *John 1:35–40*

c. AD 27–28
Beyond Jordan

Brings his brother

He finds Simon and tells him they have found the Messiah. Then he brings Simon to Jesus, who names him Cephas. *John 1:41–42*

c. AD 28
Sea of Galilee

Called to fish for men

Jesus sees Simon and Andrew casting a net into the sea and calls them to follow him. They leave their nets at once. *Mark 1:16–18*

c. AD 29
Near the Sea of Galilee

Finds the loaves

Before Jesus feeds the five thousand, Andrew points out a boy with five barley loaves and two small fishes, though he wonders what good they are. *John 6:5–13*

c. AD 30
Jerusalem

Brings the Greeks

At the last Passover some Greeks ask Philip to see Jesus. Philip tells Andrew, and together they tell Jesus. *John 12:20–22*

Group notes

Key activities

Andrew is named only about a dozen times in the New Testament, most often in John's Gospel. The other disciple with him in John 1:35–40 is not named; many think it was John the apostle.

1. **Followed the Lamb of God.** When his teacher pointed to Jesus, Andrew followed and asked where he was staying. *John 1:37–39*
2. **Brought his brother.** He went first to Simon with the news that the Messiah had come. *John 1:40–42*
3. **Left his nets.** He answered Jesus' call to become a fisher of men. *Mark 1:16–18; Matthew 4:18–20*
4. **Was chosen as an apostle.** He is named among the Twelve in every list. *Matthew 10:2; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:14; Acts 1:13*
5. **Asked about the future.** With Peter, James and John he asked Jesus privately on the Mount of Olives when the temple would fall. *Mark 13:3–4*
6. **Offered what little there was.** He brought a boy's lunch to Jesus, asking, "But what are they among so many?" *John 6:8–9*
7. **Opened the way for Greeks.** He helped carry the request of some Greek visitors to Jesus. *John 12:20–22*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Andrew.

Old Testament

Echo: 2 Samuel 7:12–16	The anointed king Andrew hoped for as "the Messias"
Echo: 2 Kings 4:42–44	Elisha feeds a hundred with twenty barley loaves

New Testament

John 1:35–42	Andrew follows Jesus and brings Simon
Mark 1:16–18, 29; Matthew 4:18–20	Called with Peter; Jesus visits their home
Mark 13:3	With the inner three on the Mount of Olives
John 6:8–9; 12:22	He brings the loaves and the Greeks
Acts 1:13	In the upper room; his last mention in Scripture
Tradition	Preached by the Black Sea and Greece, crucified at Patras; the X-shaped cross is much later

For discussion

1. *Observe:* Who did Andrew bring to Jesus in John 1, John 6 and John 12?
2. *Understand:* Andrew wondered what five loaves could do "among so many." What does Jesus' answer teach about small offerings?
3. *Apply:* Andrew started with his own brother. Who in your family or circle could you invite to "come and see"?
4. *Apply:* What small gift, skill or hour could you hand to Jesus this week, even if it seems too little?

127 James, son of Zebedee

A "son of thunder" who asked for glory and was given a cup of suffering.

James was a Galilean fisherman, the son of Zebedee and brother of John. With Peter and John he formed Jesus' inner circle, seeing a dead girl raised and Jesus transfigured. Jesus nicknamed the brothers "the sons of thunder." They once wanted to call down fire on a Samaritan village, and they asked for the best seats in Christ's kingdom. Jesus told them they would drink his cup, and for James that came true first. He is the only one of the Twelve whose martyrdom the New Testament records, killed by Herod Agrippa I in AD 44.

At a glance

Name	Greek *Iakobos*, from the Hebrew Jacob
Family	Son of Zebedee; brother of John the apostle (Mark 1:19)
Mother	"The mother of Zebedee's children"; probably Salome
Work	Fisherman in a family business, partner of Simon (Luke 5:10)
Nickname	Boanerges, "the sons of thunder" (Mark 3:17)
Death	Killed with the sword by Herod, AD 44 (Acts 12:1–2)
Not the same as	James, son of Alphaeus, or James, brother of Jesus

> *"Now about that time Herod the king stretched forth his hands to vex certain of the church. And he killed James the brother of John with the sword."*
>
> Acts 12:1–2, KJV

The life of James, son of Zebedee

Dates are approximate (AD). Jesus' ministry is dated c. AD 27/28–30 in this study. The date of James's death is firm, because Herod Agrippa I died in AD 44.

c. AD 28
Sea of Galilee

Called from the boat

Jesus finds James and John mending nets with their father Zebedee. They leave their father in the ship with the hired servants and follow Jesus. *Mark 1:19–20*

c. AD 28
On a mountain

Chosen and named

Jesus appoints the Twelve and gives James and his brother the name Boanerges, "the sons of thunder." *Mark 3:13–17*

c. AD 29
On a high mountain

Sees the glory

James, Peter and John watch Jesus transfigured, his clothes shining, as Moses and Elijah talk with him. *Mark 9:2–8*

c. AD 30
Road to Jerusalem

Asks for a throne

James and John ask to sit at Jesus' right and left hand in his glory. Jesus asks if they can drink his cup, and they say they can. *Mark 10:35–40*

AD 44
Jerusalem

Killed by Herod

King Herod Agrippa I turns against the church and has James put to death with the sword, the first of the Twelve to die for Christ. *Acts 12:1–2*

Group notes

Key activities

Matthew says the mother of James and John made the request for seats of glory, while Mark has the brothers ask. Both agree that Jesus answered the brothers directly.

1. **Left his father and his nets.** He walked away from the family business to follow Jesus. *Mark 1:19–20; Matthew 4:21–22*
2. **Saw a dead girl raised.** Jesus let only Peter, James and John go in with Jairus's family. *Mark 5:37–43*
3. **Saw the Transfiguration.** He was one of three witnesses on the mountain. *Mark 9:2–8*
4. **Wanted fire from heaven.** When a Samaritan village refused Jesus, James and John asked if they should call down fire "even as Elias did." Jesus rebuked them. *Luke 9:51–56*
5. **Asked for glory.** He and John asked for the places of honor, and Jesus answered, "Ye know not what ye ask." *Mark 10:35–45; Matthew 20:20–28*
6. **Asked about the end.** With Peter, John and Andrew he asked Jesus privately about the temple's fall. *Mark 13:3–4*
7. **Was called to watch in Gethsemane.** Jesus took the three aside as he began to be sore amazed and very heavy, but they fell asleep. *Mark 14:32–41*
8. **Drank the cup.** He became the first apostle to die as a martyr. *Acts 12:1–2*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Tradition, not Scripture: his accuser confessed Christ and died with him (Eusebius); a medieval story links him to Spain and Santiago de Compostela.

Old Testament

Echo: 2 Kings 1:9–12	Elijah's fire, which the brothers wanted to copy
Echo: Isaiah 51:17	"The cup" of God's fury, which Jesus drinks himself

New Testament

Matthew 10:2; Mark 3:17; Acts 1:13	Among the first names of the Twelve
Mark 5:37; 9:2; 14:33	One of the three closest to Jesus
Mark 10:35–45	"To give his life a ransom for many"
John 21:2	"The sons of Zebedee" meet the risen Jesus
Acts 12:1–2	His death, told in one verse

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Jesus ask James and John, and how did they answer (Mark 10:38–39)?
2. *Understand:* What does Jesus' rebuke about fire show about his kingdom?
3. *Apply:* Where are you tempted to seek recognition instead of service?
4. *Apply:* James's death is told in one verse. What unseen faithfulness is God asking of you?

128 John the apostle

A "son of thunder" who became the apostle of love.

John was a Galilean fisherman, the son of Zebedee and brother of James, and one of Jesus' inner circle. In the first three Gospels he is fiery: he stops a stranger casting out devils and wants fire on a Samaritan village. In Acts he stands beside Peter, unafraid before the council, and Paul calls him a pillar of the church. Tradition identifies him with "the disciple whom Jesus loved" and credits him with a Gospel, three letters and Revelation. These are still discussed, but his story shows zeal reshaped by love.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yochanan*, "the LORD is gracious"
Family	Son of Zebedee; brother of James; mother probably Salome
Work	Fisherman, partner of Simon Peter (Luke 5:10)
Nickname	With James, Boanerges, "the sons of thunder" (Mark 3:17)
Key people	Peter; James; Mary, mother of Jesus; Paul
Known as	Traditionally "the disciple whom Jesus loved" (John 13:23)
Writings	Traditionally John, 1–3 John, Revelation; debated
Later life	Tradition says he lived to old age at Ephesus

> *"Now when they saw the boldness of Peter and John, and perceived that they were unlearned and ignorant men, they marvelled; and they took knowledge of them, that they had been with Jesus."*
>
> Acts 4:13, KJV

The life of John the apostle

Dates are approximate (AD). The crucifixion is dated AD 30 or AD 33; this study uses c. AD 30. The Patmos date follows tradition; some prefer c. AD 68.

c. AD 28
Sea of Galilee

Called with his brother

Jesus calls James and John from mending nets, and they leave Zebedee to follow him. *Mark 1:19–20*

c. AD 29
On a high mountain

Sees the Transfiguration

John, Peter and James see Jesus shine with glory and hear the Father's voice from the cloud. *Mark 9:2–8*

c. AD 30
Road to Jerusalem

Asks for glory

John and James ask for the seats at Jesus' right and left. Jesus teaches that the greatest must be the servant of all. *Mark 10:35–45*

c. AD 30
Jerusalem

At the supper and the cross

Peter and John prepare the Passover. At the cross Jesus entrusts his mother to "the disciple whom Jesus loved," traditionally John. *Luke 22:8–13; John 19:25–27*

c. AD 30
The empty tomb

Runs and believes

Told the tomb is empty, Peter and the beloved disciple run to it. The other disciple arrives first, goes in after Peter, sees, and believes. *John 20:1–10*

Soon after Pentecost
Jerusalem

Arrested with Peter

After the healing of a lame man at the temple gate, Peter and John are jailed and questioned. They refuse to stop speaking about Jesus. *Acts 3:1–4:22*

c. AD 46–49
Jerusalem

Counted a pillar

Paul names James, Cephas and John as pillars of the church, who give him and Barnabas the right hand of fellowship. *Galatians 2:9*

c. AD 95
Patmos

Sees the Revelation

A servant of Christ named John, exiled on the island of Patmos, receives visions for seven churches in Asia. Tradition identifies him as the apostle. *Revelation 1:1, 9–11*

Key activities

Several scenes below involve "the disciple whom Jesus loved." John's Gospel never names him. Since the second century most Christians have identified him as John; some scholars suggest another follower, such as Lazarus or an unknown Jerusalem disciple.

1. **Left his nets.** He and James left their father and the boat to follow Jesus. *Mark 1:19–20*
2. **Was named a son of thunder.** Jesus gave the brothers the name Boanerges. *Mark 3:17*
3. **Forbade a stranger.** He stopped one casting out devils in Jesus' name; Jesus said, "Forbid him not." *Luke 9:49–50*
4. **Wanted fire from heaven.** He and James wanted to call down fire on a Samaritan village, and Jesus rebuked them. *Luke 9:51–56*
5. **Asked for honor.** He and James asked for the best seats in the kingdom. *Mark 10:35–41*
6. **Prepared the Passover.** Jesus sent Peter and John to make ready the last supper. *Luke 22:8–13*
7. **Leaned on Jesus at supper.** The beloved disciple, reclining next to Jesus, asked who would betray him. *John 13:23–26*
8. **Took Mary home.** From the cross Jesus said to the disciple, "Behold thy mother!" and he took her into his home. *John 19:26–27*
9. **Recognized the risen Lord.** At the miraculous catch the beloved disciple said to Peter, "It is the Lord." *John 21:4–7*
10. **Spoke boldly.** Ordered to be silent, Peter and John said they could not stop speaking what they had seen and heard. *Acts 4:13–20*
11. **Went to Samaria.** Once eager for fire on Samaritans, he prayed there for believers to receive the Spirit. *Acts 8:14–17*
12. **Wrote so others would believe.** His traditional Gospel was written "that ye might believe." *John 20:30–31*

Across Scripture

Tradition (Irenaeus, c. AD 180): John wrote the Gospel at Ephesus and lived into Trajan's reign. Others credit the beloved disciple's circle or "John the elder"; Revelation's John does not call himself an apostle.

Old Testament

Exodus 12:46; Zechariah 12:10	Fulfilled at the cross (John 19:35–37)
Echo: Genesis 1:1; Daniel 7	"In the beginning"; Revelation draws on Daniel and Ezekiel

New Testament

Mark 3:17; 5:37; 9:2; 10:35–45	Inner circle and son of thunder
John 13:23; 19:26; 21:20–24	The beloved disciple, who "wrote these things"
Acts 3:1–4:22; 8:14–25	With Peter in Jerusalem and Samaria
Galatians 2:9	A pillar of the church
1 John 4:7–8; 2 John 1	"Let us love one another," from "the elder"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did the council notice about Peter and John (Acts 4:13)?
2. *Understand:* John once wanted fire on Samaria, then prayed there for the Spirit. What changed him?
3. *Apply:* Where are you tempted to dismiss believers who "followeth not with us"?
4. *Apply:* Who has God placed in your care this season, as Jesus entrusted Mary to John?

129 Philip

The practical disciple who asked to see the Father and was shown the Son.

Philip came from Bethsaida, the hometown of Peter and Andrew. Jesus found him and said simply, "Follow me." Philip at once went to find his friend Nathanael and told him they had found the one Moses and the prophets wrote about. When Nathanael scoffed, Philip did not argue. He said, "Come and see." John's Gospel shows Philip as a careful, practical man. He counts the cost of bread for a crowd. He passes a request from some Greeks on to Andrew. At the last supper he asks Jesus to show them the Father. Jesus' answer to Philip is one of the clearest claims in Scripture: "he that hath seen me hath seen the Father."

At a glance

Name	Greek *Philippos*, "lover of horses"
Home	Bethsaida of Galilee (John 1:44; 12:21)
Friend	Nathanael, whom he brought to Jesus (John 1:45)
Among the Twelve	Always fifth in the lists, often paired with Bartholomew (Matthew 10:3; Luke 6:14)
Main passages	John 1:43–46; 6:5–7; 12:20–22; 14:8–11
Not the same as	Philip the evangelist, one of the seven (Acts 6:5; 8:5–40; 21:8)
Later life	Not recorded in Scripture; see Tradition on page 4

> *"Jesus saith unto him, Have I been so long time with you, and yet hast thou not known me, Philip? he that hath seen me hath seen the Father."*
>
> John 14:9, KJV

The life of Philip

Dates are approximate (AD). Jesus' ministry is dated c. AD 27/28–30 in this study. Only John's Gospel tells stories about Philip; the other Gospels and Acts only list him.

c. AD 27–28
Toward Galilee

Called by Jesus

The day after Andrew and Peter meet Jesus, Jesus goes to Galilee, finds Philip, and says to him, "Follow me." *John 1:43–44*

c. AD 27–28
Galilee

Brings Nathanael

Philip tells Nathanael they have found Jesus of Nazareth, the one Moses and the prophets wrote of. When Nathanael doubts, Philip says, "Come and see." *John 1:45–46*

c. AD 29
Near the Sea of Galilee

Tested by a question

Facing a hungry crowd, Jesus asks Philip where to buy bread. Philip reckons that two hundred pennyworth would not be enough for each to have a little. *John 6:5–7*

c. AD 30
Jerusalem

Approached by Greeks

Some Greeks at the Passover come to Philip with a request: "Sir, we would see Jesus." He tells Andrew, and they tell Jesus. *John 12:20–22*

c. AD 30
The last supper

Asks to see the Father

Philip says, "Lord, shew us the Father, and it sufficeth us." Jesus answers that whoever has seen him has seen the Father. *John 14:8–11*

Group notes

Key activities

John notes that Jesus asked Philip about bread "to prove him: for he himself knew what he would do" (John 6:6). The question was a test of faith, not a request for advice.

1. **Followed at once.** He answered Jesus' simple call to follow. *John 1:43*
2. **Shared the news.** He told Nathanael that Jesus fulfilled the Law and the Prophets. *John 1:45*
3. **Invited a doubter.** Instead of arguing, he said to Nathanael, "Come and see." *John 1:46*
4. **Was chosen as an apostle.** He is named among the Twelve in every list. *Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:14; Acts 1:13*
5. **Counted the cost.** He calculated that even two hundred pennyworth of bread would not feed the crowd. *John 6:5–7*
6. **Passed on a request.** He brought the Greeks' wish to see Jesus through Andrew to Jesus. *John 12:20–22*
7. **Asked an honest question.** He asked to see the Father and heard Jesus say that to see him is to see the Father. *John 14:8–11*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Philip.

Old Testament

Deuteronomy 18:15	The prophet like Moses, perhaps in Philip's mind (John 1:45)
Echo: Exodus 33:18	Moses asks to see God's glory; Philip asks to see the Father

New Testament

John 1:43–46	Called, and brings Nathanael
John 6:5–7; 12:21–22	Tested about bread; brings the Greeks
John 14:8–9	Asks to see the Father
Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:14; Acts 1:13	Listed among the Twelve
Tradition	Polycrates (in Eusebius) says he was buried at Hierapolis; perhaps confused with Philip the evangelist (Acts 21:8–9)

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What three words did Philip say to his doubting friend (John 1:46)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Jesus tested Philip with a question he already knew the answer to (John 6:5–6)?
3. *Apply:* Philip counted what he had instead of trusting what Jesus could do. Where are you doing the math without Jesus?
4. *Apply:* Who in your life has honest doubts about Jesus, and how could you say "Come and see" to them this week?

130 Nathanael (Bartholomew)

The honest skeptic who met Jesus and was promised greater things.

Nathanael came from Cana in Galilee. When his friend Philip told him the Messiah was Jesus of Nazareth, Nathanael scoffed: "Can there any good thing come out of Nazareth?" But he went to see. Jesus greeted him as "an Israelite indeed, in whom is no guile" and told him he had seen him under the fig tree. Nathanael's doubt turned at once into one of the earliest confessions in John's Gospel: "thou art the Son of God; thou art the King of Israel." John names him only twice. The first three Gospels never mention a Nathanael, but they list an apostle named Bartholomew beside Philip. For that reason many Christians have long believed the two names belong to one man.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Nathanael*, "God has given"
Other name	Probably Bartholomew, "son of Tolmai"; the link is likely but not certain
Home	Cana in Galilee (John 21:2)
Friend	Philip, who brought him to Jesus (John 1:45)
Main passages	John 1:45–51; 21:2
As Bartholomew	Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:14; Acts 1:13
Later life	Not recorded in Scripture; see Tradition on page 4

"Jesus saw Nathanael coming to him, and saith of him, Behold an Israelite indeed, in whom is no guile!"

John 1:47, KJV

The life of Nathanael (Bartholomew)

Dates are approximate (AD). Jesus' ministry is dated c. AD 27/28–30 in this study. Entries marked "as Bartholomew" depend on the two names being the same man.

c. AD 27–28
Galilee

Hears about Jesus

Philip finds Nathanael and says they have found the one Moses and the prophets wrote of, Jesus of Nazareth. Nathanael doubts that anything good can come from Nazareth. *John 1:45–46*

c. AD 27–28
Galilee

Meets Jesus

Jesus says he saw Nathanael under the fig tree before Philip called him. Nathanael confesses him as the Son of God and King of Israel. *John 1:47–51*

c. AD 28
As Bartholomew

Chosen as an apostle

After a night of prayer, Jesus names twelve apostles. Bartholomew is listed next to Philip. *Luke 6:12–16*

c. AD 30
Sea of Tiberias

Sees the risen Lord

Nathanael of Cana is among seven disciples who go fishing with Peter, catch nothing all night, and meet the risen Jesus on the shore at dawn. *John 21:1–14*

c. AD 30
As Bartholomew

Waits and prays

Bartholomew is with the apostles in the upper room after the ascension, waiting for the promised Spirit. *Acts 1:13–14*

Group notes

Key activities

Nathanael appears only in John, and Bartholomew appears only in the lists of the Twelve. The link rests on three clues: Bartholomew is a family name ("son of Tolmai") that would allow a personal name as well, he is paired with Philip in three lists, and John counts Nathanael among the disciples. Scripture never says directly that they are one person.

1. **Questioned honestly.** He asked, "Can there any good thing come out of Nazareth?" *John 1:46*
2. **Came and saw.** Despite his doubt, he went with Philip to meet Jesus. *John 1:46–47*
3. **Was known before he came.** Jesus knew his character and had seen him under the fig tree. *John 1:47–48*
4. **Confessed Jesus.** He called Jesus "the Son of God" and "the King of Israel." *John 1:49*
5. **Received a promise.** Jesus told him he would see heaven open and angels ascending and descending upon the Son of man. *John 1:50–51*
6. **Met the risen Christ.** He was one of the seven by the sea when Jesus appeared. *John 21:1–2*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Nathanael.

Old Testament

Genesis 28:12	Jacob's ladder; Jesus uses its words to Nathanael (John 1:51)
Echo: Genesis 27:35	Jacob took the blessing "with subtilty"; Nathanael has no guile
Echo: 1 Kings 4:25; Micah 4:4	Sitting under one's fig tree, a picture of peace

New Testament

John 1:45–51	Nathanael meets Jesus
John 21:2	Among the seven who see the risen Jesus by the sea
Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:14; Acts 1:13	Bartholomew listed among the Twelve
Tradition	Eusebius links Bartholomew with India; others say Armenia and martyrdom. Not in Scripture

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Nathanael describe Jesus after their short conversation (John 1:49)?
2. *Understand:* Jesus praised Nathanael's lack of guile even though he had just spoken bluntly about Nazareth. What does this show about honesty?
3. *Apply:* Nathanael brought his doubts to Jesus instead of staying away. What question would you like to bring to Jesus?
4. *Apply:* Jesus knew Nathanael before they met. How does it help you this week to know that God sees you under your "fig tree"?

131 Matthew

The tax collector who left his table to follow Jesus and threw a party for sinners.

Matthew, also called Levi, collected taxes by the Sea of Galilee, probably at Capernaum. To most Jews of his day, that made him a collaborator and a cheat. Jesus walked past his tax booth and said, "Follow me." Matthew left it all and followed. Then he threw a great feast so his fellow tax collectors could meet Jesus too. When the Pharisees objected, Jesus answered that the sick, not the healthy, need a doctor. No Gospel records a word Matthew spoke, yet the church has long linked his name with the first Gospel.

At a glance

Name	Matthew, probably "gift of the LORD"; also called Levi (Mark 2:14; Luke 5:27)
Family	Son of Alphaeus (Mark 2:14)
Work	Publican (tax collector), probably at Capernaum (Matthew 9:9)
Main passages	Matthew 9:9–13; Mark 2:14–17; Luke 5:27–32
Among the Twelve	Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:15; Acts 1:13
Writing	Traditionally the Gospel of Matthew; authorship is debated
Later life	Not recorded in Scripture; see Tradition on page 4

"And as Jesus passed forth from thence, he saw a man, named Matthew, sitting at the receipt of custom: and he saith unto him, Follow me. And he arose, and followed him."

Matthew 9:9, KJV

The life of Matthew

Dates are approximate (AD). Jesus' ministry is dated c. AD 27/28–30 in this study. Scripture does not give Matthew's age.

c. AD 28
Capernaum

Called from the tax booth

Walking by the Sea of Galilee, Jesus sees Levi the son of Alphaeus sitting at the receipt of custom. At the words "Follow me," he leaves everything and follows. *Mark 2:13–14; Luke 5:27–28*

c. AD 28
His own house

Hosts a great feast

Levi makes a great feast for Jesus, and many tax collectors and sinners sit down to eat with him and his disciples. *Luke 5:29; Matthew 9:10*

c. AD 28
His own house

Hears Jesus defend him

The Pharisees ask why Jesus eats with publicans and sinners. Jesus answers that he came to call sinners to repentance. *Matthew 9:11–13*

c. AD 28
On a mountain

Chosen as an apostle

Jesus names the Twelve. In Matthew's Gospel the list calls him "Matthew the publican," keeping his old label. *Matthew 10:2–4; Luke 6:13–16*

c. AD 30
Jerusalem

Waits in the upper room

After the ascension Matthew is with the other apostles and the women, praying and waiting for the Spirit. *Acts 1:13–14*

Group notes

Key activities

Mark and Luke call him Levi, while Matthew's Gospel calls him Matthew. Most readers take these as two names for one man, as with Simon and Peter.

1. **Sat at the receipt of custom.** He worked in a trade that made him an outsider among his people. *Matthew 9:9*
2. **Left everything.** Luke says he "left all, rose up, and followed him." *Luke 5:27–28*
3. **Opened his home.** He made a great feast so other tax collectors could meet Jesus. *Luke 5:29*
4. **Saw Jesus defend sinners.** Jesus answered the critics, "They that be whole need not a physician, but they that are sick." *Matthew 9:12*
5. **Heard mercy taught.** Jesus sent the critics to learn what Hosea meant: "I will have mercy, and not sacrifice." *Matthew 9:13*
6. **Joined the Twelve.** He was listed among the apostles, still named as a publican. *Matthew 10:3*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Matthew.

Old Testament

Hosea 6:6	Mercy, not sacrifice; quoted by Jesus at Matthew's feast (Matthew 9:13)
Echo: Matthew 1:22; 2:15; 4:14	His Gospel's deep interest in fulfilled prophecy

New Testament

Matthew 9:9–13; Mark 2:14–17; Luke 5:27–32	His call and feast
Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:15; Acts 1:13	Listed among the Twelve
Echo: Luke 19:1–10; 18:9–14	Zacchaeus, and the publican who went home justified
Tradition	Papias (in Eusebius) credits Matthew with this Gospel; many scholars debate the link

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Matthew do right after he left his tax booth (Luke 5:28–29)?
2. *Understand:* Why did the Pharisees object to Jesus eating with publicans, and what did Jesus mean by his answer (Matthew 9:11–13)?
3. *Apply:* Matthew's first act as a disciple was to throw a party for his old friends. Who could you invite to meet Jesus over a meal?
4. *Apply:* Is there anyone you have written off as too far gone? How might you show them mercy this week?

132 Thomas

The loyal, blunt disciple whose doubt ended in the Gospel's highest confession.

Thomas is often called "Doubting Thomas," but that nickname is not in the Bible, and it tells only part of his story. John's Gospel shows him as a man of courage and honesty. When Jesus decided to return to Judea, where enemies wanted him dead, Thomas said, "Let us also go, that we may die with him." When Jesus spoke of the way to the Father, Thomas admitted he did not understand. And when the others said they had seen the risen Lord, Thomas refused to believe without seeing the wounds. A week later Jesus met him and invited him to touch. Thomas answered with the fullest confession of faith in the Gospels: "My Lord and my God."

At a glance

Name	Aramaic *Thoma*, "twin"; in Greek Didymus, also "twin" (John 11:16)
Family	Not named; the twin is never identified
Among the Twelve	Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:15; Acts 1:13
Main passages	John 11:16; 14:5–6; 20:24–29; 21:2
Known for	Courage, blunt questions and the confession "My Lord and my God"
Nickname	"Doubting Thomas" is a later phrase, not biblical
Later life	Not recorded in Scripture; see Tradition on page 4

"And Thomas answered and said unto him, My Lord and my God."

John 20:28, KJV

The life of Thomas

Dates are approximate (AD). The crucifixion is dated AD 30 or AD 33; this study uses c. AD 30. Only John tells stories about Thomas; the other Gospels list him.

c. AD 28
Galilee

Chosen as an apostle

Jesus names the Twelve, and Thomas is among them. Nothing else is known of his life before this. *Luke 6:13–16*

c. AD 30
Beyond Jordan

Ready to die with Jesus

When Jesus decides to go back to Judea after Lazarus dies, the disciples warn him of danger. Thomas urges them to go and die with him. *John 11:7–16*

c. AD 30
The last supper

Asks the way

Jesus says the disciples know the way. Thomas answers that they do not even know where he is going. Jesus replies, "I am the way, the truth, and the life." *John 14:4–6*

c. AD 30
Easter evening

Absent and unconvinced

Thomas is not with the others when Jesus appears. He says he will not believe unless he sees and touches the nail prints and the wound in Jesus' side. *John 20:19–25*

c. AD 30
Eight days later

Sees and believes

Jesus appears again with Thomas present and invites him to touch his wounds. Thomas confesses, "My Lord and my God." *John 20:26–29*

c. AD 30
Sea of Tiberias

Goes fishing

Thomas is among the seven who meet the risen Jesus by the sea. *John 21:1–2*

Group notes

Key activities

Scripture never says whether Thomas actually touched Jesus' wounds. Jesus invited him to, but John records only his confession.

1. **Followed as one of the Twelve.** He was chosen and named in every list of apostles. *Matthew 10:3; Acts 1:13*
2. **Spoke with courage.** He said, "Let us also go, that we may die with him." *John 11:16*
3. **Asked an honest question.** He said, "Lord, we know not whither thou goest; and how can we know the way?" *John 14:5*
4. **Demanded evidence.** Unless he could see "the print of the nails" and touch the wounds, he said, "I will not believe." *John 20:25*
5. **Confessed Jesus as Lord and God.** Faced with the risen Christ, he gave the Gospel's clearest confession. *John 20:28*
6. **Received a blessing for others.** Jesus told him, "blessed are they that have not seen, and yet have believed." *John 20:29*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Thomas.

Old Testament

Echo: Judges 6:36–40	Gideon asks God for signs before he will believe
Echo: Psalm 35:23	"My God and my Lord," the titles Thomas gives Jesus

New Testament

John 11:16; 14:5; 20:24–29; 21:2	Thomas's words and appearances
Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:15; Acts 1:13	Listed among the Twelve
John 20:30–31	John writes "that ye might believe" right after Thomas's story
1 Peter 1:8	Believers who love Jesus without having seen him
Tradition	Early writers say Parthia; the Saint Thomas Christians of India say he died near Chennai

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Thomas say he needed before he would believe, and what did Jesus offer him (John 20:25–27)?
2. *Understand:* Jesus blessed "they that have not seen, and yet have believed." What does that mean for readers of John's Gospel today?
3. *Apply:* Thomas was honest about his questions. What doubt or question could you bring into the open with God or with your group?
4. *Apply:* Thomas missed the first meeting with the risen Lord. How can you keep from missing your gathering this week?

133 The lesser-known apostles

Faithful names on the list: James son of Alphaeus, Judas (Thaddaeus), Simon the Zealot, and Matthias.

Every list of the Twelve ends with a few names we know almost nothing about. James the son of Alphaeus is never quoted. Judas, "not Iscariot," asks Jesus one question at the last supper. Simon is remembered only by his label, "the Canaanite" or "Zelotes," which probably marks him as zealous for Israel's cause. After the resurrection Matthias is chosen to take the place of Judas Iscariot. These men were sent out with the same authority as Peter and John. Their place on the list reminds us that most of Christ's servants work without fame.

At a glance

James son of Alphaeus	Ninth in every list; possibly "James the less" (Matthew 10:3; Mark 15:40)
Judas, not Iscariot	Also Thaddaeus; "Judas the brother of James" (Luke 6:16)
Simon the Zealot	"The Canaanite" (Matthew 10:4) and "Zelotes" (Luke 6:15)
Matthias	Chosen by lot to replace Judas Iscariot (Acts 1:23–26)
Main passages	Matthew 10:2–4; Mark 3:16–19; Luke 6:14–16; John 14:22; Acts 1:13–26
Later lives	Not recorded in Scripture; see Tradition on page 4

"And he ordained twelve, that they should be with him, and that he might send them forth to preach."

Mark 3:14, KJV

The life of The lesser-known apostles

Dates are approximate (AD). Jesus' ministry is dated c. AD 27/28–30 in this study, and the crucifixion c. AD 30. Scripture gives no ages.

c. AD 28
On a mountain

Chosen as apostles

After a night of prayer, Jesus chooses twelve from among his disciples. James son of Alphaeus, Judas and Simon are named among them. *Luke 6:12–16*

c. AD 29
Galilee

Sent out two by two

Jesus gives the Twelve power over unclean spirits and sends them to preach repentance, heal the sick, and anoint with oil. *Mark 6:7–13; Matthew 10:1–15*

c. AD 30
The last supper

Judas asks a question

Judas, "not Iscariot," asks why Jesus will show himself to the disciples and not to the world. Jesus speaks of love, obedience and his dwelling with them. *John 14:21–23*

c. AD 30
Jerusalem

Wait in the upper room

After the ascension James, Judas and Simon pray with the other apostles, the women, and Jesus' mother and brothers. *Acts 1:13–14*

c. AD 30
Jerusalem

Matthias is chosen

Peter calls for a witness of the resurrection to replace Judas Iscariot. After prayer the lot falls on Matthias, who is numbered with the eleven apostles. *Acts 1:15–26*

Group notes

Key activities

The names in the lists differ slightly. Most readers take Thaddaeus, Lebbaeus and "Judas of James" as one man known by more than one name. Luke's Greek says only "Judas of James," so he may be James's son rather than his brother; the KJV supplies "brother."

1. **Were chosen by Jesus.** Each was named an apostle after Jesus prayed all night. *Luke 6:12–16*
2. **Shared the mission.** They were sent with power to heal and to preach the kingdom of God. *Luke 9:1–6*
3. **Asked about Jesus' self-revelation.** Judas asked, "Lord, how is it that thou wilt manifest thyself unto us, and not unto the world?" *John 14:22*
4. **Held on after the cross.** They stayed together and continued in prayer with one accord. *Acts 1:13–14*
5. **Stepped into an empty place.** Matthias, who had been with Jesus since John's baptism, became a witness of the resurrection with the eleven. *Acts 1:21–26*
6. **Received the Spirit.** All the apostles were together on the day of Pentecost, and Peter stood up "with the eleven." *Acts 2:1–4, 14*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names these apostles.

Old Testament

Psalm 69:25; 109:8	Applied by Peter to Judas's empty place (Acts 1:20)
Proverbs 16:33	The lot is cast, but the LORD decides
Echo: Genesis 49:28	Twelve apostles, like Israel's twelve tribes
Echo: Numbers 25:11–13	Phinehas, zealous for his God, like Simon's title

New Testament

Matthew 10:2–4; Mark 3:16–19; Luke 6:14–16; Acts 1:13	The four lists
John 14:22; Acts 1:23–26	Judas asks his question; Matthias is chosen
Matthew 19:28; Revelation 21:14	Twelve thrones and twelve foundations
Tradition	Simon and Jude are said to have died in Persia

For discussion

1. *Observe:* According to Mark 3:14, what were the Twelve chosen for?
2. *Understand:* What did the church look for in Judas's replacement (Acts 1:21–22)?
3. *Apply:* These apostles served with little recognition. Where are you serving unnoticed, and how can you keep at it?
4. *Apply:* A zealot and a tax collector served together. Who very different from you could you work with or pray for?

134 Judas Iscariot

The chosen apostle who betrayed his Master for thirty pieces of silver.

Judas Iscariot was one of the Twelve. Jesus chose him, sent him out to preach and heal, and trusted him with the group's money. He saw the miracles and heard the teaching as closely as Peter and John did. Yet he became the man who handed Jesus over to his enemies. John says Judas was a thief who stole from the common purse. Luke and John say Satan entered him. For thirty pieces of silver he led an armed crowd to Gethsemane and marked Jesus with a kiss. When he saw Jesus condemned, he tried to return the money, and then he took his own life. His story is one of the most sobering in Scripture. It shows that being close to Jesus is not the same as belonging to him.

At a glance

Name	Judas, the Greek form of Judah, "praise"
Iscariot	Probably "man of Kerioth," a town in Judah; other meanings have been suggested (Joshua 15:25)
Family	Son of Simon Iscariot (John 6:71; 13:26)
Role	Treasurer of the Twelve; "had the bag" (John 12:6; 13:29)
Price	Thirty pieces of silver (Matthew 26:15)
Death	Hanged himself; the field bought with the money was called the field of blood (Matthew 27:5–8; Acts 1:18–19)
Successor	Matthias (Acts 1:26)

"But Jesus said unto him, Judas, betrayest thou the Son of man with a kiss?"

Luke 22:48, KJV

The life of Judas Iscariot

Dates are approximate (AD). The crucifixion is dated AD 30 or AD 33; this study uses c. AD 30. The last five entries fall within one week.

c. AD 28
On a mountain

Chosen as an apostle

Jesus names the Twelve after a night of prayer. In each Gospel list Judas Iscariot is named last and marked as the one who would betray him. *Luke 6:12–16; Mark 3:19*

c. AD 29
Capernaum

Singled out

When many disciples turn away, Jesus says, "Have not I chosen you twelve, and one of you is a devil?" John explains that he meant Judas. *John 6:66–71*

c. AD 30
Bethany

Objects to the ointment

Mary anoints Jesus with costly ointment. Judas asks why it was not sold and given to the poor. John says he cared not for the poor but was a thief. *John 12:1–8*

c. AD 30
Jerusalem

Strikes a deal

Judas goes to the chief priests and asks what they will give him to hand Jesus over. They agree on thirty pieces of silver, and he watches for his chance. *Matthew 26:14–16; Luke 22:3–6*

c. AD 30
The last supper

Goes out into the night

Jesus says one of them will betray him and gives Judas the sop. Satan enters him, Jesus says, "That thou doest, do quickly," and Judas goes out. *John 13:21–30*

c. AD 30
Gethsemane

Betrays with a kiss

Judas arrives with a great multitude carrying swords and staves. He greets Jesus, "Hail, master," and kisses him, the agreed sign for the arrest. *Matthew 26:47–50*

c. AD 30
Jerusalem

Dies in despair

Seeing Jesus condemned, Judas brings back the silver and says he has betrayed innocent blood. The priests will not take it back. He throws it down in the temple and hangs himself. *Matthew 27:3–5*

Key activities

Matthew says Judas hanged himself and the priests bought a potter's field with the money. Acts says Judas "purchased a field" with it and, "falling headlong," burst open. Many readers combine the two accounts; others see two independent reports. Both call the place the field of blood.

1. **Was chosen and sent.** He was among the Twelve whom Jesus sent to preach and heal. *Matthew 10:1–5*
2. **Kept the bag.** He held the group's money and stole from it. *John 12:6; 13:29*
3. **Complained about Mary's gift.** He called her ointment a waste that could have been sold for three hundred pence. *John 12:4–5*
4. **Let Satan in.** Scripture says the devil put betrayal into his heart and that Satan entered him. *Luke 22:3; John 13:2, 27*
5. **Sold his Master.** He asked the chief priests, "What will ye give me, and I will deliver him unto you?" *Matthew 26:15*
6. **Had his feet washed.** Jesus washed the disciples' feet, yet said, "Ye are not all clean," knowing who would betray him. *John 13:5, 10–11*
7. **Asked if it was he.** He asked, "Master, is it I?" and Jesus answered, "Thou hast said." *Matthew 26:25*
8. **Left the supper.** He took the sop and went out, "and it was night." *John 13:30*
9. **Kissed Jesus.** He used a sign of friendship to point out Jesus to the arresting crowd. Jesus called him "Friend." *Matthew 26:48–50*
10. **Regretted too late.** He said, "I have sinned in that I have betrayed the innocent blood," and brought back the silver. *Matthew 27:3–4*
11. **Took his own life.** He went out and hanged himself. *Matthew 27:5*
12. **Left an empty place.** Peter said Judas had gone "to his own place," and Matthias took his office among the apostles. *Acts 1:16–26*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Judas.

Old Testament

Psalm 41:9	The friend who ate bread, applied by Jesus (John 13:18)
Psalm 69:25; 109:8	Applied by Peter to Judas's empty office (Acts 1:20)
Zechariah 11:12–13	Thirty pieces cast to the potter; Matthew cites "Jeremy" (27:9)
Echo: Genesis 37:26–28	Judah sells his brother Joseph for silver
Echo: 2 Samuel 17:23	Ahithophel betrays David and hangs himself

New Testament

Matthew 26:24	Better for that man if he had not been born
John 17:12	None lost "but the son of perdition"
Acts 1:16–25	Peter recounts his end; a replacement is chosen
Tradition	His motives are debated; Scripture names greed and Satan's work

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Judas do after he saw that Jesus was condemned (Matthew 27:3–5)?
2. *Understand:* Peter and Judas both failed Jesus that night. Why did their stories end so differently?
3. *Apply:* Judas was stealing from the bag long before the betrayal. What hidden habit do you need to bring into the light?
4. *Apply:* The priests told Judas, "see thou to that." How could you point someone full of regret to Jesus this week?

135 Nicodemus

The teacher of Israel who came to Jesus by night and stood by him in the end.

Nicodemus was a Pharisee and "a ruler of the Jews," a respected teacher in Jerusalem. He appears only in John's Gospel, and only three times. First he comes to Jesus by night and hears that he must be "born again." Later he speaks up for Jesus in the council and is mocked for it. Last, he joins Joseph of Arimathea in burying Jesus with a costly load of spices. John never says when Nicodemus came to faith, but his three scenes trace a man moving slowly out of the shadows and into the open.

At a glance

Name	Greek *Nikodemos*, usually explained as "victor over the people"
Group	A Pharisee (John 3:1)
Position	"A ruler of the Jews," probably of the Sanhedrin (John 3:1)
Title	"A master of Israel," meaning a teacher (John 3:10)
When	c. AD 28–30, during Jesus' ministry
Key places	Jerusalem
Key people	Jesus, the chief priests and Pharisees, Joseph of Arimathea
New Testament	Only in John's Gospel (John 3:1–21; 7:45–52; 19:38–42)

> *"Jesus answered and said unto him, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God."*
>
> John 3:3, KJV

The life of Nicodemus

Dates are approximate (AD) and follow the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30. On the other main view (AD 33), add about three years.

c. AD 28–29
Passover

Comes by night

At Passover in Jerusalem many believe when they see Jesus' miracles. Nicodemus comes to Jesus by night and calls him "a teacher come from God," because no one could do such signs unless God were with him. *John 2:23–3:2*

The same night

Hears of new birth

Jesus tells him a man must be "born of water and of the Spirit." Nicodemus asks, "How can these things be?" Jesus speaks of the Son of man being lifted up, as Moses lifted up the serpent. *John 3:3–15*

c. AD 29
Feast of tabernacles

Speaks up in the council

Officers sent to arrest Jesus return empty-handed. When the Pharisees scorn the crowd, Nicodemus asks whether the law judges a man before hearing him. They answer, "Art thou also of Galilee?" *John 7:45–52*

c. AD 30
The day of the crucifixion

Helps bury Jesus

With Joseph of Arimathea he brings about a hundred pounds of myrrh and aloes. They wind Jesus' body in linen with the spices and lay it in a new tomb in a nearby garden. *John 19:38–42*

Group notes

Key activities

John does not say why Nicodemus came by night. Some think he feared the other leaders, others that night was simply a quiet time for study. Many also notice John's theme of light and darkness (John 3:19–21).

1. **Came to Jesus.** He sought Jesus out and honoured him as a teacher from God because of the signs he had done. *John 3:1–2*
2. **Asked honest questions.** He asked how a grown man could be born again, and then, "How can these things be?" *John 3:4, 9*
3. **Heard the heart of the gospel.** In this conversation he heard that God so loved the world that he gave his only begotten Son. *John 3:14–17*
4. **Stood up for fairness.** He reminded the council that the law does not judge a man before hearing him. *John 7:50–51*
5. **Bore the council's scorn.** The others mocked him as if he were a Galilean follower, and told him to search the Scriptures. *John 7:52*
6. **Gave a costly burial.** He brought about a hundred Roman pounds of myrrh and aloes, roughly seventy pounds by modern weight, a gift fit for a king. *John 19:39*
7. **Stepped into the open.** With Joseph of Arimathea he handled Jesus' body publicly on the day the council had condemned him. *John 19:38–40*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Nicodemus.

Old Testament

Numbers 21:8–9	The brass serpent, Jesus' picture for Nicodemus (John 3:14–15)
Echo: Ezekiel 36:25–27	Clean water, a new heart and a new spirit
Echo: Deuteronomy 1:16–17	Judges must hear a matter fairly

New Testament

John 3:1–21	The night talk; where Jesus' words end is debated
John 7:45–52	He defends a fair hearing for Jesus
John 19:38–42	He helps Joseph of Arimathea bury Jesus
Echo: John 12:42–43	Rulers who believed but feared to confess
Echo: 1 Peter 1:23	Born again by the word of God

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Nicodemus say about Jesus when he first came to him (John 3:2)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Jesus answered with "Ye must be born again" (John 3:7) rather than talking about his miracles?
3. *Apply:* Nicodemus came with honest questions. What question about faith would you like to bring to God in prayer this week?
4. *Apply:* In John 7 Nicodemus spoke up for fairness in a hostile room. Where could you speak a quiet word for what is fair this week?

136 The woman at the well

A Samaritan woman came for water and went home to tell her town about the Christ.

At midday a Samaritan woman came to draw water at Jacob's well near Sychar. A tired Jewish traveller sitting there asked her for a drink. It was Jesus. In one conversation he crossed three walls: Jew and Samaritan, man and woman, teacher and a woman with a troubled past. He offered her "living water," told her the truth about her life, and plainly said he was the Messiah. She left her waterpot and ran to tell the town. Scripture never names her, yet she brought a whole town to Jesus.

At a glance

Name	Not given in Scripture
People	A Samaritan (John 4:9)
Home	Sychar, a city of Samaria (John 4:5)
Life	Five husbands; the man she now had was not her husband (John 4:18)
When	c. AD 28–29, early in Jesus' ministry
Main passages	John 4:1–42
New Testament	Only in John's Gospel

> *"But whosoever drinketh of the water that I shall give him shall never thirst; but the water that I shall give him shall be in him a well of water springing up into everlasting life."*
>
> John 4:14, KJV

The life of The woman at the well

The date is approximate (AD) and follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30. John places the story soon after Jesus' first Passover in Jerusalem.

c. AD 28–29
The sixth hour

A request for water

On his way from Judea to Galilee, Jesus rests, wearied, at Jacob's well. A woman of Samaria comes to draw water, and he says, "Give me to drink." She is astonished that a Jew would ask this of her. *John 4:1–9*

At the well

Living water

Jesus offers "living water" that becomes a well springing up into everlasting life. She asks for this water so she need not keep coming to draw, still thinking of the well. *John 4:10–15*

At the well

Her life laid bare

Jesus tells her to call her husband. When she says she has none, he names her five husbands. She calls him a prophet and raises the old question of where to worship. *John 4:16–20*

At the well

The Messiah revealed

Jesus says true worshippers will worship the Father "in spirit and in truth." When she speaks of the coming Messiah, Jesus says, "I that speak unto thee am he." *John 4:21–26*

The same day

She tells the town

She leaves her waterpot and goes into the city: "Come, see a man, which told me all things that ever I did: is not this the Christ?" The people go out to him. *John 4:27–30*

Two days

Many believe

Many Samaritans believe because of her words. Jesus stays two days, and many more believe his own word, saying he is "the Saviour of the world." *John 4:39–42*

Key activities

John does not explain her five marriages. Some readers assume a sinful past. Others note that a woman could be widowed or divorced by her husbands with little choice of her own. Jesus names her situation plainly, and the text records no word of condemnation.

1. **Came to draw water.** She came to Jacob's well at about the sixth hour, when Jesus was sitting there. *John 4:6–7*
2. **Questioned the stranger.** She asked why a Jew would ask her for a drink, and whether he was greater than "our father Jacob." *John 4:9–12*
3. **Asked for living water.** "Sir, give me this water, that I thirst not, neither come hither to draw." *John 4:15*
4. **Told the truth.** She said, "I have no husband," and Jesus said she had spoken well. *John 4:17–18*
5. **Raised the question of worship.** She asked whether God should be worshipped on the Samaritans' mountain or in Jerusalem. *John 4:19–24*
6. **Spoke of the Messiah.** "I know that Messias cometh, which is called Christ." *John 4:25–26*
7. **Left her waterpot.** She went back into the city in such haste that she left her waterpot behind. *John 4:28*
8. **Brought her town to Jesus.** Her simple testimony led many Samaritans to believe and to come and hear him. *John 4:29–30, 39–42*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names the woman at the well.

Old Testament

Genesis 33:18–20; 48:22	Jacob's land near Shechem, given to Joseph (John 4:5)
2 Kings 17:24–41	Where the Samaritans and their mixed worship came from
Echo: Genesis 24; 29:1–12	Meetings at wells: Rebekah and Rachel
Echo: Jeremiah 2:13	God, "the fountain of living waters"

New Testament

John 4:1–42	The main account
John 7:37–39	Living water again, explained as the Spirit
Luke 10:30–37; 17:11–19	A good Samaritan and a grateful Samaritan leper
Acts 8:5–25	The gospel reaches Samaria, and many believe
Echo: Revelation 22:17	Take the water of life freely

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What does the woman do after Jesus says, "I that speak unto thee am he" (John 4:26–30)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Jesus began with a request for water rather than a sermon?
3. *Apply:* She left her waterpot behind. What everyday concern might you set down this week to pay attention to Jesus?
4. *Apply:* Her testimony was simple: "Come, see." Who is one person you could invite to church or to your group this week?

137 Mary Magdalene

Set free by Jesus, faithful at the cross, and the first to see him risen.

Mary Magdalene is named in all four Gospels. Jesus had cast seven devils out of her, and from then on she followed him, helping support his work from her own means. When most of the disciples fled, she stood near the cross. She watched where his body was laid, came early to the tomb, and became the first to see the risen Jesus and carry the news. She is often remembered as a repentant prostitute, but Scripture never says so; that is later tradition, from a sixth-century sermon. The Bible's Mary is a woman set free, loyal to the end.

At a glance

Name	Mary called Magdalene, probably meaning "of Magdala"
Home	Probably Magdala, a town on the western shore of the Sea of Galilee
Healed	Jesus had cast seven devils out of her (Luke 8:2; Mark 16:9)
When	Followed Jesus c. AD 28–30, from Galilee to the cross
Key places	Galilee, Golgotha, the garden tomb
Key people	Jesus, Joanna, Susanna, Peter, John the apostle
Main passages	Luke 8:1–3; Mark 15:40–16:11; John 19:25; 20:1–18
Not the same as	The sinful woman of Luke 7 or Mary of Bethany

"Jesus saith unto her, Mary. She turned herself, and saith unto him, Rabboni; which is to say, Master."

John 20:16, KJV

The life of Mary Magdalene

Dates are approximate (AD), with the crucifixion c. AD 30 (on the AD 33 view, add three years). The Gospels do not say when she was healed.

c. AD 28–29
In Galilee

Set free

Jesus casts seven devils out of her. The Gospels never tell the story, only name it as what marked her life. *Luke 8:2; Mark 16:9*

c. AD 29
Galilee

Travels with Jesus

With Joanna, Susanna and many others she goes with Jesus and the Twelve and "ministered unto him of their substance." *Luke 8:1–3*

c. AD 30
Friday

At the cross

Having followed him up to Jerusalem, she stands by the cross with Jesus' mother and other women. *John 19:25; Mark 15:40–41*

c. AD 30
Friday evening

Sees where he is laid

She and "the other Mary" watch the burial, then prepare spices and rest on the sabbath. *Matthew 27:61; Luke 23:55–56*

c. AD 30
Sunday dawn

Finds the tomb open

While it is still dark she sees the stone taken away and runs to tell Peter and the disciple whom Jesus loved. *John 20:1–2*

c. AD 30
Sunday

Meets the risen Lord

Weeping at the tomb, she takes Jesus for the gardener until he says her name. She goes and tells the disciples. *John 20:11–18*

Group notes

Key activities

The Gospels name different groups of women at the cross and the tomb, but Mary Magdalene appears in every list, and usually first. Mark 16:9–20 is missing from some of the oldest manuscripts. The KJV includes it.

1. **Received deliverance.** Jesus cast seven devils out of her. Scripture gives no details, only the fact of her freedom. *Luke 8:2*
2. **Followed Jesus.** She joined the Twelve and other women on Jesus' preaching journeys through Galilee. *Luke 8:1–2*
3. **Gave from her means.** With other women she supported Jesus and his disciples with her own money and goods. *Luke 8:3*
4. **Stayed at the cross.** When the disciples had fled, she remained near Jesus as he died. *Mark 14:50; 15:40–41; John 19:25*
5. **Watched the burial.** She saw where Jesus was laid, so she knew which tomb to come back to. *Mark 15:47*
6. **Prepared spices.** She bought and prepared spices to anoint his body after the sabbath. *Luke 23:55–24:1; Mark 16:1*
7. **Came to the tomb first.** She came while it was still dark and found the stone rolled away. *John 20:1*
8. **Ran for help.** "They have taken away the Lord out of the sepulchre, and we know not where they have laid him." *John 20:2*
9. **Stayed and wept.** After Peter and the other disciple went home, she stayed at the tomb, grieving. *John 20:10–13*
10. **Knew his voice.** When Jesus called her "Mary," she turned and answered, "Rabboni." *John 20:14–16*
11. **Carried the first message.** Jesus sent her to his brethren, and she went and told the disciples that she had seen the Lord. *John 20:17–18*
12. **Was counted among the witnesses.** Luke names her first among the women who told these things to the apostles, though at first they did not believe. *Luke 24:10–11*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Mary Magdalene.

Old Testament

Echo: Song of Solomon 3:1–4	Seeking "him whom my soul loveth," often read with John 20
Echo: Psalm 30:5	Weeping for a night, joy in the morning
Echo: Isaiah 43:1	"I have called thee by thy name"

New Testament

Luke 8:1–3	She travels with Jesus and supports his work
Matthew 27:55–28:10; Mark 15:40–16:11	At the cross, the burial and the empty tomb
Luke 24:1–11	Among the women who tell the apostles
John 19:25; 20:1–18	Her meeting with the risen Jesus
Tradition	Gregory the Great (AD 591) merged her with Luke 7 and Mary of Bethany; Scripture does not

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Mary do in John 20:1–2, and again in John 20:11?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Jesus appeared first to Mary and sent her to tell the others?
3. *Apply:* Mary gave from her own means. What time, money or skill could you give to God's work this month?
4. *Apply:* Mary knew Jesus when he spoke her name. Where do you need to hear that God knows you by name?

138 Martha, Mary and Lazarus

A family in Bethany whom Jesus loved, and whose brother he called out of the grave.

Martha, Mary and their brother Lazarus lived in Bethany, just outside Jerusalem, and their home was a place of welcome for Jesus. John says simply that "Jesus loved Martha, and her sister, and Lazarus." Luke shows Martha busy serving and Mary sitting at Jesus' feet. John tells how Lazarus died, how Jesus wept with the sisters, and how he called Lazarus out of the tomb after four days. Days later Mary poured costly ointment on Jesus' feet. This family shows friendship with Jesus in ordinary life, in grief, and in worship.

At a glance

Names	Martha; Mary; Lazarus, a Greek form of Eleazar
Family	Two sisters and their brother (John 11:1–2)
Home	Bethany, under two miles from Jerusalem (John 11:18)
When	c. AD 29–30
Known for	Welcoming Jesus; Lazarus raised; Mary's anointing
Key people	Jesus, Thomas, the mourners, Caiaphas, Judas Iscariot
Main passages	Luke 10:38–42; John 11:1–12:19

"Jesus said unto her, I am the resurrection, and the life: he that believeth in me, though he were dead, yet shall he live:"

John 11:25, KJV

The life of Martha, Mary and Lazarus

Dates are approximate (AD), with the crucifixion c. AD 30 (on the AD 33 view, add three years). Luke gives no date and does not name the village.

c. AD 29
A village visit

Martha welcomes Jesus

Mary sits at his feet while Martha is "cumbered about much serving." Jesus says Mary has chosen "that good part." *Luke 10:38–42*

c. AD 30
Winter

Lazarus falls sick

The sisters send word to Jesus beyond the Jordan. He says the sickness is for God's glory and stays two more days. *John 10:40; 11:1–6*

c. AD 30
Four days later

Martha meets Jesus

Jesus tells her, "I am the resurrection, and the life." She confesses him as the Christ, the Son of God. *John 11:17–27*

c. AD 30
The same day

Jesus weeps

Mary falls at his feet with the same words as Martha. Seeing the mourners weeping, Jesus groans in spirit and weeps. *John 11:28–37*

c. AD 30
The same day

Lazarus comes forth

The stone is taken away, and Jesus cries, "Lazarus, come forth." The dead man walks out in graveclothes. *John 11:38–44*

c. AD 30
Soon after

The council plots

Many believe, but the council, led by Caiaphas, plans Jesus' death, and Jesus withdraws to Ephraim. *John 11:45–54*

c. AD 30
Six days before Passover

Supper and anointing

Martha serves and Mary anoints Jesus' feet with spikenard. Crowds come to see Lazarus, and the priests plot to kill him too. *John 12:1–11*

Key activities

Matthew 26:6–13 and Mark 14:3–9 tell of a woman who anoints Jesus' head at the house of Simon the leper in Bethany. Most readers think this is the same event as John 12, where the woman is Mary. Luke 7:36–50 is a different anointing, in Galilee.

1. **Martha opened her home.** She received Jesus into her house as a guest. *Luke 10:38*
2. **Mary sat at Jesus' feet.** She took the place of a disciple and listened to his word. *Luke 10:39*
3. **Martha spoke her frustration.** "Lord, dost thou not care that my sister hath left me to serve alone?" Jesus answered her gently: "one thing is needful." *Luke 10:40–42*
4. **The sisters sent for Jesus.** They brought their need straight to him and trusted his love. *John 11:3*
5. **Martha confessed her faith.** In grief she still said, "I believe that thou art the Christ, the Son of God." *John 11:21–27*
6. **Mary brought her tears.** She fell at Jesus' feet and wept, and Jesus wept with her. *John 11:32–35*
7. **Lazarus was raised.** At Jesus' command he came out of the tomb, and Jesus said, "Loose him, and let him go." *John 11:43–44*
8. **Many believed.** The miracle led many to put their faith in Jesus. *John 11:45; 12:11*
9. **Martha served again.** At the supper in Bethany she served, as she had before. *John 12:2*
10. **Mary anointed Jesus.** She poured a pound of spikenard on his feet and wiped them with her hair. Jesus said, "against the day of my burying hath she kept this." *John 12:3–8*
11. **Lazarus became a target.** Because his new life drew people to Jesus, the chief priests planned to kill him as well. *John 12:10–11*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names this family.

Old Testament

Echo: 1 Kings 17:17–24; 2 Kings 4:32–37	Elijah and Elisha raise dead sons
Echo: Ezekiel 37:12–14	God opens graves and gives his Spirit

New Testament

Luke 10:38–42	Martha serves and Mary listens
John 11:1–12:19	Lazarus raised; the council plots; Mary anoints Jesus
Matthew 26:6–13; Mark 14:3–9	The anointing at Bethany, told as a memorial
Luke 16:19–31	A different Lazarus, the beggar in a parable
Echo: 1 Thessalonians 4:13–14	Not sorrowing as those with no hope
Tradition	Legends take Lazarus to Cyprus or Provence; merging Mary with Magdalene is unscriptural

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Martha and Mary each say to Jesus when he arrived (John 11:21, 32)?
2. *Understand:* Jesus knew he would raise Lazarus, yet he wept (John 11:35). What does that show about him?
3. *Apply:* Are you more like Martha, busy serving, or Mary, sitting to listen? What would one step toward the other look like?
4. *Apply:* Martha believed in the middle of grief. How could you come alongside someone grieving this week?

139 Jairus

A synagogue ruler who fell at Jesus' feet for his dying daughter and learned to "only believe."

Jairus was "one of the rulers of the synagogue" in a town by the Sea of Galilee. He was a respected man, but when his twelve-year-old daughter lay dying, he pushed through the crowd and fell at Jesus' feet. Jesus went with him. Then came a delay, as Jesus stopped to heal a woman who touched his clothes. While they waited, word came that the girl had died. Jesus turned to Jairus and said, "Be not afraid, only believe." At the house he took the girl by the hand and raised her to life. Matthew, Mark and Luke all tell the story. It is a story about a desperate parent, an unwelcome delay, and trust in Jesus when all hope seems gone.

At a glance

Name	Jairus, the Greek form of the Old Testament name Jair
Position	"One of the rulers of the synagogue" (Mark 5:22)
Family	A wife and "one only daughter, about twelve years of age" (Luke 8:42; Mark 5:40)
Home	A town by the Sea of Galilee, probably Capernaum
When	c. AD 28–29, during Jesus' ministry in Galilee
Key people	Jesus; Peter, James and John; a woman healed on the way
Main passages	Mark 5:21–43; Matthew 9:18–26; Luke 8:40–56

"As soon as Jesus heard the word that was spoken, he saith unto the ruler of the synagogue, Be not afraid, only believe."

Mark 5:36, KJV

The life of Jairus

The date is approximate (AD) and follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30. Matthew tells the story more briefly. There, the ruler says at the start that his daughter "is even now dead" (Matthew 9:18).

c. AD 28–29
By the sea

Falls at Jesus' feet

When Jesus crosses back over the lake, a crowd gathers. Jairus comes, falls at his feet, and begs him to come and lay hands on his little daughter, who "lieth at the point of death." *Mark 5:21–23*

On the way

A delay

A woman who has suffered bleeding for twelve years touches Jesus' garment and is healed. Jesus stops, asks who touched him, and speaks with her while Jairus waits. *Mark 5:24–34*

On the way

Bad news

Messengers arrive from Jairus's house: "Thy daughter is dead: why troublest thou the Master any further?" Jesus tells Jairus not to be afraid, but only to believe. *Mark 5:35–36*

At the house

Laughed to scorn

Jesus lets only Peter, James and John follow him. He tells the loud mourners that the child "is not dead, but sleepeth," and they laugh at him. *Mark 5:37–40*

At the house

Talitha cumi

With the parents and the three disciples, Jesus takes the girl's hand and tells her to arise. She gets up and walks. He orders them to tell no one and to give her something to eat. *Mark 5:40–43*

Group notes

Key activities

Mark and Luke tell Jairus's story wrapped around the healing of the woman with the issue of blood. Both stories involve the number twelve, and Jesus calls the woman "Daughter" (Mark 5:34). Many readers see the link as deliberate.

1. **Humbled himself.** A synagogue ruler fell at the feet of a travelling teacher in front of the crowd. *Mark 5:22*
2. **Pleaded for his daughter.** He begged Jesus earnestly to come and lay his hands on her, that she might live. *Mark 5:23*
3. **Waited.** He stood by while Jesus stopped to find and speak with the woman who had touched him. *Mark 5:30–34*
4. **Kept believing.** When the news of death came, he heard Jesus' word, "Be not afraid, only believe," and went on with him. *Mark 5:35–37*
5. **Witnessed the miracle.** He and his wife watched Jesus raise their daughter, and they were "astonished with a great astonishment." *Mark 5:40–42*
6. **Was told to keep quiet.** Jesus charged them that no one should know it, and told them to feed her. *Mark 5:43*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jairus.

Old Testament

Echoes	Elijah raises the son of the widow of Zarephath (1 Kings 17:17–24). Elisha raises the son of the Shunammite woman (2 Kings 4:18–37). In both stories the prophet goes into a private room with the child.

New Testament

Mark 5:21–43	The fullest account, with the Aramaic words Jesus spoke.
Matthew 9:18–26	A shorter account that calls him "a certain ruler."
Luke 8:40–56	Luke names him and says she was his only daughter.
Echoes	Jesus raises a widow's son at Nain (Luke 7:11–15) and Lazarus of Bethany (John 11:43–44). Peter later says "Tabitha, arise" to Dorcas (Acts 9:40), words close to Jesus' own.

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Jesus say to Jairus when the bad news came (Mark 5:36)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Mark places the woman's healing in the middle of Jairus's story?
3. *Apply:* Jairus had to wait while Jesus helped someone else. How do you respond when God seems to delay?
4. *Apply:* Jairus came to Jesus for his child. Who is one person you will pray for by name every day this week?

140 The centurion of Capernaum

A Gentile officer whose faith in Jesus' word made Jesus marvel.

The centurion of Capernaum was a military officer, a Gentile living among Jews in Galilee. Unusually, the local Jewish elders spoke well of him: he loved their nation and had built their synagogue. When a servant he valued lay sick and close to death, he asked Jesus for help. Yet he did not think himself worthy to have Jesus under his roof. As a soldier he understood authority, and he believed Jesus only had to give the word. Jesus marvelled and said he had not found such great faith in Israel. The servant was healed that same hour, a foretaste of the nations coming to Christ.

At a glance

Name	Not given in Scripture
Rank	Centurion, an officer over about a hundred soldiers
People	A Gentile who loved the Jewish nation (Luke 7:5, 9)
Home	Capernaum, on the north shore of the Sea of Galilee
Known for	Building a synagogue, and trusting Jesus to heal from a distance
When	c. AD 28–29, early in Jesus' ministry in Galilee
Main passages	Matthew 8:5–13; Luke 7:1–10

"The centurion answered and said, Lord, I am not worthy that thou shouldest come under my roof: but speak the word only, and my servant shall be healed."

Matthew 8:8, KJV

The life of The centurion of Capernaum

The date is approximate (AD) and follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30. Both Gospels place the story soon after Jesus' great sermon, when he returns to Capernaum.

Before Jesus came

Builds a synagogue

Stationed at Capernaum, the centurion comes to love the Jewish nation. He builds the town a synagogue, and the elders of the Jews speak warmly of him. *Luke 7:4–5*

c. AD 28–29
Capernaum

His servant is dying

A servant who is dear to him lies at home, sick of the palsy and grievously tormented, ready to die. Hearing of Jesus, he sends elders of the Jews to ask Jesus to come and heal him. *Matthew 8:5–6; Luke 7:2–3*

Near the house

Speak the word only

As Jesus comes near, the centurion sends friends with a message. He is not worthy for Jesus to enter his house. Like a soldier under orders, a word from Jesus will be enough. *Luke 7:6–8; Matthew 8:8–9*

The same hour

Healed from a distance

Jesus marvels and says he has not found so great faith, no, not in Israel. He says, "as thou hast believed, so be it done unto thee," and the servant is healed. *Matthew 8:10–13; Luke 7:9–10*

Group notes

Key activities

Matthew says the centurion came to Jesus himself. Luke says he sent Jewish elders and then friends. Many readers explain that people often spoke of someone doing what he did through messengers. Others see two ways of telling one story. John 4:46–54, about a nobleman's son, is usually treated as a different event.

1. **Loved another nation.** Though a Gentile officer, he loved the Jewish people and built their synagogue. *Luke 7:4–5*
2. **Cared for his servant.** He treated a sick servant as someone dear to him, not as property to replace. *Luke 7:2; Matthew 8:6*
3. **Asked for help.** He sent respected Jewish elders to plead with Jesus on his behalf. *Luke 7:3–4*
4. **Confessed his unworthiness.** The elders said he was worthy, but he said, "I am not worthy." *Luke 7:4, 6–7; Matthew 8:8*
5. **Understood authority.** He said he was "a man under authority, having soldiers under me," and saw that Jesus' word had authority over sickness. *Matthew 8:9*
6. **Amazed Jesus.** Jesus marvelled at him, which the Gospels record only here and at the unbelief of Nazareth. *Matthew 8:10; Luke 7:9; Mark 6:6*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names the centurion.

Old Testament

Echoes	Naaman, a Gentile army commander, is healed at a word through Elisha, without the prophet touching him (2 Kings 5:9–14). "He sent his word, and healed them" (Psalm 107:20). Many nations will come up to the mountain of the Lord (Isaiah 2:2–3).

New Testament

Matthew 8:5–13	Jesus adds that many will come from the east and west and sit down with Abraham, Isaac and Jacob.
Luke 7:1–10	Luke tells of the elders' and friends' messages.
Echoes	Other centurions in the New Testament: the one at the cross who said, "Truly this man was the Son of God" (Mark 15:39); Cornelius, the first Gentile convert in Acts (Acts 10:1–48); and Julius, who treated Paul kindly (Acts 27:1–3, 43).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did the Jewish elders say about the centurion, and what did he say about himself (Luke 7:4–7)?
2. *Understand:* What did the centurion understand about Jesus' authority that others missed?
3. *Apply:* The centurion used his position to help people outside his own group. How could you use your influence for someone different from you this week?
4. *Apply:* Where do you find it hard to trust God's word without seeing results first? Name one situation to pray about this week.

141 Zacchaeus

A rich tax collector who climbed a tree to see Jesus and came down a changed man.

Zacchaeus was the chief tax collector in Jericho, and he was rich. People despised tax collectors as cheats who worked for Rome, and Zacchaeus was at the top of that trade. When Jesus passed through Jericho on his way to Jerusalem, Zacchaeus was too short to see over the crowd, so he ran ahead and climbed a sycomore tree. Jesus stopped, called him by name, and invited himself to his house. The crowd grumbled, but Zacchaeus stood up and promised to give half his goods to the poor and repay fourfold anyone he had cheated. Jesus said salvation had come to his house.

At a glance

Name	From a Hebrew name usually explained as "pure"
Job	"Chief among the publicans," a senior tax collector (Luke 19:2)
Wealth	"He was rich" (Luke 19:2)
Home	Jericho
When	c. AD 30, days before Jesus' final Passover
Known for	Climbing a sycomore tree, and giving back what he had taken
Main passages	Luke 19:1–10
New Testament	Only in Luke

"For the Son of man is come to seek and to save that which was lost."

Luke 19:10, KJV

The life of Zacchaeus

The date is approximate (AD) and follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30. Luke sets the story on Jesus' last journey up to Jerusalem (Luke 19:11, 28).

c. AD 30
Jericho

Tries to see Jesus

Jesus passes through Jericho. Zacchaeus wants to see who Jesus is but cannot because of the crowd, for he is "little of stature." He runs ahead and climbs a sycomore tree. *Luke 19:1–4*

The same day

Called by name

At the tree Jesus looks up: "Zacchaeus, make haste, and come down; for to day I must abide at thy house." Zacchaeus hurries down and receives him joyfully. *Luke 19:5–6*

The same day

The crowd murmurs

Everyone who sees it complains that Jesus has gone "to be guest with a man that is a sinner." To them, a chief tax collector is beyond the pale. *Luke 19:7*

At his house

A changed man

Zacchaeus stands and promises half his goods to the poor and fourfold repayment to anyone he has cheated. Jesus says, "This day is salvation come to this house." *Luke 19:8–10*

Group notes

Key activities

Zacchaeus's words in Luke 19:8 can be read two ways. Most take them as a promise of change from that day. Some read them as a description of what he already did, defending himself against the crowd. Either way, Jesus declares that salvation has come.

1. **Sought Jesus.** He wanted to see who Jesus was, and he did not let the crowd stop him. *Luke 19:3*
2. **Climbed a tree.** He ran ahead and climbed a sycomore, setting aside his dignity to catch a glimpse. *Luke 19:4*
3. **Welcomed Jesus joyfully.** He came down at once and received Jesus into his home. *Luke 19:6*
4. **Gave to the poor.** He pledged half of his goods to the poor. *Luke 19:8*
5. **Promised to repay fourfold.** He offered to restore four times over anything taken by false accusation, far more than the law usually required. *Luke 19:8; Numbers 5:7*
6. **Heard a new name.** Jesus called him "a son of Abraham," a true member of God's people. *Luke 19:9*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Zacchaeus.

Old Testament

Exodus 22:1; 2 Samuel 12:6	Fourfold repayment, the measure Zacchaeus chose
Leviticus 6:1–5; Numbers 5:6–7	The usual repayment: the full amount plus a fifth
Echo: Ezekiel 34:16	"I will seek that which was lost"

New Testament

Luke 19:1–10	The only account
Luke 3:12–13	John tells tax collectors to exact no more than appointed
Luke 5:27–32; 15:1–2	Jesus eats with tax collectors and sinners
Echo: Matthew 9:9	Matthew, another tax collector, follows Jesus
Echo: Luke 15	The lost sheep, coin and son are found

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Zacchaeus do to see Jesus, and what did Jesus say to him (Luke 19:3–5)?
2. *Understand:* Why did the crowd murmur, and how does Luke 19:10 answer them?
3. *Apply:* Zacchaeus made things right with what he had wrongly taken. Is there something you need to set right with someone this week?
4. *Apply:* Who in your community is treated like Zacchaeus, and how could you welcome them?

142 Bartimaeus

A blind beggar who would not be silenced, received his sight, and followed Jesus.

Bartimaeus was a blind man who sat begging by the road outside Jericho. When he heard that Jesus of Nazareth was passing by, he began to shout, "Jesus, thou son of David, have mercy on me." The crowd told him to be quiet, but he shouted all the more. Jesus stopped and called for him. Bartimaeus threw off his cloak, jumped up, and came. Jesus asked what he wanted, and he said simply that he wanted to see. Jesus told him his faith had made him whole, and at once he could see. Then he followed Jesus on the road to Jerusalem. Mark alone gives his name, perhaps because early Christians knew him.

At a glance

Name	Bartimaeus, "the son of Timaeus" (Mark 10:46)
Situation	Blind, sitting "by the highway side begging" (Mark 10:46)
Place	The road at Jericho
When	c. AD 30, on Jesus' last journey to Jerusalem
Called Jesus	"Son of David," a title for the Messiah (Mark 10:47)
After his healing	"Followed Jesus in the way" (Mark 10:52)
Main passages	Mark 10:46–52; Matthew 20:29–34; Luke 18:35–43

"And Jesus said unto him, Go thy way; thy faith hath made thee whole. And immediately he received his sight, and followed Jesus in the way."

Mark 10:52, KJV

The life of Bartimaeus

The date is approximate (AD) and follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30. Mark sets the healing as Jesus leaves Jericho, just days before he enters Jerusalem.

c. AD 30
Leaving Jericho

Cries out

A great crowd follows Jesus out of Jericho. Blind Bartimaeus hears that it is Jesus of Nazareth and cries out, "Jesus, thou son of David, have mercy on me." *Mark 10:46–47*

On the road

Refuses to be silenced

Many in the crowd sternly tell him to hold his peace. Instead, he cries out "the more a great deal," calling again on the Son of David for mercy. *Mark 10:48*

On the road

Called

Jesus stands still and tells them to call him. The people say, "Be of good comfort, rise; he calleth thee." Casting away his garment, Bartimaeus rises and comes to Jesus. *Mark 10:49–50*

On the road

Sees and follows

Jesus asks, "What wilt thou that I should do unto thee?" He answers, "Lord, that I might receive my sight." He is healed at once and follows Jesus. *Mark 10:51–52*

Group notes

Key activities

Matthew tells of two blind men, and Luke places the healing as Jesus comes near Jericho rather than as he leaves. Suggested explanations include the two Jerichos of the time, the old town and Herod's newer one nearby, or Mark naming only the better-known man. Christians differ on how best to fit the accounts together.

1. **Listened.** Though he could not see, he heard who was passing and knew what it meant. *Mark 10:47*
2. **Called Jesus Son of David.** He used a royal title for the Messiah before anyone in the crowd did. *Mark 10:47*
3. **Persisted.** When many told him to be quiet, he cried out even louder. *Mark 10:48*
4. **Threw off his garment.** He cast away his cloak and came to Jesus at once. *Mark 10:50*
5. **Asked plainly.** He named exactly what he wanted: to receive his sight. *Mark 10:51*
6. **Followed.** Once he could see, he followed Jesus along the road toward Jerusalem. *Mark 10:52*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Bartimaeus.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 7:12–16	David's lasting throne, behind the title "son of David"
Echo: Psalm 146:8; Isaiah 35:5; 42:7	The LORD opens the eyes of the blind

New Testament

Mark 10:46–52	The main account, which alone gives his name
Matthew 20:29–34	Two blind men by the way side, whom Jesus touches
Luke 18:35–43	A blind man near Jericho healed; the people praise God
Luke 4:18	Jesus sent to preach "recovering of sight to the blind"
Echo: Mark 10:36	Jesus asks James and John a similar question
Echo: John 9:1–7	Jesus heals a man born blind

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Bartimaeus do when the crowd told him to be quiet (Mark 10:48)?
2. *Understand:* Jesus could see that he was blind. Why do you think he still asked, "What wilt thou that I should do unto thee?"
3. *Apply:* If Jesus asked you that same question today, what would you honestly say?
4. *Apply:* Bartimaeus threw off his cloak to come to Jesus. What would you need to set aside this week to follow Jesus more closely?

143 Caiaphas

The high priest who judged it expedient that one man should die for the people.

Caiaphas was the high priest in Jerusalem through the whole of Jesus' ministry. He was the son-in-law of Annas, an earlier high priest, and he held the office for about eighteen years under Roman rule. After Jesus raised Lazarus, Caiaphas told the council that it was better for one man to die than for the whole nation to perish. John says he spoke more truly than he knew. Caiaphas presided at Jesus' night trial, put him under oath, tore his clothes at his answer, and sent him to Pontius Pilate. Weeks later he sat in judgment on Peter and John. He is a picture of religious power protecting itself, and of God's purpose working even through its opponents.

At a glance

Name	Caiaphas. The Jewish historian Josephus calls him Joseph Caiaphas
Office	High priest in Jerusalem, c. AD 18–36
Family	Son-in-law of Annas, a former high priest (John 18:13)
Party	Probably a Sadducee, like the high priest's circle in Acts 5:17
Key places	Jerusalem: the temple and his palace (Matthew 26:3, 57)
Key people	Annas, the council, Jesus, Pilate, Peter, John
Main passages	Matthew 26:57–68; John 11:47–53; 18:13–28; Acts 4

"Now Caiaphas was he, which gave counsel to the Jews, that it was expedient that one man should die for the people."

John 18:14, KJV

The life of Caiaphas

Dates are approximate (AD). His years in office come from Josephus. Gospel events follow the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30; on the other main view (AD 33), add about three years.

c. AD 28–29
In office

High priest when John preaches

Luke dates John the Baptist's call to a time when "Annas and Caiaphas" were high priests. Caiaphas holds the office, while his father-in-law Annas keeps great influence. *Luke 3:1–2*

c. AD 30
After Lazarus

Counsels Jesus' death

After Lazarus is raised, the council fears that the Romans will take away "both our place and nation." Caiaphas says it is expedient that one man die for the people. *John 11:47–53*

c. AD 30
Before Passover

Plots at his palace

The chief priests, scribes and elders gather at the palace of the high priest, Caiaphas. They agree to take Jesus by subtlety and kill him, but not on the feast day. *Matthew 26:3–5*

c. AD 30
Night

Tries Jesus

Jesus is sent bound from Annas to Caiaphas. False witnesses disagree. Caiaphas puts Jesus under oath, hears his answer, tears his clothes and declares it blasphemy. *John 18:24; Matthew 26:57–66*

c. AD 30
Morning

Sends Jesus to Pilate

In the morning the council binds Jesus and leads him from Caiaphas to the Roman governor's hall of judgment. *Matthew 27:1–2; John 18:28*

c. AD 30
Weeks later

Questions the apostles

With Annas and others, he questions Peter and John about healing a lame man. The council forbids them to speak or teach in Jesus' name. *Acts 4:5–21*

Key activities

Luke 3:2 and Acts 4:6 speak of Annas as high priest alongside Caiaphas. Annas had held the office earlier (c. AD 6–15, according to Josephus) and kept the title and much influence. Readers differ on exactly how the two shared authority.

1. **Held the high priesthood.** He was "the high priest that same year," the year of Jesus' death. *John 11:49; 18:13*
2. **Spoke an unknowing prophecy.** John says he spoke "not of himself," but prophesied that Jesus would die for the nation and gather God's scattered children. *John 11:49–52*
3. **Plotted in secret.** He hosted the leaders who planned to arrest Jesus quietly. *Matthew 26:3–4*
4. **Put Jesus under oath.** "I adjure thee by the living God, that thou tell us whether thou be the Christ, the Son of God." *Matthew 26:63–64*
5. **Tore his clothes.** He rent his clothes, said Jesus had spoken blasphemy, and the council judged him worthy of death. *Matthew 26:65–66*
6. **Handed Jesus to Rome.** He sent Jesus on to Pilate, since the council could not lawfully put anyone to death. *John 18:28–31*
7. **Opposed the apostles.** He sat with the council that threatened Peter and John. *Acts 4:6, 18–21*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Caiaphas.

Old Testament

Echo: Exodus 28:29	The high priest bears Israel's names before the Lord
Echo: Isaiah 53:8	The servant "stricken" for the transgression of the people

New Testament

Luke 3:2	Named in Luke's dating of John the Baptist
John 11:47–53; 18:13–28	His counsel; Jesus sent from Annas to him and on to Pilate
Matthew 26:3–5, 57–68	The plot and the night trial (Mark 14:53–65 omits his name)
Acts 4:5–22	Among those who question Peter and John
Acts 5:17–40; 9:1–2	An unnamed high priest, probably Caiaphas if before c. AD 36
Echo: Hebrews 7:26–27	Jesus, the true high priest, offered once for all

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reason did the council give for wanting to stop Jesus (John 11:47–48)?
2. *Understand:* John says Caiaphas prophesied without knowing it (John 11:51). What does that show about God's purposes?
3. *Apply:* Caiaphas chose what seemed safe for his position over what was true. Where are you tempted to do the same?
4. *Apply:* Jesus stayed silent before false witnesses (Matthew 26:62–63). How could you respond with restraint to an unfair criticism this week?

144 Pontius Pilate

The Roman governor who found no fault in Jesus and handed him over to be crucified.

Pontius Pilate was the Roman governor of Judea from AD 26 to 36. He held the power of life and death, and so Jesus' trial ended before him. All four Gospels show a man who questioned Jesus, found no fault in him, and tried several ways to let him go. He sent him to Herod, offered the crowd Barabbas, and had him scourged in the hope that it would be enough. In the end he gave way to pressure, washed his hands, and handed Jesus over to be crucified. He is the only Roman official named in the ancient Christian creeds. His question, "What is truth?", still hangs in the air.

At a glance

Name	Pontius Pilatus, in Latin
Office	Roman prefect, or governor, of Judea, AD 26–36
Base	Caesarea on the coast; in Jerusalem at the great feasts
Emperor	Tiberius (Luke 3:1)
Family	A wife who warned him about Jesus (Matthew 27:19)
Key people	Jesus, Caiaphas and the chief priests, Herod Antipas, Barabbas, Joseph of Arimathea
Main passages	Matthew 27; Mark 15; Luke 23; John 18:28–19:42
Later mentions	Acts 3:13; 4:27; 13:28; 1 Timothy 6:13

> *"Pilate saith unto him, What is truth? And when he had said this, he went out again unto the Jews, and saith unto them, I find in him no fault at all."*
>
> John 18:38, KJV

The life of Pontius Pilate

His years in office (AD 26–36) come from Josephus. Gospel events follow the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30; on the other main view, AD 33.

c. AD 28–29
Governor of Judaea

Named in Luke's dating

Luke dates John the Baptist's call to the fifteenth year of the emperor Tiberius, "Pontius Pilate being governor of Judaea." *Luke 3:1*

Before AD 30
Jerusalem

Blood at the altar

Some tell Jesus of Galileans "whose blood Pilate had mingled with their sacrifices." Jesus uses the news to call his hearers to repent. Scripture gives no other details. *Luke 13:1–3*

c. AD 30
Friday dawn

Questions Jesus

The chief priests bring Jesus, accused of claiming to be a king. Pilate examines him and finds no fault. Hearing that he is a Galilean, he sends him to Herod Antipas. *Luke 23:1–7; John 18:28–38*

c. AD 30
Friday morning

Offers Barabbas

Hoping to release Jesus, he offers the crowd a choice of prisoner. His wife sends a warning after a dream. The chief priests stir the crowd, who ask for Barabbas. *Matthew 27:15–21*

c. AD 30
Friday morning

Washes his hands

He has Jesus scourged and says, "Behold the man!" Fearing a riot and the charge of disloyalty to Caesar, he washes his hands before the crowd and hands Jesus over. *John 19:1–16; Matthew 27:24–26*

c. AD 30
Friday and Saturday

Title, body and guard

He refuses to change the title "THE KING OF THE JEWS," grants Jesus' body to Joseph of Arimathea, and lets the chief priests seal and guard the tomb. *John 19:19–22, 38; Matthew 27:62–66*

Key activities

Jesus told Pilate, "Thou couldest have no power at all against me, except it were given thee from above" (John 19:11). The Gospels show Pilate as both unwilling and responsible, and Acts 4:27–28 places the whole event within God's purpose.

1. **Examined Jesus.** He asked, "Art thou the King of the Jews?" and heard that Jesus' kingdom was not of this world. *John 18:33–37*
2. **Asked about truth.** He asked, "What is truth?" and went out without waiting for an answer. *John 18:38*
3. **Declared him innocent.** Three times he said he found no fault in Jesus. *Luke 23:4, 14, 22*
4. **Sent him to Herod.** He tried to pass the case to Herod Antipas, who sent Jesus back. *Luke 23:6–12*
5. **Offered Barabbas.** He hoped the crowd would choose Jesus, but they chose Barabbas. *Mark 15:6–15*
6. **Washed his hands.** He said, "I am innocent of the blood of this just person: see ye to it." *Matthew 27:24*
7. **Gave in to pressure.** When the crowd cried, "If thou let this man go, thou art not Caesar's friend," he delivered Jesus to be crucified. *John 19:12–16*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Pilate.

Old Testament

Psalm 2:1–2	Rulers against the LORD's anointed; applied to Pilate (Acts 4:25–27)
Echo: Isaiah 53:7	Like a sheep before her shearers, he is silent
Echo: Deuteronomy 21:6–7	Elders wash their hands to declare innocence of blood

New Testament

Matthew 27; Mark 15; Luke 23; John 18:28–19:42	The four trial accounts
Luke 3:1; 13:1	Pilate as governor, and the Galileans he killed
Acts 3:13; 4:27; 13:28	The apostles name his part in Jesus' death
1 Timothy 6:13	Christ's good confession before Pontius Pilate
Tradition	The Apostles' Creed: Jesus "suffered under Pontius Pilate"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How many times does Pilate say he finds no fault in Jesus (Luke 23:4, 14, 22)?
2. *Understand:* Pilate washed his hands, but was he free of responsibility? Why or why not?
3. *Apply:* Pilate knew what was right but feared the crowd. Where do you feel pressure to go along with others against your conscience?
4. *Apply:* Pilate asked, "What is truth?" and walked away. What truth do you need to stop and face this week?

145 Herod Antipas

The ruler of Galilee who beheaded John the Baptist and mocked Jesus.

Herod Antipas, a son of Herod the Great, ruled Galilee and Perea for more than forty years, the region where Jesus grew up and did most of his ministry. The Gospels show a man pulled in two directions. He feared John the Baptist and liked to hear him, yet imprisoned him for condemning his marriage and beheaded him to keep a rash oath. He wanted to see Jesus do a miracle, yet when Jesus stood before him, Herod mocked him. Jesus called him "that fox." His life shows how curiosity about God can harden into contempt.

At a glance

Name	Herod Antipas, "Herod the tetrarch" (Luke 3:19)
Family	Son of Herod the Great; brother of Archelaus (Matthew 2:22)
Office	Tetrarch of Galilee and Perea, 4 BC–AD 39
Wife	Herodias, formerly his brother's wife (Mark 6:17)
Cities	Rebuilt Sepphoris; founded Tiberias
Key people	John the Baptist, Herodias, Jesus, Pontius Pilate
Main passages	Mark 6:14–29; Luke 3:19–20; 9:7–9; 13:31–33; 23:6–12
Jesus called him	"That fox" (Luke 13:32)

> *"And when Herod saw Jesus, he was exceeding glad: for he was desirous to see him of a long season, because he had heard many things of him; and he hoped to have seen some miracle done by him."*
>
> Luke 23:8, KJV

The life of Herod Antipas

Dates are approximate. His reign and exile come from Josephus. Gospel events follow the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30; on the other main view (AD 33), add about three years.

c. 4 BC
After his father's death

Becomes tetrarch

When Herod the Great dies, Rome divides his kingdom among his sons. Antipas receives Galilee and Perea. Luke later dates John's ministry by him: "Herod being tetrarch of Galilee." *Luke 3:1*

c. AD 28–29
Galilee

Imprisons John

John rebukes Herod for taking Herodias, his brother's wife, "and for all the evils which Herod had done." Herod shuts John up in prison. *Luke 3:19–20; Mark 6:17–18*

c. AD 29
His birthday

Beheads John

At a birthday feast Herodias' daughter dances, and Herod swears to give her whatever she asks. Prompted by her mother, she asks for John's head. Herod, "exceeding sorry," sends an executioner. *Mark 6:21–28*

c. AD 29
Galilee

Troubled by Jesus

Hearing of Jesus' works, Herod is perplexed. He says, "It is John, whom I beheaded: he is risen from the dead," and he wants to see Jesus. *Mark 6:14–16; Luke 9:7–9*

c. AD 29–30
On the road

Threatens Jesus

Some Pharisees warn Jesus that Herod wants to kill him. Jesus replies, "Go ye, and tell that fox," and continues his work on the way to Jerusalem. *Luke 13:31–33*

c. AD 30
Crucifixion day

Mocks Jesus

Pilate sends Jesus to Herod, who is in Jerusalem. Herod questions him at length, but Jesus answers nothing. Herod and his soldiers mock him, dress him in a gorgeous robe, and send him back. *Luke 23:6–12*

Key activities

Mark 6:17 calls Herodias's first husband Philip, while Josephus calls him Herod. Many think he had both names, and he is not the same as Philip the tetrarch of Luke 3:1. Herodias's daughter is not named in Scripture; Josephus names her Salome.

1. **Ruled Galilee.** He governed the region where Jesus lived and ministered. *Luke 3:1; 23:6–7*
2. **Took his brother's wife.** He married Herodias, which John said was not lawful. *Mark 6:17–18*
3. **Listened to John.** He feared John as a just and holy man and heard him gladly, yet did not change. *Mark 6:20*
4. **Kept a foolish oath.** Rather than lose face before his guests, he kept a rash promise. *Mark 6:22–26*
5. **Killed John.** He had John beheaded in prison, and John's disciples buried the body. *Mark 6:27–29*
6. **Wanted to see Jesus.** He was curious and hoped to see a miracle. *Luke 9:9; 23:8*
7. **Mocked the silent Jesus.** When Jesus would not answer, Herod set him at nought and mocked him. *Luke 23:9–11*
8. **Made friends with Pilate.** That same day he and Pilate, once enemies, became friends. *Luke 23:12*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Herod Antipas.

Old Testament

Leviticus 18:16; 20:21	No taking a brother's wife, behind John's rebuke
Psalm 2:1–2	Applied to Herod and Pilate (Acts 4:25–27)
Echo: 1 Kings 19:1–2; 21:17–24	Ahab and Jezebel against the prophet Elijah
Echo: Esther 5:3	A king offers "to the half of the kingdom" (Mark 6:23)

New Testament

Matthew 14:1–12; Mark 6:14–29	The death of John the Baptist
Luke 3:1, 19–20; 9:7–9; 13:31–33; 23:6–12	Luke's fuller portrait
Luke 8:3; Acts 13:1	Joanna, wife of his steward, and Manaen, raised with him
Acts 4:27	Named among those gathered against Jesus
Mark 8:15	"The leaven of Herod"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Herod think of John, according to Mark 6:20?
2. *Understand:* Herod liked to hear John but would not change. Why is that so dangerous?
3. *Apply:* Herod kept a rash promise to save face. Is there a promise you should rethink, or be slower to make?
4. *Apply:* Herod wanted a miracle, not a Master. How can you come to Jesus this week for who he is, not only what he can do?

146 Barabbas

The guilty prisoner who walked free while Jesus was crucified.

Barabbas was a prisoner in Jerusalem when Jesus was brought to trial. The Gospels call him a notable prisoner, a robber, and a man jailed for insurrection and murder. At Passover the Roman governor customarily released one prisoner the people asked for. Pontius Pilate, sure that Jesus was innocent, offered the crowd a choice between Barabbas and Jesus. Urged on by the chief priests, the crowd cried out for Barabbas. So a man who had taken life went free, and the man who gave life was led away to die. Scripture tells us nothing about Barabbas before his arrest or after his release. Yet his brief moment has made him one of the best-known names of the Passion.

At a glance

Name	Barabbas, from Aramaic words meaning "son of the father"
Charge	Sedition, or insurrection, and murder (Luke 23:19; Mark 15:7)
Also called	"A notable prisoner" (Matthew 27:16) and "a robber" (John 18:40)
Place	Jerusalem, in Roman custody
When	Released c. AD 30, at Passover
Key people	Pontius Pilate, the chief priests, the crowd, Jesus
Main passages	Matthew 27:15–26; Mark 15:6–15; Luke 23:18–25; John 18:39–40

"Then cried they all again, saying, Not this man, but Barabbas. Now Barabbas was a robber."

John 18:40, KJV

The life of Barabbas

The date follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30; on the other main view, AD 33. Scripture tells us nothing about Barabbas before his arrest or after his release.

Before Passover
Jerusalem

Arrested

An insurrection breaks out in the city, and murder is done in it. Barabbas lies bound in prison with others who took part in the uprising. *Mark 15:7; Luke 23:19*

c. AD 30
Passover morning

Offered for release

At the feast the governor usually releases one prisoner of the people's choosing. Pilate asks, "Whom will ye that I release unto you? Barabbas, or Jesus which is called Christ?" *Matthew 27:15–17; Mark 15:6–9*

The same morning

Chosen by the crowd

The chief priests and elders persuade the crowd to ask for Barabbas and to destroy Jesus. They cry out, "Not this man, but Barabbas." *Matthew 27:20–21; John 18:40*

The same morning

Set free

Pilate, "willing to content the people," releases Barabbas to them. He has Jesus scourged and hands him over to be crucified. *Mark 15:15; Luke 23:24–25*

Group notes

Key activities

Some early manuscripts of Matthew 27:16–17 call him "Jesus Barabbas," which would make Pilate's question a choice between two men named Jesus. The KJV does not include this reading, and scholars are divided about it.

1. **Joined an insurrection.** He was held with rebels who had risen up in the city. *Mark 15:7*
2. **Was jailed for murder.** Luke says he was in prison "for a certain sedition made in the city, and for murder." *Luke 23:19*
3. **Became a notorious name.** Matthew calls him "a notable prisoner," someone the crowd already knew. *Matthew 27:16*
4. **Was set against Jesus.** Pilate placed him beside Jesus and asked the crowd to choose. *Matthew 27:17*
5. **Went free in Jesus' place.** Pilate released the man guilty of sedition and murder, and delivered Jesus to their will. *Mark 15:15; Luke 23:25*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Barabbas.

Old Testament

Echo: Isaiah 53:5	"He was wounded for our transgressions"
Echo: Leviticus 16:7–10, 21–22	One goat dies, one goes free; some compare the choice

New Testament

Matthew 27:15–26; Mark 15:6–15; Luke 23:18–25; John 18:39–40	All four tell of the choice
Acts 3:14	Peter: they "desired a murderer to be granted unto you"
Echo: 1 Peter 3:18	"The just for the unjust"; Barabbas as every sinner freed is application, not text

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How do the Gospels describe Barabbas (Mark 15:7; Luke 23:19; John 18:40)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think the crowd chose Barabbas over Jesus?
3. *Apply:* Barabbas went free while Jesus died. How does that picture help you understand 1 Peter 3:18?
4. *Apply:* Scripture does not say what Barabbas did with his freedom. What is one way you will use your freedom in Christ to serve someone this week?

147 Simon of Cyrene

A passer-by from Africa who was made to carry Jesus' cross.

Simon of Cyrene appears in only one verse in each of three Gospels. He was a man from Cyrene in North Africa, coming into Jerusalem "out of the country," when he met the procession leading Jesus to be crucified. The Roman soldiers seized him and forced him to carry Jesus' cross. Luke adds that he carried it "after Jesus," walking behind him. Mark names Simon's sons, Alexander and Rufus, as if his first readers knew them. That small detail has led many to think Simon's family later became believers. Simon did not choose his burden, but it put him closer to Jesus on the road to the cross than anyone else. His brief moment has become a picture of what it means to follow Jesus.

At a glance

Name	Simon, "a Cyrenian" (Mark 15:21)
Home	Cyrene, a city in North Africa, in modern Libya
Family	Father of Alexander and Rufus (Mark 15:21)
When	c. AD 30, the day of the crucifixion
Where	On the road out of Jerusalem to Golgotha
Known for	Carrying Jesus' cross
Main passages	Matthew 27:32; Mark 15:21; Luke 23:26

"And they compel one Simon a Cyrenian, who passed by, coming out of the country, the father of Alexander and Rufus, to bear his cross."

Mark 15:21, KJV

The life of Simon of Cyrene

The date follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30; on the other main view, AD 33. Scripture tells only this one episode of Simon's life.

Earlier

A man of Cyrene

Simon comes from Cyrene in North Africa. Scripture does not say whether he lived in Jerusalem or had come as a pilgrim for Passover. Jews from Cyrene were among those in Jerusalem at the feasts. *Mark 15:21; Acts 2:10*

c. AD 30
Friday morning

Coming in from the country

As the soldiers lead Jesus out to be crucified, Simon is passing by, "coming out of the country," and meets the procession on the road. *Mark 15:20–21; Luke 23:26*

The same hour

Compelled to carry the cross

The soldiers lay hold on Simon and compel him to bear Jesus' cross. Luke says they laid it on him "that he might bear it after Jesus." *Matthew 27:32; Luke 23:26*

The same hour

At Golgotha

They bring Jesus to Golgotha, which is, being interpreted, "The place of a skull." There they offer him wine mingled with myrrh and crucify him. *Mark 15:22–24*

Group notes

Key activities

John 19:17 says Jesus went out "bearing his cross," while the other Gospels say Simon carried it. Many readers conclude that Jesus carried it at first and Simon took it over on the way.

1. **Passed by.** He was simply on his way into the city when he met the procession. *Mark 15:21*
2. **Was compelled.** The soldiers forced him into service; he did not volunteer. *Matthew 27:32*
3. **Carried the cross.** He bore the cross that had been laid on Jesus. *Luke 23:26*
4. **Walked behind Jesus.** Luke pictures him carrying the cross "after Jesus," the posture of a follower. *Luke 23:26*
5. **Was remembered by name.** Mark named him and his sons, as if Alexander and Rufus were known to the church. *Mark 15:21*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Simon of Cyrene.

Old Testament

Echoes	Isaac carries the wood for the offering up the mountain (Genesis 22:6). "Surely he hath borne our griefs, and carried our sorrows" (Isaiah 53:4).

New Testament

Matthew 27:32; Mark 15:21; Luke 23:26	Three short accounts of Simon carrying the cross.
John 19:17	Jesus goes out bearing his cross.
Romans 16:13	Paul greets "Rufus chosen in the Lord, and his mother and mine." He may be Simon's son.
Acts 2:10; 6:9; 11:20; 13:1	Men of Cyrene are present at Pentecost, oppose Stephen, preach at Antioch, and lead in the church there.
Echoes	"If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow me" (Luke 9:23). "Bear ye one another's burdens" (Galatians 6:2).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What details does Mark give about Simon that Matthew and Luke leave out (Mark 15:21)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Mark mentions Alexander and Rufus?
3. *Apply:* Simon did not choose his burden, yet it put him close to Jesus. How has an unwanted burden drawn you closer to God?
4. *Apply:* Whose burden could you help carry this week (Galatians 6:2)?

148 The thief on the cross

A dying criminal who asked Jesus to remember him and heard, "To day shalt thou be with me in paradise."

Two criminals were crucified with Jesus, one on each side. Matthew and Mark say both of them joined in mocking him. But Luke records that one of them spoke up. When the other railed at Jesus, he rebuked him: they were getting what they deserved, "but this man hath done nothing amiss." Then he turned to Jesus and asked, "Lord, remember me when thou comest into thy kingdom." Jesus promised that he would be with him in paradise that very day. We do not know his name, his crime, or his past. He could offer Jesus nothing but a request, and his story is one of Scripture's clearest pictures of grace.

At a glance

Name	Not given in Scripture. Tradition calls him Dismas
Called	A "malefactor" (Luke 23:32, 39) and a "thief" (Matthew 27:38, 44)
Crime	Not stated. He says his punishment is just (Luke 23:41)
Where	Golgotha, on a cross beside Jesus
When	c. AD 30, the day of the crucifixion
Known for	Asking Jesus to remember him; promised paradise
Main passages	Luke 23:32–43; Matthew 27:38, 44; Mark 15:27, 32

"And Jesus said unto him, Verily I say unto thee, To day shalt thou be with me in paradise."

Luke 23:43, KJV

The life of The thief on the cross

The date follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30; on the other main view, AD 33. Mark says Jesus was crucified at the third hour, and darkness fell from the sixth hour to the ninth (Mark 15:25, 33).

c. AD 30
Friday morning

Led out with Jesus

Two malefactors are led out with Jesus to be put to death. At the place called Calvary they are crucified, one on his right hand and the other on his left. *Luke 23:32–33*

On the cross

Joins the mocking

Matthew and Mark say that the thieves crucified with Jesus reviled him, joining the priests, the scribes and those passing by. *Matthew 27:44; Mark 15:32*

Before the ninth hour

Rebukes the other

One malefactor rails, "If thou be Christ, save thyself and us." The other rebukes him: they suffer justly, "but this man hath done nothing amiss." *Luke 23:39–41*

Before the ninth hour

Asks to be remembered

He says, "Lord, remember me when thou comest into thy kingdom." Jesus promises that he will be with him in paradise that very day. *Luke 23:42–43*

Before sunset

Dies

So that the bodies will not remain on the crosses on the sabbath, the soldiers break the legs of the two men crucified with Jesus. *John 19:31–32*

Group notes

Key activities

Matthew and Mark say both thieves reviled Jesus, while Luke says one did and one did not. Some think both mocked at first and one later changed; others think Matthew and Mark speak in general terms. The comma in Luke 23:43 is also debated. Most read "To day shalt thou be with me," while a few read "I say unto thee to day" as a solemn formula.

1. **Faced the truth.** He admitted, "we receive the due reward of our deeds." *Luke 23:41*
2. **Feared God.** He asked his fellow criminal, "Dost not thou fear God, seeing thou art in the same condemnation?" *Luke 23:40*
3. **Defended Jesus.** In the middle of the mockery, he said Jesus had done nothing wrong. *Luke 23:41*
4. **Called on Jesus as King.** He asked to be remembered when Jesus came into his kingdom. *Luke 23:42*
5. **Received a promise.** Jesus assured him that he would be with him in paradise that day. *Luke 23:43*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names the thief on the cross.

Old Testament

Isaiah 53:12	"Numbered with the transgressors" (Luke 22:37; Mark 15:28 KJV)
Deuteronomy 21:22–23	A body must not remain on a tree overnight
Echo: Genesis 40:14	Joseph asks the butler, "think on me"

New Testament

Luke 23:32–43	The only account of his request and Jesus' promise
Matthew 27:38, 44; Mark 15:27–32	Two thieves crucified with Jesus revile him
John 19:18, 31–33	Jesus between the two; their legs broken
Echo: 2 Corinthians 12:4; Revelation 2:7	Paradise mentioned again
Echo: Matthew 20:1–16	Eleventh-hour workers receive full pay

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What three things did the repentant thief say (Luke 23:40–42)?
2. *Understand:* The thief could offer Jesus nothing but a request. What does Jesus' answer show about grace?
3. *Apply:* The thief admitted, "we receive the due reward of our deeds." What would honest confession to God look like for you this week?
4. *Apply:* Is there someone you have written off as beyond God's reach? How could you pray for them by name this week?

149 Joseph of Arimathea

A rich member of the council who went boldly to Pilate and laid Jesus in his own tomb.

Joseph of Arimathea was a wealthy member of the Jewish council and a secret disciple of Jesus, afraid of the other leaders. He had not agreed with the council's plan to kill Jesus. On the afternoon Jesus died, with the sabbath hours away, Joseph stepped out of the shadows and boldly asked Pilate for the body. With Nicodemus he wrapped it in linen and spices and laid it in his own new rock tomb. All four Gospels tell of him, and his tomb became the place where the resurrection was first announced.

At a glance

Name	Joseph of Arimathaea, in the KJV spelling
Home	Arimathaea, "a city of the Jews"; site uncertain (Luke 23:51)
Position	"An honourable counsellor" of the council (Mark 15:43)
Wealth	"A rich man" (Matthew 27:57)
Faith	A disciple, "but secretly for fear of the Jews" (John 19:38)
Key people	Jesus, Pontius Pilate, Nicodemus, Mary Magdalene
Main passages	Matthew 27:57–60; Mark 15:42–46; Luke 23:50–54; John 19:38–42

"Joseph of Arimathaea, an honourable counsellor … went in boldly unto Pilate, and craved the body of Jesus."

Mark 15:43, KJV

The life of Joseph of Arimathea

The date follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30; on the other main view, AD 33. Joseph appears only on the day of Jesus' death, though Luke tells us how he had voted before.

Before the crucifixion
In the council

Refuses to consent

Joseph is "a good man, and a just," who waits for the kingdom of God. He has not agreed with the council's plan and action against Jesus. *Luke 23:50–51*

c. AD 30
Friday afternoon

Goes boldly to Pilate

It is the day of preparation, the day before the sabbath. Joseph goes in to Pilate and asks for the body. Pilate checks with the centurion that Jesus is dead, then gives it to him. *Mark 15:42–45*

c. AD 30
Before sunset

Takes down the body

Joseph buys fine linen and takes the body down. With Nicodemus, who brings myrrh and aloes, he winds it in linen with the spices, as the Jews bury their dead. *Mark 15:46; John 19:38–40*

c. AD 30
Before the sabbath

Lays Jesus in his tomb

In a garden near the place of crucifixion, he lays Jesus in "his own new tomb, which he had hewn out in the rock." He rolls a great stone to the door and departs. *Matthew 27:59–60; John 19:41–42*

Group notes

Key activities

Arimathaea's location is uncertain. Many identify it with Ramathaim-zophim, Samuel's hometown in the hill country of Ephraim (1 Samuel 1:1), but this is not certain.

1. **Waited for the kingdom.** He was looking for the kingdom of God, like Simeon and Anna before him. *Mark 15:43; Luke 23:51*
2. **Dissented in the council.** He had not consented to the council's decision against Jesus. *Luke 23:51*
3. **Followed secretly.** For a time he kept his faith hidden, out of fear of the other leaders. *John 19:38*
4. **Went in boldly.** He risked his standing by asking Pilate for the body of a condemned man. *Mark 15:43*
5. **Gave his own tomb.** He laid Jesus in a new tomb where no one had yet been laid. *Matthew 27:60; Luke 23:53*
6. **Worked with Nicodemus.** Together they prepared the body with linen and spices. *John 19:39–40*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Joseph of Arimathea.

Old Testament

Isaiah 53:9	"With the rich in his death," seen in the rich man's tomb
Deuteronomy 21:22–23	No body left on a tree overnight
Echo: Psalm 16:10	No corruption for the Holy One (Acts 2:27)

New Testament

Matthew 27:57–60; Mark 15:42–46; Luke 23:50–54; John 19:38–42	The burial
Matthew 28:1–6	The women find his tomb empty
Acts 13:29; 1 Corinthians 15:3–4	Laid in a sepulchre; buried and rose again
Echo: John 12:42–43	Rulers who believed but would not confess

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How does each Gospel describe Joseph (Matthew 27:57; Mark 15:43; Luke 23:50–51; John 19:38)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Joseph stepped forward only after Jesus had died?
3. *Apply:* Joseph had been a secret disciple. Where do you keep your faith quiet, and what would one bold step look like?
4. *Apply:* Joseph gave his own tomb. What costly gift could you offer to Jesus or to someone in need this month?

150 James, brother of Jesus

The brother who did not believe, then became a pillar of the Jerusalem church.

James grew up in the same house in Nazareth as Jesus, yet John says plainly that Jesus' brothers did not believe in him. After the resurrection Jesus appeared to James, and everything changed. Within a few years James was a leader of the Jerusalem church, one of the "pillars." At the Jerusalem council he gave the ruling that welcomed Gentile believers without making them keep the whole law of Moses. The letter of James, traditionally credited to him, is a plain call to live out what we believe.

At a glance

Name	Greek *Iakobos*, from the Hebrew name Jacob
Family	Brother of Jesus, Joses, Simon and Judas (Mark 6:3)
Known as	"James the Lord's brother" (Galatians 1:19); "the Just" (tradition)
When	Leader in Jerusalem c. AD 40s–62
Key places	Nazareth; Jerusalem
Key people	Jesus; Mary; Peter; Paul; Barnabas
Main passages	Acts 15:13–21; 21:18–25; Galatians 1:19; 2:9–12
Not the same as	James son of Zebedee or son of Alphaeus

"Even so faith, if it hath not works, is dead, being alone."

James 2:17, KJV

The life of James, brother of Jesus

Dates are approximate (AD). Acts and Galatians give the order of events, but not exact years. His death date comes from the Jewish historian Josephus.

c. AD 28–30
Jesus' ministry

Does not believe

James and his brothers watch Jesus' public work from close by. They urge him to show himself openly, and John adds that "neither did his brethren believe in him." *John 7:3–5; Mark 3:21, 31–35*

c. AD 30
After the resurrection

Meets the risen Lord

Paul lists James among the witnesses of the resurrection. The risen Jesus appears to him personally. Scripture does not tell us what was said. *1 Corinthians 15:7*

c. AD 30
Before Pentecost

Prays with the believers

In the upper room in Jerusalem, the brothers of Jesus pray with the apostles, the women and Mary his mother. They are now among his followers. *Acts 1:13–14*

c. AD 36–38
Paul's first visit

Meets Paul

Three years after his conversion, Paul spends fifteen days with Peter in Jerusalem. The only other leader he sees is "James the Lord's brother." *Galatians 1:18–19*

AD 44
Peter's escape

A recognized leader

After an angel frees Peter from Herod's prison, Peter tells the believers to report the news "unto James, and to the brethren," then leaves the city. *Acts 12:17*

c. AD 49
The Jerusalem council

Gives the ruling

When the church debates whether Gentile believers must be circumcised, James speaks last. He quotes Amos and proposes a letter asking only a few things of them. *Acts 15:13–29*

c. AD 57
Paul's last visit

Welcomes Paul

Paul reports what God has done among the Gentiles. James and the elders glorify God, then advise him on how to answer rumours among Jewish believers. *Acts 21:17–26*

Key activities

Christians have understood "the Lord's brother" in different ways. Many Protestants read it as a younger son of Mary and Joseph. Eastern Orthodox tradition sees a son of Joseph by an earlier marriage, and Roman Catholic tradition often a close relative or cousin.

1. **Doubted, then believed.** He did not believe during Jesus' ministry, but he was among the believers after the resurrection. *John 7:5; Acts 1:14*
2. **Saw the risen Christ.** Jesus appeared to him by name. *1 Corinthians 15:7*
3. **Led the Jerusalem church.** Peter sent word to him, and Paul called him a pillar. *Acts 12:17; Galatians 2:9*
4. **Welcomed Gentiles.** He judged "that we trouble not them, which from among the Gentiles are turned to God." *Acts 15:19*
5. **Gave Paul the right hand of fellowship.** With Peter and John he agreed that Paul and Barnabas should go to the Gentiles. *Galatians 2:9*
6. **Wrote to scattered believers.** The letter of James opens with "James, a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ." *James 1:1*
7. **Urged a working faith.** He called believers to be "doers of the word, and not hearers only." *James 1:22; 2:14–26*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names James.

Old Testament

Amos 9:11–12	Rebuilding David's tabernacle, quoted at the council (Acts 15:16–17)
Echo: Genesis 37; 42–45	Joseph's doubting brothers later bow before him

New Testament

Matthew 13:55; Mark 6:3; John 7:3–5	Heads the brothers' list; they do not believe
1 Corinthians 15:7	"After that, he was seen of James"
Acts 12:17; 15:13–21; 21:18	He leads the Jerusalem church
Galatians 1:19; 2:9, 12	Paul meets him and calls him a pillar
James 1:1; Jude 1	His letter (authorship debated); Jude, "brother of James"
Tradition	Josephus records his death in Jerusalem in AD 62

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Jesus' brothers say and do in John 7:3–5?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think the risen Jesus appeared to James in person (1 Corinthians 15:7)?
3. *Apply:* James once doubted his own brother. Who in your family is far from faith, and how can you pray for them?
4. *Apply:* Faith without works is dead. What one concrete act this week would put your faith into practice?

151 Stephen

The first Christian martyr, who died praying for those who killed him.

Stephen first appears as one of seven men chosen to make sure the widows of the Jerusalem church were fed fairly. He was known as a man "full of faith and of the Holy Ghost." But he did far more than serve tables. He did wonders among the people and argued so wisely that his opponents could not answer him. Brought before the council on false charges, he gave the longest speech in Acts, retelling Israel's story from Abraham to Solomon. When he said he saw Jesus standing at God's right hand, the crowd stoned him. He died praying for his killers. A young man named Saul watched, and the church was scattered far beyond Jerusalem.

At a glance

Name	Greek *Stephanos*, "crown" or "wreath"
Family	Not given
Role	One of the seven chosen to serve the widows (Acts 6:3–5)
When	Died c. AD 33–35
Key places	Jerusalem
Key people	The twelve apostles; Philip the evangelist and the other five; the high priest; Saul (Paul)
Main passages	Acts 6:1–8:2; 11:19; 22:20
Known as	The first Christian to die for his faith

"And they stoned Stephen, calling upon God, and saying, Lord Jesus, receive my spirit."

Acts 7:59, KJV

The life of Stephen

Dates are approximate (AD). Acts gives no year for Stephen's death. Most place it a few years after the resurrection, c. AD 33–35.

Early church
Jerusalem

Chosen as one of the seven

Greek-speaking believers complain that their widows are overlooked in the daily food. The apostles ask the church to choose seven trusted men, and Stephen is named first. *Acts 6:1–6*

Jerusalem

Wonders and wisdom

Stephen, "full of faith and power," does great wonders among the people. Men from several synagogues argue with him, but they cannot resist the wisdom and Spirit with which he speaks. *Acts 6:8–10*

Before the council

False charges

His opponents stir up the people and bring false witnesses. They claim he speaks against the temple and the law. The council sees his face "as it had been the face of an angel." *Acts 6:11–15*

Before the council

The great speech

Stephen retells Israel's history: Abraham, Joseph, Moses, the tabernacle and the temple. He shows that Israel often rejected the ones God sent, and he charges his hearers with doing the same. *Acts 7:1–53*

c. AD 33–35
Outside the city

Stoned

Stephen sees the heavens opened and Jesus standing at God's right hand. The crowd drags him out and stones him. He prays for them and "fell asleep." *Acts 7:54–60*

After his death

Buried and mourned

Devout men bury Stephen with great lamentation. A great persecution breaks out, and believers scatter, preaching the word wherever they go. *Acts 8:1–4; 11:19*

Key activities

Stephen's speech in Acts 7 sometimes differs in small details from Genesis, such as where Abraham's call came and the numbers in Jacob's family. Most readers see Stephen following the Greek Old Testament or summarising freely.

1. **Served the widows.** He was chosen to oversee the daily distribution of food, so the apostles could give themselves to prayer and the word. *Acts 6:2–6*
2. **Did great wonders.** "Stephen, full of faith and power, did great wonders and miracles among the people." *Acts 6:8*
3. **Spoke with wisdom.** His opponents "were not able to resist the wisdom and the spirit by which he spake." *Acts 6:10*
4. **Retold Israel's story.** He traced God's work from Abraham to Solomon and taught that "the most High dwelleth not in temples made with hands." *Acts 7:2–50*
5. **Spoke hard truth.** He called his hearers "stiffnecked and uncircumcised in heart and ears." *Acts 7:51–53*
6. **Saw Jesus in glory.** "Behold, I see the heavens opened, and the Son of man standing on the right hand of God." *Acts 7:55–56*
7. **Forgave his killers.** He kneeled and cried, "Lord, lay not this sin to their charge." *Acts 7:60*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links. "Protomartyr" is a title from later tradition.

Old Testament

Genesis 12 – Exodus 32; 1 Kings 6–8	The history his speech retells
Amos 5:25–27; Isaiah 66:1–2	Prophets he quotes (Acts 7:42–43, 49–50)
Echo: 2 Chronicles 24:20–22	Zechariah stoned for speaking God's word

New Testament

Acts 6:1–8:2	The main account
Acts 8:1; 22:20	Saul consented and kept the killers' clothes
Acts 11:19	The scattering spreads the gospel to Antioch
Echo: Luke 23:34, 46	Jesus' dying prayers, mirrored by Stephen's
Echo: Revelation 2:10	The "crown of life," often linked with his name

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What words does Acts use to describe Stephen's character (Acts 6:3, 5, 8, 10)?
2. *Understand:* Stephen was chosen to hand out food, yet became a great witness. What does that say about "small" jobs?
3. *Apply:* Stephen prayed for those hurting him. Who is hard for you to forgive, and how could you pray for them?
4. *Apply:* Where have you seen God bring good out of a painful loss?

152 Ananias and Sapphira

A couple who lied about a gift, and a young church that learned to fear God.

In the first days of the Jerusalem church, believers shared what they had so that no one went without. Some sold land and brought the money to the apostles, as Barnabas did. Ananias and his wife Sapphira also sold property. But they agreed to keep back part of the price while appearing to give it all. Peter said the land and money had always been theirs to keep. Their sin was the lie. First Ananias, then Sapphira, fell down dead. It is a sobering reminder that God sees the heart, and that honesty matters more than the size of a gift.

At a glance

Names	Ananias, "the LORD is gracious"; Sapphira, probably "beautiful"
Family	Husband and wife (Acts 5:1)
When	Early years of the Jerusalem church, c. AD 30–33
Key places	Jerusalem
Key people	Peter; the apostles; Barnabas
Main passages	Acts 4:32–5:11
Not the same as	Ananias of Damascus (Acts 9:10) or the high priest (Acts 23:2)

"Whiles it remained, was it not thine own? … thou hast not lied unto men, but unto God."

Acts 5:4, KJV

The life of Ananias and Sapphira

Acts gives no date. The story comes early in Acts, before Stephen's death, so it probably happened within a few years of Pentecost, c. AD 30–33.

Jerusalem
Early church

The church shares

The believers are "of one heart and of one soul." They hold all things in common, and those who own land or houses sell them and lay the money at the apostles' feet. *Acts 4:32–35*

Jerusalem
Early church

Barnabas gives his land

Joses, called Barnabas, a Levite from Cyprus, sells land and brings all the money to the apostles. His generosity sets the scene for what follows. *Acts 4:36–37*

The sale

A plan to deceive

Ananias and Sapphira sell a possession. With his wife's full knowledge, Ananias keeps back part of the price and lays only a portion at the apostles' feet. *Acts 5:1–2*

Before Peter

Ananias dies

Peter asks why Satan has filled his heart "to lie to the Holy Ghost." Hearing Peter's words, Ananias falls down and dies. Young men wrap his body, carry him out and bury him. *Acts 5:3–6*

About three hours later

Sapphira dies

Sapphira comes in, not knowing what has happened. Peter asks whether they sold the land for so much, and she says yes. She too falls down dead at his feet. *Acts 5:7–10*

Afterward

Great fear

Great fear comes on the whole church and on all who hear. The apostles do many signs, and believers are added to the Lord, "multitudes both of men and women." *Acts 5:11–14*

Key activities

Readers have long asked why the judgment was so severe. Acts does not explain it. Many see it as a warning at the church's founding, like the judgments on Nadab and Abihu and on Achan at the start of Israel's worship and conquest.

1. **Sold a possession.** Like others in the church, they sold property. Peter says the land and the money were theirs to use as they chose. *Acts 5:1, 4*
2. **Kept back part of the price.** Ananias kept back part of the money, "his wife also being privy to it." *Acts 5:2*
3. **Lied to the Holy Ghost.** Peter told Ananias, "thou hast not lied unto men, but unto God." *Acts 5:3–4*
4. **Agreed together.** Peter asked Sapphira, "How is it that ye have agreed together to tempt the Spirit of the Lord?" *Acts 5:8–9*
5. **Died under judgment.** Each of them fell down and died when confronted with the lie. *Acts 5:5, 10*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; the couple is not named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: Joshua 7	Achan secretly keeps back what belonged to God
Echo: Leviticus 10:1–2	Nadab and Abihu judged at worship's start
Echo: 1 Samuel 16:7	"The LORD seeth not as man seeth"

New Testament

Acts 5:1–11	The only account of the couple
Acts 4:36–37	Barnabas's honest gift just before their story
Echo: Ephesians 4:25	Put away lying; speak truth with your neighbour
Echo: 2 Corinthians 9:7	"God loveth a cheerful giver"
Debated	Were they true believers disciplined, or never converted? Acts does not say

For discussion

1. *Observe:* According to Peter, whose was the land and the money before and after the sale (Acts 5:4)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think lying about a gift was treated so seriously in the church's early days?
3. *Apply:* Where are you tempted to seem more generous or spiritual than you are?
4. *Apply:* Sapphira had a moment to tell the truth (Acts 5:8). What do you need to be honest about this week?

153 Gamaliel

The respected teacher who told the council to leave the apostles alone.

Gamaliel was a Pharisee and teacher of the law, honoured by all the people of Jerusalem. He appears only twice in the New Testament, but both times matter. When the council was ready to kill the apostles, Gamaliel gave calm advice. If this movement came from men, it would fall apart. If it came from God, no one could stop it, and they might be fighting against God. The council agreed, and the apostles were beaten but freed. Years later Paul said he had been trained "at the feet of Gamaliel." Scripture never says Gamaliel believed, but his caution gave the young church room to grow.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Gamliel*, "God is my reward"
Family	Not given; tradition makes him Hillel's grandson
Role	Pharisee, "a doctor of the law," member of the council (Acts 5:34)
When	Teaching in Jerusalem in the early first century AD
Key places	Jerusalem
Key people	Peter and the apostles; the high priest; Paul, his former student
Main passages	Acts 5:17–42; 22:3
Not the same as	Gamaliel son of Pedahzur, a leader of Manasseh (Numbers 1:10)

"But if it be of God, ye cannot overthrow it; lest haply ye be found even to fight against God."

Acts 5:39, KJV

The life of Gamaliel

Dates are approximate (AD). Scripture gives no dates for Gamaliel. The council scene comes a few years after Pentecost, c. AD 30–33.

Before c. AD 30
Jerusalem

A respected teacher

Gamaliel is a Pharisee and a doctor of the law, "had in reputation among all the people." He teaches in Jerusalem and sits on the council, the highest Jewish court. *Acts 5:34*

Before c. AD 30
Jerusalem

Trains Saul of Tarsus

A young man from Tarsus in Cilicia studies under him. Saul is taught "according to the perfect manner of the law of the fathers" and becomes zealous for God. *Acts 22:3; 26:4–5*

c. AD 30–33
Before the council

The apostles on trial

The high priest's party arrests the apostles for preaching in the temple. Peter answers, "We ought to obey God rather than men." The council is furious and wants to kill them. *Acts 5:17–33*

The same day

Gamaliel speaks

He has the apostles put outside for a while. He reminds the council of Theudas and Judas of Galilee, whose movements died with them. He advises them to let these men alone. *Acts 5:34–39*

The same day

The council agrees

The council takes his advice. The apostles are beaten, told not to speak in Jesus' name, and released. They leave rejoicing and keep preaching daily. *Acts 5:40–42*

c. AD 57
Jerusalem

Paul names his teacher

Arrested in the temple, Paul speaks to the crowd in Hebrew. He tells them he was "brought up in this city at the feet of Gamaliel." *Acts 21:40–22:3*

Key activities

Gamaliel mentions Theudas before Judas of Galilee (c. AD 6). The historian Josephus describes a Theudas who rebelled c. AD 44–46, after this speech. Many think Gamaliel meant an earlier Theudas, while others suspect a problem in the sources. The question is still discussed.

1. **Taught the law.** He was a doctor of the law, honoured by all the people. *Acts 5:34*
2. **Trained Paul.** Paul was brought up "at the feet of Gamaliel." *Acts 22:3*
3. **Slowed down an angry council.** He had the apostles put outside "a little space" so the council could think. *Acts 5:34–35*
4. **Pointed to history.** He showed that the movements of Theudas and Judas of Galilee came to nothing after their leaders died. *Acts 5:36–37*
5. **Warned against fighting God.** "If this counsel or this work be of men, it will come to nought: But if it be of God, ye cannot overthrow it." *Acts 5:38–39*
6. **Persuaded the council.** "And to him they agreed," and the apostles were released alive. *Acts 5:40*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Gamaliel.

Old Testament

Numbers 1:10; 7:54	A different Gamaliel, leader of Manasseh
Echo: Proverbs 19:21	"The counsel of the LORD, that shall stand"
Echo: Proverbs 21:30	No wisdom or counsel against the LORD

New Testament

Acts 5:34–40	His speech in the council
Acts 22:3	Paul trained at his feet
Philippians 3:5–6; Galatians 1:14	Paul's strict Pharisee training
Echo: John 7:50–51	Nicodemus asks the council for a fair hearing
Tradition	Jewish tradition: a leading rabbi of Hillel's school. Christian legend, not Scripture: later baptized

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What two possibilities did Gamaliel lay before the council (Acts 5:38–39)?
2. *Understand:* Scripture never says Gamaliel followed Jesus. How is being open-minded different from trusting Christ?
3. *Apply:* Gamaliel calmed an angry room. When a conversation heats up this week, how can you slow it down?
4. *Apply:* Is there any place where you might be resisting something God is doing?

154 Philip the evangelist

The table-server who carried the gospel to Samaria, to an African official, and down the coast.

Philip was one of the seven chosen to care for the widows in the Jerusalem church. When persecution broke out after Stephen's death, he went to Samaria, a place most Jews avoided, and preached Christ with great results. Then an angel sent him to a desert road, where he met an Ethiopian official reading Isaiah. Philip pointed him to Jesus and baptized him, then preached town to town up to Caesarea. Twenty years later he was still there, "Philip the evangelist," with four daughters who prophesied.

At a glance

Name	Greek *Philippos*, "lover of horses"
Family	Four daughters "which did prophesy" (Acts 21:9)
Role	One of the seven; "the evangelist" (Acts 6:5; 21:8)
When	Active c. AD 30s–50s
Key places	Jerusalem; Samaria; the Gaza road; Caesarea
Key people	Stephen; Simon the sorcerer; the Ethiopian; Paul
Main passages	Acts 6:1–6; 8:4–40; 21:8–9
Not the same as	Philip, one of the twelve apostles (John 1:43–46)

"Then Philip opened his mouth, and began at the same scripture, and preached unto him Jesus."

Acts 8:35, KJV

The life of Philip the evangelist

Dates are approximate (AD). Acts gives no years. The mission to Samaria follows Stephen's death, c. AD 33–35, and Paul's visit to Caesarea is c. AD 57.

Early church
Jerusalem

Chosen as one of the seven

When Greek-speaking widows are neglected, the church chooses seven men full of the Spirit and wisdom. Philip is named second, after Stephen. The apostles pray and lay hands on them. *Acts 6:1–6*

c. AD 33–35
Samaria

Preaches Christ

Persecution scatters the believers. Philip goes down to the city of Samaria and preaches Christ. Crowds listen, unclean spirits are cast out, the lame are healed, and "there was great joy in that city." *Acts 8:1–8*

Samaria

Baptizes many, including Simon

Men and women believe and are baptized. Even Simon, a well-known sorcerer, believes and follows Philip. Peter and John come from Jerusalem, and the Samaritans receive the Holy Ghost. *Acts 8:9–17*

The Gaza road

Meets the Ethiopian

An angel sends Philip south to a desert road. He finds a treasurer of the queen of Ethiopia reading Isaiah, explains the passage, preaches Jesus, and baptizes him in roadside water. *Acts 8:26–38*

Azotus to Caesarea

Preaches along the coast

The Spirit catches Philip away. He is found at Azotus and preaches in all the cities along the way until he comes to Caesarea. *Acts 8:39–40*

c. AD 57
Caesarea

Hosts Paul

At the end of his third journey, Paul and his companions stay many days in Philip's house. The prophet Agabus comes and warns Paul about what awaits him in Jerusalem. *Acts 21:8–14*

Key activities

The KJV includes Acts 8:37, the Ethiopian's confession of faith. Many of the oldest Greek manuscripts do not have this verse, so some modern translations put it in a footnote.

1. **Served the widows.** He was trusted to oversee the daily care of the church's needy widows. *Acts 6:3–5*
2. **Crossed a cultural line.** He took the gospel to Samaria, and "there was great joy in that city." *Acts 8:5–8*
3. **Did signs.** Unclean spirits came out, and many who were palsied and lame were healed. *Acts 8:6–7, 13*
4. **Obeyed without delay.** Told to go to a desert road, "he arose and went." *Acts 8:26–27*
5. **Ran to the chariot.** The Spirit said, "Go near, and join thyself to this chariot," and Philip ran to it. *Acts 8:29–30*
6. **Explained Scripture.** He asked, "Understandest thou what thou readest?" and preached Jesus from Isaiah 53. *Acts 8:30–35*
7. **Baptized the Ethiopian.** The official went on his way rejoicing. *Acts 8:36–39*
8. **Kept preaching.** He preached in every city from Azotus to Caesarea, and years later was still known as the evangelist. *Acts 8:40; 21:8*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Philip.

Old Testament

Isaiah 53:7–8	The passage the Ethiopian was reading (Acts 8:32–35)
Echo: Isaiah 56:3–5	Faithful eunuchs promised a better name
Echo: Psalm 68:31	"Ethiopia shall soon stretch out her hands unto God"

New Testament

Acts 6:5	Listed second among the seven
Acts 8:4–40	Samaria and the Ethiopian
Acts 21:8–9	"Philip the evangelist," with four prophesying daughters
Echo: Acts 1:8	Judaea, Samaria, the uttermost part: Philip reaches each
Tradition	Often confused with Philip the apostle; later life in Asia Minor uncertain

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Philip do after the angel and the Spirit spoke to him (Acts 8:26–30)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Philip began with the very passage the Ethiopian was reading?
3. *Apply:* Who might welcome a gentle question about faith from you this week?
4. *Apply:* What small job could you take on this month to serve your church or neighbours?

155 Simon the sorcerer

The magician of Samaria who tried to buy the power of the Holy Ghost.

Simon was the most famous man in Samaria. For a long time he had amazed the people with sorcery, and they called him "the great power of God." Then Philip came preaching Christ, with real signs and healings. The crowds turned to Jesus, and Simon himself believed and was baptized. He followed Philip everywhere, amazed at the miracles. But when Peter and John arrived and the Holy Ghost was given through the laying on of their hands, Simon offered them money for the same power. Peter's rebuke was sharp: God's gift cannot be bought. Simon asked the apostles to pray for him, and there the story ends. His name lives on in the word "simony," the buying or selling of church offices and spiritual things.

At a glance

Name	Greek *Simon*, from the Hebrew Simeon, "hearing." Later called Simon Magus, "Simon the magician"
Family	Not given
Known as	"The great power of God," to the Samaritans (Acts 8:10)
When	c. AD 33–35, soon after Stephen's death
Key places	A city of Samaria
Key people	Philip the evangelist; Peter; John the apostle
Main passages	Acts 8:9–24
New Testament	Named only in Acts 8

"Thy money perish with thee, because thou hast thought that the gift of God may be purchased with money."

Acts 8:20, KJV

The life of Simon the sorcerer

Dates are approximate (AD). The events follow the scattering after Stephen's death, c. AD 33–35. Acts does not tell us what became of Simon.

Before Philip comes
Samaria

Amazes the people

For a long time Simon uses sorcery and bewitches the people of Samaria. He claims to be "some great one," and everyone from the least to the greatest listens to him. *Acts 8:9–11*

c. AD 33–35
Samaria

Believes and is baptized

Philip preaches the kingdom of God and the name of Jesus Christ. Men and women believe and are baptized, and Simon himself believes too. He stays close to Philip, amazed at the signs. *Acts 8:12–13*

Samaria

Watches the apostles

The church in Jerusalem sends Peter and John. They pray for the Samaritans and lay hands on them, and the believers receive the Holy Ghost. Simon sees it happen. *Acts 8:14–18*

Samaria

Offers money

Simon offers the apostles money, saying, "Give me also this power, that on whomsoever I lay hands, he may receive the Holy Ghost." *Acts 8:18–19*

Samaria

Rebuked and asks for prayer

Peter tells him his heart is not right before God and calls him to repent. Simon answers, "Pray ye to the Lord for me, that none of these things which ye have spoken come upon me." *Acts 8:20–24*

Group notes

Key activities

Christians differ on whether Simon's faith was real. Some think he was a true but immature believer who sinned badly. Others think his faith was only on the surface, because Peter says his heart was "not right in the sight of God." Acts leaves the question open.

1. **Practised sorcery.** He "used sorcery, and bewitched the people of Samaria, giving out that himself was some great one." *Acts 8:9*
2. **Believed and was baptized.** "Then Simon himself believed also: and when he was baptized, he continued with Philip." *Acts 8:13*
3. **Tried to buy spiritual power.** Seeing the Holy Ghost given, he offered the apostles money. *Acts 8:18–19*
4. **Heard a hard rebuke.** Peter said, "Thou hast neither part nor lot in this matter: for thy heart is not right in the sight of God." *Acts 8:20–21*
5. **Was called to repent.** Peter urged him to repent and pray, for he was "in the gall of bitterness, and in the bond of iniquity." *Acts 8:22–23*
6. **Asked for prayer.** He asked the apostles to pray for him. Acts does not say what happened next. *Acts 8:24*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Simon.

Old Testament

Deuteronomy 18:10–12	The law forbids witchcraft and enchantments
Deuteronomy 29:18	"Gall and wormwood," behind Peter's phrase
Echo: 2 Kings 5:20–27	Gehazi tries to profit from God's healing
Echo: Isaiah 55:1	Buy "without money and without price"

New Testament

Acts 8:9–24	The only account of Simon
Echo: Matthew 10:8	"Freely ye have received, freely give"
Echo: Acts 13:6–12	Paul confronts the sorcerer Elymas
Tradition	Later writers tied him to Gnosticism; these stories grew over time

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Simon see that made him offer money (Acts 8:18–19)?
2. *Understand:* What did Simon misunderstand about God's gifts?
3. *Apply:* Where are you tempted to use faith to gain attention or status?
4. *Apply:* Who could you ask to pray for you this week about a struggle you face?

Group notes

156 Paul

The persecutor who met the risen Jesus and carried the gospel to the Gentiles.

Paul, first known as Saul, was a strict Pharisee who tried to destroy the church. On the road to Damascus, the risen Jesus stopped him in his tracks. From that day he gave his life to the message he had fought. He travelled thousands of miles, planting churches across what is now Turkey and Greece. He was beaten, stoned, jailed and shipwrecked. Thirteen of his letters are in the New Testament. More than anyone, Paul showed that Gentiles are saved by grace through faith, just as Jews are. Acts ends with him in Rome, still preaching.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Saul*, "asked for"; Roman *Paulus*, "small"
Family	Tribe of Benjamin; son of a Pharisee (Philippians 3:5; Acts 23:6)
Background	Born in Tarsus; Roman citizen; a tentmaker (Acts 18:3; 22:3, 28)
When	Converted c. AD 33–35; died c. AD 64–67 (tradition)
Key places	Tarsus; Jerusalem; Damascus; Antioch; Corinth; Ephesus; Rome
Key people	Barnabas; Silas; Timothy; Luke; Priscilla and Aquila; Peter
Main passages	Acts 7:58–8:3; 9; 13–28; Romans – Philemon
Letters	Thirteen bear his name; authorship of some is debated

"I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me."

Galatians 2:20, KJV

The life of Paul

Dates are approximate (AD), combining Acts and Galatians 1–2. His death in Rome is tradition, not Scripture; some think he was released and imprisoned again.

Before c. AD 30
Tarsus and Jerusalem

A zealous Pharisee

Born in Tarsus, Saul is brought up at the feet of Gamaliel, more zealous than others his age. *Acts 22:3; Galatians 1:14; Philippians 3:5–6*

c. AD 33–35
Jerusalem

The persecutor

He consents to Stephen's death, drags believers to prison, and seeks letters to arrest them in Damascus. *Acts 7:58–8:3; 9:1–2*

c. AD 33–35
Road to Damascus

Meets the risen Jesus

A light strikes him down. Blind three days, he is healed and baptized by Ananias. *Acts 9:3–19*

c. AD 35–46
Arabia, Tarsus, Antioch

The quiet years

He preaches in Damascus, goes into Arabia, and works in Syria and Cilicia until Barnabas brings him to Antioch. *Galatians 1:15–24; Acts 9:19–30; 11:25–30*

c. AD 46–48
Cyprus and Galatia

First journey

Sent out with Barnabas, he preaches in Cyprus and Galatia, and is stoned at Lystra. *Acts 13:1–14:28*

c. AD 49–57
Europe and Asia

Council and later journeys

After the Jerusalem council, he plants churches in Philippi, Thessalonica and Corinth, then spends about three years in Ephesus. *Acts 15:1–21:16; 20:31*

c. AD 57–62
Caesarea and Rome

Prisoner for Christ

Arrested in the temple, he appeals to Caesar, survives shipwreck, and preaches two years in Rome under guard. *Acts 21:17–28:31*

Key activities

The order follows Acts. Paul's letters fill in his own thoughts and struggles along the way.

1. **Persecuted the church.** He "made havock of the church," and later called himself the chief of sinners. *Acts 8:3; 1 Timothy 1:15*
2. **Met the risen Lord.** On the Damascus road he asked, "Who art thou, Lord?" and heard, "I am Jesus whom thou persecutest." *Acts 9:3–6*
3. **Preached at once.** "And straightway he preached Christ in the synagogues, that he is the Son of God." *Acts 9:20–22*
4. **Was sent by the Spirit.** At Antioch the Holy Ghost said, "Separate me Barnabas and Saul." *Acts 13:1–3*
5. **Turned to the Gentiles.** When some Jews rejected the message, he said, "lo, we turn to the Gentiles." *Acts 13:44–48*
6. **Defended grace.** He resisted forced circumcision of Gentiles and rebuked Peter to his face. *Acts 15:1–2; Galatians 2:11–16*
7. **Answered the call to Europe.** A vision of a man saying "Come over into Macedonia, and help us" led him to Philippi. *Acts 16:9–15*
8. **Sang in prison.** Beaten and chained at Philippi, he and Silas prayed and sang praises at midnight. The jailer and his house believed. *Acts 16:22–34*
9. **Reasoned in Athens.** He spoke on Mars' hill about an altar "TO THE UNKNOWN GOD" and proclaimed the risen Christ. *Acts 17:22–34*
10. **Built up churches.** He stayed eighteen months in Corinth and about three years in Ephesus, teaching daily and working with his hands. *Acts 18:1–11; 19:8–10; 20:31–35*
11. **Wrote letters.** He wrote to churches and co-workers to teach, correct and encourage them. *Romans 1:1–7; 2 Thessalonians 3:17*
12. **Testified before rulers.** He spoke before Felix, Festus and King Agrippa, and he said, "I appeal unto Caesar." *Acts 24–26; 25:11*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Paul.

Old Testament

Habakkuk 2:4; Genesis 15:6	Roots of his teaching on faith (Romans 1:17; 4:3)
Isaiah 49:6	"A light of the Gentiles," taken as his calling (Acts 13:47)
Echo: Jeremiah 1:5	Set apart before birth (Galatians 1:15)

New Testament

Acts 7:58–28:31	The main account, from Stephen's death to Rome
Acts 9; 22:3–21; 26:9–23	His conversion told three times
Romans – Philemon	Thirteen letters bearing his name
2 Corinthians 11:23–28	His beatings, shipwrecks and dangers
2 Timothy 4:6–8	"I have fought a good fight"
2 Peter 3:15–16	Peter's "beloved brother Paul"
Tradition	Beheaded in Rome under Nero; his writing Hebrews is debated

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Jesus say to Saul on the Damascus road, and how did Saul respond (Acts 9:3–9)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Paul kept calling himself the chief of sinners (1 Timothy 1:15–16)?
3. *Apply:* Who have you quietly given up on, and how can you pray for them this week?
4. *Apply:* Who could you encourage this week with a note, a message or a visit?

157 Ananias of Damascus

The ordinary disciple who was sent to lay hands on the church's fiercest enemy.

Ananias was a devout believer in Damascus. Saul of Tarsus was coming to arrest people like him. Then the Lord told Ananias in a vision to go to the street called Straight and lay hands on Saul, now struck blind. Ananias was afraid, and said so. But the Lord called Saul "a chosen vessel" to carry his name to the nations. So Ananias went. His first words to the man who had come to arrest him were "Brother Saul." Scales fell from Saul's eyes, and Ananias baptized him. His obedience helped launch a great missionary.

At a glance

Name	Greek form of Hananiah, "the LORD is gracious"
Described as	"A devout man according to the law" (Acts 22:12)
When	c. AD 33–35, at Saul's conversion
Key places	Damascus; the street called Straight
Key people	Saul (Paul); the believers in Damascus
Main passages	Acts 9:10–19; 22:12–16
Not the same as	Sapphira's husband (Acts 5:1) or the high priest (Acts 23:2)

"Brother Saul, the Lord, even Jesus … hath sent me, that thou mightest receive thy sight."

Acts 9:17, KJV

The life of Ananias of Damascus

Dates are approximate (AD). Saul's conversion is dated c. AD 33–35. Ananias's story is told twice: by Luke in Acts 9 and by Paul himself in Acts 22.

Before Saul arrives
Damascus

A devout disciple

Ananias is a follower of Jesus living in Damascus. He is devout according to the law and well respected by the Jews there. He has heard of the harm Saul has done in Jerusalem. *Acts 9:10, 13; 22:12*

c. AD 33–35
Damascus

The vision

The Lord calls him by name, and Ananias answers, "Behold, I am here, Lord." He is told to go to the house of Judas on the street called Straight and ask for Saul of Tarsus, who is praying. *Acts 9:10–12*

The same vision

Honest fear

Ananias objects that Saul has come with authority to arrest all who call on Jesus' name. The Lord answers that Saul is "a chosen vessel unto me," and that he will suffer for Christ's name. *Acts 9:13–16*

The house of Judas

Sight and baptism

Ananias goes, lays his hands on Saul, and calls him "Brother Saul." Something like scales falls from Saul's eyes. He sees again, is baptized, and takes food. *Acts 9:17–19*

The house of Judas

A message for Saul

Paul later recalls that Ananias told him God had chosen him to see the Just One and be his witness to all people, and urged, "arise, and be baptized." *Acts 22:14–16*

c. AD 57
Jerusalem

Remembered by Paul

Speaking to a hostile crowd in Jerusalem, Paul describes Ananias as a devout man with a good report among all the Jews of Damascus. *Acts 22:12–13*

Key activities

Acts names three men called Ananias: the husband of Sapphira, this disciple in Damascus, and the high priest who later tried Paul. The name was common among Jews at the time.

1. **Heard and answered.** When the Lord called his name, he replied, "Behold, I am here, Lord." *Acts 9:10*
2. **Spoke his fear honestly.** "Lord, I have heard by many of this man, how much evil he hath done to thy saints at Jerusalem." *Acts 9:13–14*
3. **Obeyed.** "And Ananias went his way, and entered into the house." *Acts 9:17*
4. **Welcomed an enemy as family.** He laid hands on Saul and called him "Brother Saul." *Acts 9:17*
5. **Was used to heal.** "There fell from his eyes as it had been scales: and he received sight forthwith." *Acts 9:18*
6. **Baptized Saul.** He urged him, "why tarriest thou? arise, and be baptized, and wash away thy sins, calling on the name of the Lord." *Acts 9:18; 22:16*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; Ananias is not named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: 1 Samuel 3:10	Samuel: "Speak; for thy servant heareth"
Echo: Isaiah 6:8	"Here am I; send me"
Echo: Jonah 1:1–3	Sent to people he feared, Jonah ran instead
Echo: Exodus 3:11–4:13	Moses argued with God before going

New Testament

Acts 9:10–19	Luke's account of Ananias's vision and visit.
Acts 22:12–16	Paul's own account, adding Ananias's words about his calling.
Acts 26:12–18	Paul tells the story again before King Agrippa but does not mention Ananias.
Echoes	Barnabas later did something similar in Jerusalem, taking Saul in when others were afraid of him (Acts 9:26–27). Jesus taught, "Love your enemies" (Matthew 5:44). Paul wrote that God's people are "fellowcitizens with the saints, and of the household of God" (Ephesians 2:19).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Ananias say to the Lord, and how did the Lord answer (Acts 9:13–16)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think the words "Brother Saul" mattered so much?
3. *Apply:* Ananias admitted his fear, then obeyed. What is God asking of you that you have been putting off?
4. *Apply:* Who do you find hard to see as a brother or sister in Christ? How could you welcome them?

158 Barnabas

The "son of consolation" who saw the best in people and helped them grow.

His given name was Joses, a form of Joseph, but the apostles called him Barnabas, "the son of consolation." It fit him. He first appears selling land and giving the money to the church. When everyone in Jerusalem was afraid of Saul, Barnabas took him to the apostles and vouched for him. When Gentiles began to believe in Antioch, Barnabas was sent to check, and he rejoiced at what he saw. Then he went to Tarsus to find Saul and bring him into the work. Together they carried famine relief to Jerusalem and made the first great missionary journey. Later they parted over John Mark, and Barnabas chose to give the young man a second chance. Acts calls him "a good man, and full of the Holy Ghost and of faith."

At a glance

Name	Joses (Joseph); surnamed Barnabas, "The son of consolation" (Acts 4:36)
Family	A Levite; relative of John Mark ("sister's son," KJV; "cousin" in many translations) (Colossians 4:10)
Home	Cyprus; later Jerusalem and Antioch
When	Active c. AD 30s–50s
Key places	Jerusalem; Antioch; Cyprus; Iconium; Lystra; Derbe
Key people	Paul; John Mark; Peter; James, brother of Jesus; Silas
Main passages	Acts 4:36–37; 9:26–27; 11:19–30; 13–15
Called	An apostle, together with Paul (Acts 14:14)

"For he was a good man, and full of the Holy Ghost and of faith: and much people was added unto the Lord."

Acts 11:24, KJV

The life of Barnabas

Dates are approximate (AD). Acts gives the order but few years; the Claudius famine is usually dated c. AD 44–48.

c. AD 30–33
Jerusalem

Gives his land

Joses, a Levite from Cyprus, sells land and lays the money at the apostles' feet. They call him Barnabas. *Acts 4:36–37*

c. AD 36–38
Jerusalem

Vouches for Saul

The disciples fear Saul, but Barnabas brings him to the apostles and tells how he preached boldly in Damascus. *Acts 9:26–28; Galatians 1:18*

Early AD 40s
Antioch

Encourages new believers

Sent to check on Greek believers, he sees God's grace, is glad, and urges them to cleave to the Lord. *Acts 11:19–24*

Early AD 40s
Tarsus and Antioch

Brings Saul

He fetches Saul from Tarsus. They teach a whole year, and the disciples are first called Christians. *Acts 11:25–26*

c. AD 44–46
Jerusalem

Carries famine relief

He and Saul take Antioch's gift to Judea and return with John Mark. *Acts 11:27–30; 12:25*

c. AD 46–49
Galatia and Jerusalem

Journey and council

He preaches with Saul in Cyprus and Galatia, then defends the Gentiles at the Jerusalem council. *Acts 13:1–15:35; Galatians 2:1–10*

c. AD 49
Antioch

Parts from Paul

After a sharp disagreement over John Mark, Barnabas takes Mark and sails to Cyprus. *Acts 15:36–39*

Group notes

Key activities

Galatians 2:11–13 tells of a time at Antioch when Barnabas was drawn away from eating with Gentile believers. Scholars debate whether this happened before or after the Jerusalem council.

1. **Gave generously.** "Having land, sold it, and brought the money, and laid it at the apostles' feet." *Acts 4:37*
2. **Stood up for Saul.** "But Barnabas took him, and brought him to the apostles." *Acts 9:27*
3. **Rejoiced at God's grace.** In Antioch he "had seen the grace of God, was glad, and exhorted them all." *Acts 11:23*
4. **Brought others into the work.** He went to Tarsus to find Saul and brought him to Antioch to teach. *Acts 11:25–26*
5. **Carried help to the poor.** He and Saul took the Antioch church's gift to the elders in Judea. *Acts 11:29–30*
6. **Answered God's call.** The Holy Ghost said, "Separate me Barnabas and Saul," and the church sent them out. *Acts 13:1–4*
7. **Preached in Cyprus and Galatia.** He shared in the first journey, including the meeting with the governor Sergius Paulus. *Acts 13:4–12; 14:1–7*
8. **Refused worship.** At Lystra the crowd called him Jupiter and Paul Mercurius. He tore his clothes and cried out that they were only men. *Acts 14:11–15*
9. **Defended the Gentiles.** At the council he and Paul told what God had done among the Gentiles. *Acts 15:2, 12*
10. **Stumbled at Antioch.** Paul writes that "Barnabas also was carried away with their dissimulation." *Galatians 2:13*
11. **Gave Mark a second chance.** He parted from Paul rather than leave Mark behind. *Acts 15:37–39*
12. **Worked for his own living.** Paul names him as one who, like himself, worked rather than rely on the churches' support. *1 Corinthians 9:6*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links. His martyrdom at Salamis is tradition only.

Old Testament

Numbers 18:20–24	Levites had no tribal land, yet Barnabas owned some
Isaiah 49:6	"A light of the Gentiles," quoted at Antioch (Acts 13:47)
Echo: 1 Samuel 20	Jonathan stands up for David

New Testament

Acts 4:36–37; 9:27; 11:22–30; 13–15	The main account
Galatians 2:1, 9, 13	Fellowship in Jerusalem; carried away at Antioch
1 Corinthians 9:6	He worked for his own living
Colossians 4:10; 2 Timothy 4:11	Mark, his relative, proves profitable
Tradition	The Epistle of Barnabas and Hebrews are not securely his

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How does Acts describe Barnabas in Acts 4:36 and 11:24?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Barnabas trusted people others doubted?
3. *Apply:* Who needs someone to stand beside them, as Barnabas stood by Saul?
4. *Apply:* Is there a disagreement you need to handle with more grace?

159 Cornelius

The Roman officer whose household became the first Gentile home filled with the Holy Ghost.

Cornelius was a Roman centurion stationed at Caesarea. He was not a Jew, but he feared God, prayed constantly, and gave generously to the poor. One afternoon an angel told him to send for Peter in Joppa. Meanwhile God was preparing Peter with a vision of unclean animals and a voice saying, "What God hath cleansed, that call not thou common." When Peter arrived, Cornelius had gathered his relatives and friends. As Peter preached Jesus, the Holy Ghost fell on them all. It was a turning point: God welcomes every nation on the same terms, through faith in Christ.

At a glance

Name	Latin *Cornelius*, a common Roman family name
Family	"All his house" (Acts 10:2, 24)
Rank	Centurion of "the band called the Italian band" (Acts 10:1)
When	Probably the late AD 30s, before AD 44
Key places	Caesarea; Joppa
Key people	Peter; an angel; the believers from Joppa
Main passages	Acts 10:1–48; 11:1–18; 15:7–9
Known as	First Gentile household shown receiving the Spirit (Acts 10:44–45)

"Of a truth I perceive that God is no respecter of persons: But in every nation he that feareth him, and worketh righteousness, is accepted with him."

Acts 10:34–35, KJV

The life of Cornelius

Acts gives no year. The story comes after Paul's conversion and before Herod Agrippa I's death in AD 44, so it probably happened in the late AD 30s. The timeline follows the days as Acts counts them.

Before the vision
Caesarea

A devout soldier

Cornelius is a centurion who fears God with all his household. He gives much alms to the people and prays to God continually. *Acts 10:1–2*

Day 1
The ninth hour

An angel appears

About three in the afternoon, an angel tells Cornelius that his prayers and alms have come up before God. He is to send to Joppa for Simon Peter. He sends two servants and a soldier. *Acts 10:3–8*

Day 2
Joppa

Peter's vision

At noon on the rooftop, Peter sees a sheet full of animals, clean and unclean, and hears, "What God hath cleansed, that call not thou common." Cornelius's messengers arrive at the gate. *Acts 10:9–23*

Day 4
Caesarea

Peter arrives

Cornelius has gathered his relatives and close friends. He falls at Peter's feet, but Peter raises him up, saying, "I myself also am a man." Cornelius explains why he sent for him. *Acts 10:24–33*

Day 4
Caesarea

The Spirit falls

While Peter is still preaching about Jesus, the Holy Ghost falls on all who hear. The Jewish believers are astonished. Peter orders them to be baptized in the name of the Lord. *Acts 10:34–48*

Soon after
Jerusalem

Peter explains

Some believers criticise Peter for eating with Gentiles. He tells the whole story, and they fall silent and glorify God, saying God has granted the Gentiles "repentance unto life." *Acts 11:1–18*

Key activities

Some scholars point out that the Italian cohort is known from inscriptions at a slightly later date. Others note that auxiliary units moved often, so this does not create a real difficulty.

1. **Feared God with his household.** He led his whole house in the worship of the God of Israel. *Acts 10:2*
2. **Gave and prayed.** He "gave much alms to the people, and prayed to God alway." *Acts 10:2*
3. **Obeyed at once.** As soon as the angel left, he sent men to Joppa. *Acts 10:7–8*
4. **Gathered others to hear.** He called together his relatives and near friends to wait for Peter. *Acts 10:24*
5. **Listened with an open heart.** "Now therefore are we all here present before God, to hear all things that are commanded thee of God." *Acts 10:33*
6. **Received the Holy Ghost.** "While Peter yet spake these words, the Holy Ghost fell on all them which heard the word." *Acts 10:44*
7. **Was baptized.** He and his household were baptized in the name of the Lord and asked Peter to stay on for some days. *Acts 10:47–48*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Cornelius.

Old Testament

Leviticus 11	Clean and unclean animals, behind Peter's vision
Echo: Genesis 12:3	All families of the earth blessed in Abraham
Echo: 2 Kings 5:15	Naaman, a foreign commander, knows Israel's God
Echo: Jonah 1:3; 4:1–2	From Joppa too, Jonah resisted mercy to Gentiles

New Testament

Acts 10:1–48	The main account
Acts 11:1–18	Peter retells the story in Jerusalem
Acts 15:7–9	Peter recalls it at the council
Echo: Matthew 8:5–13	The centurion of Capernaum's great faith
Echo: Galatians 3:28	Neither Jew nor Greek, all one in Christ

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What words does Acts use to describe Cornelius before Peter came (Acts 10:1–2, 22)?
2. *Understand:* Cornelius already prayed and gave alms. Why did he still need to hear about Jesus (Acts 10:43; 11:14)?
3. *Apply:* Who could you invite to church, to a meal or to your group this month?
4. *Apply:* Is there a kind of person you tend to avoid? What is one step toward them this week?

160 Dorcas

The disciple of Joppa whose kindness was so missed that Peter was called to her deathbed.

Dorcas, also called Tabitha, lived in the port town of Joppa. Acts calls her "a certain disciple" and says she "was full of good works and almsdeeds." She made coats and garments for the town's widows, some of the poorest people of her day. When she died, the believers laid her in an upper room and sent for Peter from nearby Lydda. The widows met him in tears, holding up the clothes she had made. Peter knelt, prayed, and said, "Tabitha, arise." She opened her eyes and sat up, and many in Joppa believed. Her story shows how much quiet, practical love matters to God.

At a glance

Names	Aramaic *Tabitha*, Greek *Dorcas*: both "gazelle"
Family	Not given
Described as	"A certain disciple," "full of good works and almsdeeds" (Acts 9:36)
When	Probably the late AD 30s
Key places	Joppa; Lydda
Key people	Peter; the widows of Joppa; two messengers; Simon the tanner
Main passages	Acts 9:36–43
New Testament	Named only in Acts 9

> *"But Peter put them all forth, and kneeled down, and prayed; and turning him to the body said, Tabitha, arise. And she opened her eyes: and when she saw Peter, she sat up."*
>
> Acts 9:40, KJV

The life of Dorcas

Acts gives no year. The story comes after Saul's conversion and just before Peter's visit to Cornelius, so it probably happened in the late AD 30s.

Joppa
Before her illness

A disciple full of good works

Tabitha, called Dorcas in Greek, is a believer in Joppa. She is known for her good works and her gifts to the poor. She makes coats and garments for the widows. *Acts 9:36, 39*

Joppa
In those days

Sickness and death

Dorcas falls sick and dies. The believers wash her body, as was the custom, and lay her in an upper room instead of burying her at once. *Acts 9:37*

Lydda, nearby

A message for Peter

Hearing that Peter is at Lydda, where he has just healed Aeneas, the disciples send two men. They beg him not to delay in coming to them. *Acts 9:32–35, 38*

The upper room

The widows weep

Peter comes at once. The widows stand beside him weeping, showing him the coats and garments Dorcas made while she was with them. *Acts 9:39*

The upper room

Raised to life

Peter sends them all out, kneels and prays. He says, "Tabitha, arise." She opens her eyes, sees Peter and sits up. He gives her his hand and presents her alive to the saints and widows. *Acts 9:40–41*

Joppa
Afterward

Many believe

The news spreads through all Joppa, and many believe in the Lord. Peter stays many days in the town with Simon, a tanner. *Acts 9:42–43*

Key activities

Acts 9:36 is the only place in the New Testament where the feminine form of the Greek word for "disciple" is used. Dorcas is the only woman given that exact title.

1. **Followed Jesus.** Acts calls her "a certain disciple." *Acts 9:36*
2. **Did good works.** She "was full of good works and almsdeeds which she did." *Acts 9:36*
3. **Clothed the widows.** She made coats and garments for widows in need. *Acts 9:39*
4. **Was deeply loved.** The widows wept and showed Peter the clothes she had made "while she was with them." *Acts 9:39*
5. **Was raised to life.** At Peter's word, "Tabitha, arise," she opened her eyes and sat up. *Acts 9:40–41*
6. **Became a witness.** Her raising "was known throughout all Joppa; and many believed in the Lord." *Acts 9:42*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Dorcas.

Old Testament

Echoes	Elijah raised the widow of Zarephath's son in an upper room (1 Kings 17:17–24). Elisha shut the door and prayed before the Shunammite woman's son was raised (2 Kings 4:32–37). The good wife of Proverbs "stretcheth out her hand to the poor" (Proverbs 31:20).

New Testament

Acts 9:36–43	This is the only account of Dorcas.
Echoes	Jesus put the mourners out and said to Jairus' daughter, "Talitha cumi," meaning "Damsel, I say unto thee, arise" (Mark 5:40–41). Peter follows the same pattern. Jesus said, "Naked, and ye clothed me" (Matthew 25:36). "Pure religion and undefiled before God and the Father is this, To visit the fatherless and widows in their affliction" (James 1:27).
Tradition	A traditional burial place of Tabitha is shown in Jaffa today, but it cannot be confirmed.

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did the widows show Peter when he arrived (Acts 9:39)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Acts tells us about Dorcas's sewing before it tells us about the miracle?
3. *Apply:* Dorcas used a practical skill to serve others. What skill or resource do you have that could meet a real need this month?
4. *Apply:* Who in your community is like the widows of Joppa, easy to overlook? What is one way you could help them this week?

161 John Mark

The young helper who turned back, got a second chance, and became "profitable … for the ministry."

John Mark grew up in Jerusalem, in a home where the first believers gathered to pray. He was a cousin of Barnabas, and he set out with Barnabas and Paul on their first missionary journey. Partway through, at Perga, he left them and went home. That choice later caused a sharp quarrel that split Paul and Barnabas. Barnabas gave Mark a second chance, and years later Paul himself called Mark a fellow worker and asked for him near the end of his life. Peter called him "Marcus my son." Early church tradition names him as the writer of the Gospel of Mark. His story is one of failure, patience and restoration.

At a glance

Name	Jewish name John, Roman surname Mark (Latin *Marcus*) (Acts 12:12)
Family	Son of Mary, whose Jerusalem house was a place of prayer; cousin of Barnabas (Acts 12:12; Colossians 4:10)
When	c. AD 44 to the AD 60s
Key places	Jerusalem, Antioch, Cyprus, Perga, Rome
Key people	Barnabas, Paul, Peter, Timothy, Luke
Main passages	Acts 12:12, 25; 13:5, 13; 15:36–39
Letters	Colossians 4:10; Philemon 24; 2 Timothy 4:11; 1 Peter 5:13
Tradition	Named by the early church as the writer of the Gospel of Mark

"Only Luke is with me. Take Mark, and bring him with thee: for he is profitable to me for the ministry."

2 Timothy 4:11, KJV

The life of John Mark

Dates are approximate (AD) and follow Paul's journeys. The order of events after Acts 15 is pieced together from the letters.

c. AD 44
Jerusalem

A praying household

Freed from prison, Peter goes to "the house of Mary the mother of John, whose surname was Mark," where many are praying. *Acts 12:1–17*

c. AD 44–46
Antioch and Cyprus

Helper on the first journey

Barnabas and Saul take Mark to Antioch, then on to Cyprus, "and they had also John to their minister." *Acts 12:25; 13:1–5*

c. AD 46–47
Perga

Turns back

At Perga in Pamphylia, John leaves them and returns to Jerusalem. Luke does not say why. *Acts 13:13*

c. AD 49
Antioch

The sharp split

Paul refuses to take Mark again. He and Barnabas part, and Barnabas sails with Mark to Cyprus. *Acts 15:36–39*

c. AD 60–62
With Paul in prison

A fellow worker

Mark is with Paul again, one of the few Jewish co-workers who have been "a comfort unto me." *Colossians 4:10–11; Philemon 24*

c. AD 60s
"Babylon"

With Peter

Peter sends greetings from "Marcus my son," probably meaning a son in the faith. Many take "Babylon" as a code name for Rome. *1 Peter 5:13*

c. AD 64–67
Paul's last letter

Sent for

Near the end of his life, Paul asks Timothy to bring Mark, "for he is profitable to me for the ministry." *2 Timothy 4:11*

Key activities

Scripture never explains why John Mark left at Perga or how he and Paul were reconciled. It records only the break and, years later, Paul's warm words.

1. **Grew up among praying believers.** His mother's house was a gathering place where the church prayed for Peter's release. *Acts 12:12*
2. **Went with Barnabas and Saul.** He traveled from Jerusalem to Antioch with the two leaders. *Acts 12:25*
3. **Served as an assistant.** On Cyprus he helped the missionaries in their work. *Acts 13:5*
4. **Left the mission.** At Perga he departed and went back to Jerusalem, a choice Paul still held against him later. *Acts 13:13; 15:38*
5. **Received a second chance.** Barnabas, his cousin, insisted on taking him again and took him to Cyprus when Paul would not. *Acts 15:37–39; Colossians 4:10*
6. **Worked alongside Paul again.** Mark became one of Paul's "fellowlabourers" during his imprisonment. *Colossians 4:10–11; Philemon 24*
7. **Proved useful in ministry.** Paul asked for Mark because he was "profitable" to him for the ministry. *2 Timothy 4:11*
8. **Stood by Peter.** Peter called him "Marcus my son." *1 Peter 5:13*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; Mark is not named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: Jonah 3:1	The word came to Jonah "the second time"
Echo: Exodus 2:11–15; 3:10	Moses flees, then is sent back years later

New Testament

Acts 12:12, 25	His mother's house; the move to Antioch
Acts 13:5, 13	Helper on Cyprus; leaves at Perga
Acts 15:36–39	The sharp contention between Paul and Barnabas
Colossians 4:10–11; Philemon 24	With Paul again as a fellow worker
2 Timothy 4:11	"Take Mark"; Paul's authorship of the letter is debated
1 Peter 5:13	"Marcus my son" greets from "Babylon"
Tradition	Some suggest he is the young man of Mark 14:51–52; unnamed there

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How does Paul speak about Mark in Acts 15:38 compared with 2 Timothy 4:11?
2. *Understand:* What was each of Paul and Barnabas trying to protect in their view of Mark (Acts 15:36–39)?
3. *Apply:* Who in your life needs a second chance from you?
4. *Apply:* Where do you need to stop letting a past failure define you?

162 Silas

The Jerusalem leader who became Paul's partner and sang hymns in a Philippian jail.

Silas was a respected leader and prophet in the Jerusalem church. After the council in Jerusalem, the apostles chose him to carry their letter to the Gentile believers in Antioch. When Paul and Barnabas parted ways, Paul chose Silas as his new partner, and together they carried the gospel into Europe. At Philippi they were beaten and locked in the stocks, yet at midnight they prayed and sang praises to God. Silas helped plant churches in Philippi, Thessalonica, Berea and Corinth, and his name stands beside Paul's at the start of two letters. Paul's letters call him Silvanus. Later he appears with Peter. He is a picture of steady, faithful partnership.

At a glance

Name	Silas in Acts; Silvanus in the letters (most take as one man)
Background	A leader and prophet in the Jerusalem church (Acts 15:22, 32)
Status	A Roman citizen, like Paul (Acts 16:37)
When	c. AD 49–52 with Paul; later with Peter
Key places	Jerusalem, Antioch, Philippi, Thessalonica, Berea, Corinth
Key people	Paul, Timothy, Barnabas, Judas Barsabas, Lydia, Peter
Main passages	Acts 15–18
In the letters	2 Corinthians 1:19; 1 and 2 Thessalonians 1:1; 1 Peter 5:12

"And at midnight Paul and Silas prayed, and sang praises unto God: and the prisoners heard them."

Acts 16:25, KJV

The life of Silas

Dates are approximate (AD) and follow Paul's second journey, c. AD 49–52.

c. AD 49
Jerusalem

Chosen by the council

After the council, the apostles and elders choose Judas Barsabas and Silas, "chief men among the brethren," to carry their letter to the Gentile believers in Antioch. *Acts 15:22–29*

c. AD 49
Antioch

Prophet and encourager

Judas and Silas, "being prophets also themselves," encourage and strengthen the believers with many words. The KJV adds that Silas chose to stay on in Antioch. *Acts 15:30–34*

c. AD 49
Antioch

Paul's new partner

After Paul and Barnabas part ways, Paul chooses Silas. The church commends them to God's grace, and they strengthen the churches of Syria and Cilicia. *Acts 15:36–41*

c. AD 49–50
Philippi

Singing in prison

Paul and Silas are beaten and put in the stocks after Paul frees a slave girl from a spirit. At midnight they pray and sing. An earthquake opens the doors, and the jailer believes. *Acts 16:16–34*

c. AD 50
Thessalonica and Berea

Driven onward

Their preaching wins converts but stirs up a mob. Sent away by night to Berea, Silas stays there with Timothy while Paul goes on to Athens. *Acts 17:1–15*

c. AD 50–52
Corinth

Rejoins Paul

Silas and Timothy arrive from Macedonia, and Paul, "pressed in the spirit," testifies that Jesus is the Christ. Silas is named with Paul in both letters to the Thessalonians. *Acts 18:5; 1 Thessalonians 1:1*

Later
With Peter

A faithful brother

Peter writes his first letter "by Silvanus, a faithful brother unto you." *1 Peter 5:12*

Key activities

Acts 15:34 is missing from many of the oldest manuscripts, so most modern translations leave it out. Silvanus is the longer Latin form of the name Silas.

1. **Carried the council's letter.** He took the decision of the apostles and elders to Antioch and confirmed it in person. *Acts 15:22, 27*
2. **Encouraged the church as a prophet.** He "exhorted the brethren with many words, and confirmed them." *Acts 15:32*
3. **Joined Paul's mission.** He took Barnabas's place as Paul's partner on the second journey. *Acts 15:40*
4. **Delivered the council's decrees.** With Paul and Timothy he passed on the Jerusalem decisions, and the churches grew daily. *Acts 16:4–5*
5. **Suffered at Philippi.** He was beaten with rods and fastened in the stocks without a trial. *Acts 16:22–24, 37*
6. **Praised God at midnight.** He and Paul prayed and sang while the other prisoners listened. *Acts 16:25*
7. **Helped the jailer believe.** They told him, "Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and thou shalt be saved, and thy house." *Acts 16:30–34*
8. **Planted churches.** He preached in Thessalonica, Berea and Corinth. *Acts 17:4, 10; 2 Corinthians 1:19*
9. **Helped write letters.** His name opens both letters to the Thessalonians, and Peter wrote "by Silvanus." *1 Thessalonians 1:1; 2 Thessalonians 1:1; 1 Peter 5:12*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; Silas is not named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: Psalm 119:62	"At midnight I will rise to give thanks"
Echo: Psalm 105:17–18	Joseph's feet hurt with fetters in prison

New Testament

Acts 15:22–40	Chosen by Jerusalem, sent to Antioch, chosen by Paul
Acts 16:19–40	Beaten and jailed at Philippi; a Roman citizen
Acts 17:1–15; 18:5	Thessalonica and Berea; rejoins Paul in Corinth
2 Corinthians 1:19	Preached Christ at Corinth
1 and 2 Thessalonians 1:1	Named as a sender with Paul
1 Peter 5:12	"By Silvanus": helper in writing or carrier? Debated
Echo: Philippians 4:4	"Rejoice in the Lord alway," written from prison

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Paul and Silas do at midnight, and who was listening (Acts 16:25)?
2. *Understand:* Silas was a Jerusalem leader, yet spent years as Paul's partner. What does that show?
3. *Apply:* How could you pray or give thanks in a hard situation you face now?
4. *Apply:* Whose steady, quiet service could you thank or support this week?

163 Lydia

The businesswoman by the river "whose heart the Lord opened."

Lydia was a trader in purple cloth from the city of Thyatira, living in Philippi when Paul first crossed into Europe. She already worshipped the God of Israel. One sabbath she was with a group of women praying by a river outside the city when Paul and his companions sat down and spoke to them. As she listened, the Lord opened her heart. She and her household were baptized, and she insisted that the missionaries stay in her home. Later the believers gathered at her house. She is the first convert Acts records in Europe, and her faith moved quickly from hearing to hospitality.

At a glance

Name	Lydia; perhaps "the Lydian woman"
Home city	Thyatira, in the Roman province of Asia (Acts 16:14)
Lived in	Philippi, a Roman colony in Macedonia (Acts 16:12, 15)
Work	"A seller of purple," costly dye or cloth (Acts 16:14)
Faith	She "worshipped God" before she heard Paul (Acts 16:14)
When	c. AD 49–50, on Paul's second journey
Key people	Paul, Silas, and the writer of Acts ("we," Acts 16:13)
New Testament	Named only in Acts 16:14 and 16:40

> *"And a certain woman named Lydia, a seller of purple, of the city of Thyatira, which worshipped God, heard us: whose heart the Lord opened, that she attended unto the things which were spoken of Paul."*
>
> Acts 16:14, KJV

The life of Lydia

Dates are approximate (AD). Lydia's story takes place during Paul's second journey, c. AD 49–52. Acts records only a few days of her life.

Before Paul came

From Thyatira to Philippi

Lydia, originally from Thyatira, has a house in Philippi and trades in purple. She already worships the God of Israel. *Acts 16:14–15*

c. AD 49–50
Troas

A call to Macedonia

Paul sees a vision of a man of Macedonia praying, "Come over into Macedonia, and help us." The team sails for Europe and reaches Philippi. *Acts 16:9–12*

c. AD 49–50
A sabbath by the river

She listens

Outside the city, by a river "where prayer was wont to be made," women gather. Paul and his companions sit down and speak to them, and Lydia listens. *Acts 16:13–14*

The same season

Heart opened, household baptized

The Lord opens Lydia's heart to take in Paul's message. She and her household are baptized. *Acts 16:14–15*

During their stay

Opens her home

She urges the travelers, "If ye have judged me to be faithful to the Lord, come into my house, and abide there." They accept. *Acts 16:15*

After the prison

Hosts the church

Freed from prison, Paul and Silas go to Lydia's house, see the believers, comfort them, and leave the city. *Acts 16:40*

Group notes

Key activities

Acts does not say whether Lydia was married, widowed or single. That she had her own house and household suggests she was its head, but Scripture gives no more detail.

1. **Ran a business.** She sold purple, a trade in luxury goods, far from her home city. *Acts 16:14*
2. **Worshipped God.** Before meeting Paul, she already worshipped the God of Israel. *Acts 16:14*
3. **Kept the place of prayer.** She was among the women who met by the river on the sabbath. *Acts 16:13*
4. **Listened.** She "heard us," and "attended unto the things which were spoken of Paul." *Acts 16:14*
5. **Was baptized with her household.** She took her stand with Christ publicly, and her household joined her. *Acts 16:15*
6. **Offered hospitality.** She pressed the travelers to stay with her until they agreed: "And she constrained us." *Acts 16:15*
7. **Hosted the young church.** After the prison, the believers were gathered at her house. *Acts 16:40*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; Lydia is not named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: Exodus 26:1	Blue, purple and scarlet in the tabernacle
Echo: Proverbs 31:24	The capable woman "maketh fine linen, and selleth it"
Echo: Genesis 18:1–8	Abraham hurries to welcome strangers

New Testament

Acts 16:12–15	She hears, believes, is baptized, opens her home
Acts 16:40	Paul and Silas return to her house
Philippians 1:3–5	"Fellowship in the gospel from the first day"
Revelation 2:18–29	Christ's letter to Thyatira, her home city
Echo: Luke 24:45	Jesus opens the disciples' understanding

For discussion

1. *Observe:* Where was Lydia, and what was she doing, when she first heard Paul (Acts 16:13–14)?
2. *Understand:* Lydia listened, and "the Lord opened" her heart (Acts 16:14). How do those two work together?
3. *Apply:* How could you use your home or table for someone this month?
4. *Apply:* How might your job or skills serve God's people?

Group notes

164 Priscilla and Aquila

A tentmaking couple who opened their home to Paul, taught Apollos, and risked their lives for the gospel.

Priscilla and Aquila were a Jewish couple who made tents for a living. Forced out of Rome by the emperor Claudius, they settled in Corinth, where Paul lived and worked with them. They later moved with him to Ephesus, where they quietly explained the way of God more fully to the gifted preacher Apollos. Wherever they lived, a church met in their house. Paul said they had risked their own necks for his life. They are never mentioned apart, and often Priscilla is named first. Their story shows how ordinary work, a shared home and a steady marriage can serve the gospel.

At a glance

Names	Priscilla (Prisca, 2 Timothy 4:19) and her husband Aquila
Origin	Aquila was a Jew "born in Pontus" (Acts 18:2)
Work	Tentmakers, the same trade as Paul (Acts 18:3)
When	c. AD 49 to the AD 60s
Homes	Rome, Corinth, Ephesus, then Rome again
Key people	Paul, Apollos, Timothy
Main passages	Acts 18:1–3, 18–26; Romans 16:3–5
Also in	1 Corinthians 16:19; 2 Timothy 4:19

"Greet Priscilla and Aquila my helpers in Christ Jesus: Who have for my life laid down their own necks."

Romans 16:3–4, KJV

The life of Priscilla and Aquila

Dates are approximate (AD) and follow Paul's journeys. The date of Claudius's order comes from Roman writers, not from Acts.

c. AD 49
Rome

Forced out

The emperor Claudius orders all Jews to leave Rome. Aquila and Priscilla move east to Corinth. Acts does not say whether they already believed in Jesus. *Acts 18:2*

c. AD 50
Corinth

Paul moves in

Paul arrives from Athens and finds them. Because they share the same trade, he lives and works with them while reasoning in the synagogue every sabbath. He stays in Corinth eighteen months. *Acts 18:1–4, 11*

c. AD 52
Cenchrea to Ephesus

Sail with Paul

When Paul leaves Corinth, Priscilla and Aquila sail with him as far as Ephesus. Paul travels on, and they stay behind. *Acts 18:18–19*

c. AD 52
Ephesus

Teach Apollos

They hear the eloquent preacher Apollos speak boldly in the synagogue. They take him aside and explain "the way of God more perfectly." *Acts 18:24–26*

c. AD 53–55
Ephesus

A church in their house

Writing from Ephesus, Paul sends greetings from Aquila and Priscilla "with the church that is in their house." *1 Corinthians 16:8, 19*

c. AD 57
Rome

Back home

Paul greets them in Rome, praising them as helpers who risked their lives for him. Again a church meets in their house. *Romans 16:3–5*

c. AD 64–67
Probably Ephesus

Still remembered

In his last letter Paul sends greetings to "Prisca and Aquila." Timothy, who receives the letter, seems to be in Ephesus. *2 Timothy 4:19*

Key activities

The couple are always named together. In several verses Priscilla comes first, which was unusual at the time. Some think she was the more prominent in the church; others suggest she came from a higher social rank. Manuscripts differ on the order in Acts 18:26.

1. **Started over.** Forced from Rome, they rebuilt their home and business in Corinth. *Acts 18:2–3*
2. **Took Paul in.** They gave him lodging and shared their work with him. *Acts 18:3*
3. **Moved for the gospel.** They went with Paul to Ephesus and stayed there. *Acts 18:18–19*
4. **Taught Apollos privately.** Rather than correcting him in public, "they took him unto them, and expounded unto him the way of God more perfectly." *Acts 18:26*
5. **Hosted churches.** Believers met in their home in Ephesus and in Rome. *1 Corinthians 16:19; Romans 16:5*
6. **Risked their lives for Paul.** They "laid down their own necks" for him. Scripture does not say when or where. *Romans 16:4*
7. **Earned the thanks of many churches.** Paul says all the churches of the Gentiles gave thanks for them. *Romans 16:4*
8. **Stayed faithful to the end.** Paul still sent them greetings in his final letter. *2 Timothy 4:19*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; the couple is not named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: Exodus 31:1–6	Bezalel and skilled workers serve God with their hands
Echo: Ecclesiastes 4:9	"Two are better than one"

New Testament

Acts 18:1–3	Tentmakers with Paul in Corinth
Acts 18:18–19, 26	They sail to Ephesus and teach Apollos
1 Corinthians 16:19	Greetings "with the church that is in their house"
Romans 16:3–5	Helpers who risked their lives; a church in Rome
2 Timothy 4:19	"Salute Prisca and Aquila"; Paul's authorship debated
Echo: 1 Thessalonians 2:9	Paul works so as not to burden the church

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Priscilla and Aquila do when they heard Apollos teach (Acts 18:26)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think they corrected Apollos privately?
3. *Apply:* How could your ordinary work or home open a door for someone this week?
4. *Apply:* Who has invested in you as this couple did in Apollos? How could you pass it on?

165 Apollos

The eloquent teacher from Alexandria who was willing to learn, and who "watered" what Paul had planted.

Apollos was a Jewish believer from Alexandria in Egypt, a gifted speaker who knew the Scriptures deeply. He arrived in Ephesus teaching boldly and accurately about Jesus, though he knew only the baptism of John. Priscilla and Aquila took him aside and explained the way of God more fully, and he accepted their teaching. He then went to Corinth, where he strengthened the believers and argued powerfully from Scripture that Jesus was the Christ. His gifts made him so popular that some Corinthians began to say, "I of Apollos." Paul answered that he and Apollos were only servants: one planted, one watered, but God gave the growth. Apollos is a picture of great gifts held with humility.

At a glance

Name	Apollos, a Greek name
Origin	A Jew "born at Alexandria," in Egypt (Acts 18:24)
Gifts	"An eloquent man, and mighty in the scriptures" (Acts 18:24)
When	c. AD 52 onward
Key places	Alexandria, Ephesus, Corinth in Achaia, probably Crete
Key people	Priscilla and Aquila, Paul, Titus
Main passages	Acts 18:24–19:1; 1 Corinthians 1–4
Also in	1 Corinthians 16:12; Titus 3:13

"I have planted, Apollos watered; but God gave the increase."

1 Corinthians 3:6, KJV

The life of Apollos

Dates are approximate (AD), during Paul's second and third journeys. Nothing is known of Apollos before Acts 18 or after Titus 3.

Early life
Alexandria

Trained in Scripture

Born a Jew in Alexandria, Apollos becomes an eloquent speaker and "mighty in the scriptures." He is instructed in the way of the Lord. *Acts 18:24–25*

c. AD 52
Ephesus

Bold but incomplete

"Fervent in the spirit," he teaches accurately about Jesus in the synagogue, though he knows only the baptism of John. *Acts 18:25–26*

c. AD 52
Ephesus

Taught more perfectly

Priscilla and Aquila hear him, take him aside, and explain the way of God more fully. *Acts 18:26*

c. AD 52–53
Corinth

Waters the church

With a letter of welcome from the believers in Ephesus, he crosses to Achaia. He greatly helps the believers and publicly shows from the Scriptures "that Jesus was Christ." *Acts 18:27–28; 19:1*

c. AD 53–55
Ephesus

His name used for a faction

Some in Corinth claim, "I of Apollos." Paul, writing from Ephesus, calls Apollos a fellow servant. Apollos, apparently near Paul, is not willing to return to Corinth yet. *1 Corinthians 1:12; 3:4–9; 16:12*

Later
Probably Crete

Still traveling

Paul asks Titus to help "Zenas the lawyer and Apollos" on their journey and see that they lack nothing. *Titus 3:13*

Group notes

Key activities

Acts does not explain how Apollos could teach about Jesus while knowing only John's baptism. Compare the disciples Paul met at Ephesus soon after (Acts 19:1–7).

1. **Mastered the Scriptures.** He was "mighty in the scriptures," well trained in the Old Testament. *Acts 18:24*
2. **Taught boldly.** He "spake and taught diligently the things of the Lord" and spoke out in the synagogue. *Acts 18:25–26*
3. **Received correction.** He accepted fuller teaching from Priscilla and Aquila. *Acts 18:26*
4. **Strengthened believers.** In Achaia he "helped them much which had believed through grace." *Acts 18:27*
5. **Argued in public.** He "mightily convinced the Jews, and that publickly," from the Scriptures. *Acts 18:28*
6. **Built on Paul's work.** Paul describes their work as one task: he planted, Apollos watered, and God made it grow. *1 Corinthians 3:5–9*
7. **Stayed away from Corinth for a time.** Paul urged him to go, but he was not willing then. Many think he wished to avoid feeding the divisions; the text does not say. *1 Corinthians 16:12*
8. **Kept serving.** He was still traveling in ministry in Paul's later years. *Titus 3:13*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; Apollos is not named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: Ezra 7:6	"A ready scribe in the law of Moses"
Echo: Proverbs 27:6	"Faithful are the wounds of a friend"

New Testament

Acts 18:24–28	Apollos in Ephesus and Achaia
Acts 19:1	Paul returns "while Apollos was at Corinth"
1 Corinthians 1:12; 3:4–6, 22	Believers take sides; both are servants
1 Corinthians 4:6; 16:12	Not "puffed up"; he declines to come for now
Titus 3:13	Sent on his way well supplied
Tradition	Luther suggested he wrote Hebrews; its author is unnamed and debated

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What words does Luke use to describe Apollos in Acts 18:24–25?
2. *Understand:* Why did Paul insist that "God gave the increase" (1 Corinthians 3:6–7)?
3. *Apply:* Apollos accepted correction from two tentmakers. How do you respond when someone offers to teach you?
4. *Apply:* Have you compared church leaders or picked favorites? How could you thank God for each?

166 Timothy

Paul's "own son in the faith," a young leader shaped by a faithful mother and grandmother.

Timothy grew up in Lystra, in what is now central Turkey. His mother was a Jewish believer and his father a Greek. From childhood his mother Eunice and grandmother Lois taught him the Scriptures. When Paul came through Lystra on his second journey, he invited Timothy to join him, and Timothy became his most trusted co-worker for the rest of Paul's life. Paul sent him to steady troubled churches, named him as co-sender of six letters, and wrote two letters to him, urging him to stir up his gift rather than give in to fear. Timothy's life shows how faith passed on at home can grow into a lifetime of service.

At a glance

Name	Greek *Timotheos*, "honoring God"; KJV often "Timotheus"
Family	Mother Eunice; grandmother Lois; Greek father (Acts 16:1)
Home	Lystra, in Lycaonia (Acts 16:1–2)
When	Joins Paul c. AD 49; still serving in the AD 60s
Key places	Lystra, Philippi, Thessalonica, Corinth, Ephesus, Rome
Key people	Paul, Silas, Luke, Lois and Eunice
Main passages	Acts 16:1–5; Philippians 2:19–23; 1–2 Timothy
Co-sender of	Six of Paul's letters, including Philippians

"Let no man despise thy youth; but be thou an example of the believers, in word, in conversation, in charity, in spirit, in faith, in purity."

1 Timothy 4:12, KJV

The life of Timothy

Dates are approximate (AD). Events after Acts come from the letters and cannot be dated closely.

Childhood
Lystra

Raised on Scripture

The faith of Lois and Eunice lives in him, and "from a child" he has known the holy scriptures. *2 Timothy 1:5; 3:15*

c. AD 46–48
First journey

Paul comes to Lystra

Paul is stoned at Lystra. Timothy probably comes to faith then; Paul calls him "my own son in the faith." *Acts 14:6–20; 1 Timothy 1:2; 2 Timothy 3:10–11*

c. AD 49
Second journey

Joins Paul

Well spoken of by the believers, he joins Paul, who circumcises him because his father is Greek. *Acts 16:1–3*

c. AD 50
Macedonia

Sent back to Thessalonica

He strengthens the persecuted church and brings Paul good news of their faith. *Acts 17:14–15; 18:5; 1 Thessalonians 3:1–6*

c. AD 53–57
Third journey

Paul's troubleshooter

Paul sends him from Ephesus to Macedonia and Corinth; later he travels toward Jerusalem. *Acts 19:22; 20:4; 1 Corinthians 4:17*

c. AD 60–62
Rome

At Paul's side

Named with Paul in prison letters: "I have no man likeminded." *Philippians 1:1; 2:19–23; Colossians 1:1; Philemon 1*

Later
Ephesus

Left in charge

Paul urges him to stay at Ephesus to stop false teaching. *1 Timothy 1:3; 3:14–15*

c. AD 64–67
Paul's last imprisonment

Called to come quickly

"Do thy diligence to come shortly unto me," bringing Mark, a cloak and the books. *2 Timothy 4:9–13, 21*

Key activities

Paul's letters show Timothy as loyal and trusted. Many readers also see him as young, timid or often unwell (1 Corinthians 16:10–11; 1 Timothy 4:12; 5:23; 2 Timothy 1:7). These are reasonable inferences, not direct statements.

1. **Learned Scripture at home.** His mother and grandmother passed on the Scriptures and their "unfeigned faith." *2 Timothy 1:5; 3:14–15*
2. **Earned a good name.** The believers of Lystra and Iconium spoke well of him before Paul chose him. *Acts 16:2*
3. **Gave up comfort for the mission.** He accepted circumcision so that Jewish hearers would not be turned away. *Acts 16:3*
4. **Delivered the council's decisions.** With Paul and Silas he carried the Jerusalem decrees to the churches. *Acts 16:4–5*
5. **Strengthened a persecuted church.** Paul sent him "to establish you, and to comfort you concerning your faith." *1 Thessalonians 3:2*
6. **Preached Christ at Corinth.** Paul names him as a preacher there with Silvanus. *2 Corinthians 1:19*
7. **Represented Paul.** Paul sent him, "faithful in the Lord," to remind the Corinthians of his ways. *1 Corinthians 4:17*
8. **Shared in Paul's letters.** He is named as co-sender of six of Paul's letters. *2 Corinthians 1:1; Philippians 1:1; Philemon 1*
9. **Cared genuinely for others.** Paul said he would "naturally care" for the Philippians. *Philippians 2:20–22*
10. **Led the church at Ephesus.** He was charged to guard sound teaching, choose qualified leaders and care for widows. *1 Timothy 1:3; 3:1–13; 5:3–16*
11. **Guarded his gift.** Paul urged him to stir up the gift given with the laying on of hands and not to be ashamed. *1 Timothy 4:14; 2 Timothy 1:6–8*
12. **Suffered for the faith.** Hebrews reports that "our brother Timothy is set at liberty," apparently from prison. *Hebrews 13:23*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links. Eusebius's "first bishop of Ephesus" is tradition.

Old Testament

2 Timothy 3:15	The "holy scriptures" he knew were the Old Testament
Echo: Numbers 11:28	Joshua served Moses from his youth
Echo: Jeremiah 1:6–8	"I am a child," yet God sent him

New Testament

Acts 16:1–5; 17:14–15; 18:5; 19:22; 20:4	His travels with Paul
1 Corinthians 4:17; 16:10–11	Sent to Corinth; "Let no man therefore despise him"
Philippians 2:19–22	"I have no man likeminded"
1 and 2 Timothy	Paul's letters to him; authorship debated by scholars
Hebrews 13:23	"Our brother Timothy is set at liberty"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* Who first taught Timothy the Scriptures (2 Timothy 1:5; 3:15)?
2. *Understand:* Why might example matter more than age (1 Timothy 4:12)?
3. *Apply:* Who passed faith on to you? Who could you pass it on to this month?
4. *Apply:* Where is fear holding you back from something God has given you to do (2 Timothy 1:7)?

167 Titus

The Greek co-worker Paul trusted with hard places: a test case in Jerusalem, a peacemaker in Corinth, and a builder in Crete.

Titus was a Gentile believer and one of Paul's most trusted partners. Acts never mentions him, so everything we know comes from Paul's letters. As a young man he went with Paul to Jerusalem, where the church leaders did not require him to be circumcised. That made him a living test of the gospel's welcome to Gentiles. Later Paul sent him to the troubled church at Corinth, and his return with good news lifted Paul out of deep distress. He then organized the collection for poor believers in Jerusalem. Finally Paul left him in Crete to appoint elders, and wrote him the letter that bears his name. Titus is a picture of a reliable servant sent into difficult places.

At a glance

Name	Titus, a common Roman name
Background	A Greek, that is, a Gentile, who was not circumcised (Galatians 2:3)
Relationship	Paul's "own son after the common faith" (Titus 1:4)
When	c. AD 46–49 to the AD 60s
Key places	Jerusalem, Corinth, Macedonia, Crete, Nicopolis, Dalmatia
Key people	Paul, Barnabas, the church at Corinth
Main passages	Galatians 2:1–3; 2 Corinthians 2; 7–8; Titus
In Acts	Never named

"Nevertheless God, that comforteth those that are cast down, comforted us by the coming of Titus;"

2 Corinthians 7:6, KJV

The life of Titus

Dates are approximate (AD). Galatians 2:1 may describe the famine visit (Acts 11:30) or the council (Acts 15), so the first date could be c. AD 46–49.

c. AD 46–49
Jerusalem

A test case

Paul takes Titus, a Greek, to Jerusalem with Barnabas. The leaders there do not compel him to be circumcised. Paul treats this as a defense of the gospel's freedom for Gentiles. *Galatians 2:1–5*

c. AD 55–56
Troas

Missed by Paul

Anxious about Corinth, Paul finds an open door to preach at Troas. Yet he has "no rest in my spirit" because Titus has not arrived, so he moves on to Macedonia. *2 Corinthians 2:12–13*

c. AD 55–56
Macedonia

Brings good news

Titus reaches Paul with news of the Corinthians' sorrow, repentance and renewed love for Paul. Paul is comforted, and Titus himself is refreshed by them. *2 Corinthians 7:5–16*

c. AD 56
Corinth

Completes the collection

Paul sends Titus back to finish gathering the gift for the poor believers in Jerusalem. Titus goes eagerly, "of his own accord." *2 Corinthians 8:6, 16–23*

Later
Crete

Setting things in order

Paul leaves Titus in Crete to "set in order the things that are wanting, and ordain elders in every city." *Titus 1:5*

Later
Nicopolis

Called to Paul

Paul asks Titus to join him at Nicopolis, where Paul plans to spend the winter. *Titus 3:12*

c. AD 64–67
Dalmatia

Sent on

In his final letter Paul notes that Titus has gone to Dalmatia. *2 Timothy 4:10*

Key activities

Acts never names Titus, and no one knows why. Everything we know about him comes from Paul's letters.

1. **Stood as a test case.** As an uncircumcised Greek believer, he went to Jerusalem and was accepted. *Galatians 2:1–3*
2. **Handled a painful situation.** After a sorrowful letter from Paul, he went to Corinth and found the church repentant. *2 Corinthians 7:8–13*
3. **Comforted Paul.** God "comforted us by the coming of Titus," Paul wrote. *2 Corinthians 7:6–7*
4. **Loved the Corinthians.** His affection for them grew as he remembered how they received him. *2 Corinthians 7:15*
5. **Led the collection.** He began the gift for Jerusalem's poor and was sent back to finish it. *2 Corinthians 8:6*
6. **Handled money with integrity.** He traveled with trusted brothers so the gift was above suspicion. "Did Titus make a gain of you?" Paul asked. *2 Corinthians 8:16–23; 12:18*
7. **Organized the churches of Crete.** He appointed elders who met clear standards. *Titus 1:5–9*
8. **Taught and modeled sound teaching.** He was to teach every age group and to be "a pattern of good works." *Titus 2:1–8*
9. **Went where he was sent.** He was last seen heading to Dalmatia. *2 Timothy 4:10*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; Titus is not named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: Exodus 18:21	Jethro: share the work with "able men"
Echo: 1 Samuel 12:3	Samuel: "whose ox have I taken?"

New Testament

Galatians 2:1–3	A Greek not compelled to be circumcised
2 Corinthians 2:12–13; 7:5–16	Paul's relief when Titus arrives
2 Corinthians 8:6, 16–23; 12:18	"My partner and fellowhelper"
Titus 1:4–5	Left in Crete; Paul's authorship of the letter is debated
Titus 3:12–13; 2 Timothy 4:10	Called to Nicopolis; gone to Dalmatia
Tradition	Eusebius: first bishop in Crete; later said to die there old

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Titus's arrival affect Paul (2 Corinthians 7:5–7)?
2. *Understand:* Why did Paul have trusted brothers handle the collection together (2 Corinthians 8:19–21)?
3. *Apply:* Who could you visit or contact this week with encouragement (2 Corinthians 7:6)?
4. *Apply:* What difficult task might God be asking you to take on rather than avoid?

168 Luke

"The beloved physician," Paul's loyal companion, and by early tradition the writer of Luke and Acts.

Luke is named only three times in the New Testament, all in Paul's letters. Paul calls him "the beloved physician" and a fellow worker, and in Paul's last imprisonment Luke is the one friend still with him. The early church also named Luke as the author of the Gospel of Luke and the Acts of the Apostles, which together make up about a quarter of the New Testament. Neither book names its writer, but in parts of Acts the narrator says "we," as if he traveled with Paul. If Luke is that writer, he crossed into Europe with Paul, went with him to Jerusalem, and survived a shipwreck on the way to Rome. His life shows careful work and faithful friendship.

At a glance

Name	Greek *Loukas*; "Lucas" in Philemon 24 (KJV)
Work	"The beloved physician" (Colossians 4:14)
Background	Probably a Gentile, since Paul lists him apart from his Jewish co-workers (Colossians 4:10–14)
When	With Paul at times from c. AD 49–50 into the AD 60s
Key places	Troas, Philippi, Jerusalem, Caesarea, Malta, Rome
Key people	Paul, Theophilus, John Mark, Demas, Timothy
Traditionally wrote	The Gospel of Luke and the Acts of the Apostles
Named in	Colossians 4:14; Philemon 24; 2 Timothy 4:11

"Luke, the beloved physician, and Demas, greet you."

Colossians 4:14, KJV

The life of Luke

Dates are approximate (AD). If Luke wrote Acts, the "we" passages (Acts 16:10–17; 20:5–21:18; 27:1–28:16) show when he was with Paul. That link is the traditional view, not a statement of the text.

c. AD 49–50
Troas

"We" join Paul

After Paul's vision of the man of Macedonia, the narrator writes, "immediately we endeavoured to go into Macedonia." The first "we" passage runs through the founding of the church at Philippi. *Acts 16:10–17*

c. AD 57
Philippi to Jerusalem

The collection journey

The "we" resumes as Paul sails from Philippi after the days of unleavened bread, through Troas and Miletus, then on to Tyre, Caesarea and Jerusalem. *Acts 20:5–21:18*

c. AD 57–59
Caesarea

Two years of waiting

Paul is held in Caesarea under Felix and then Festus. The "we" returns when the voyage begins there, so many think Luke stayed nearby, perhaps gathering eyewitness accounts. *Acts 24:27; 27:1*

c. AD 59–60
At sea

Storm and shipwreck

The detailed account of the voyage, the long storm and the wreck on Malta reads like an eyewitness report. On the island Paul heals many of the sick. *Acts 27:1–28:10*

c. AD 60–62
Rome

With Paul in prison

Paul sends greetings from "Luke, the beloved physician" and names "Lucas" among his fellow workers. *Acts 28:16; Colossians 4:14; Philemon 24*

c. AD 64–67
Rome

The last friend

In Paul's final letter, others have gone away. "Only Luke is with me." *2 Timothy 4:10–11*

Key activities

Neither the Gospel of Luke nor Acts names its author. From the late second century, writers such as Irenaeus name Luke, and many scholars accept this. Others think the author was a later Christian who used a travel source for the "we" passages.

1. **Investigated carefully.** The writer drew on eyewitnesses and set out to write "in order." *Luke 1:1–3*
2. **Wrote so others could be sure.** He addressed his work to Theophilus, "that thou mightest know the certainty" of what he had been taught. *Luke 1:3–4; Acts 1:1*
3. **Crossed into Europe with Paul.** He joined the mission from Troas to Philippi. *Acts 16:10–12*
4. **Traveled to Jerusalem with Paul.** He was part of the group that went up with Paul and the collection. *Acts 20:5–6; 21:15–18*
5. **Survived a shipwreck.** He sailed with Paul the prisoner and was wrecked on Malta. *Acts 27:1, 41–44; 28:1*
6. **Served as a physician.** Paul calls him "the beloved physician." *Colossians 4:14*
7. **Labored alongside Paul.** Paul lists him among his "fellowlabourers." *Philemon 24*
8. **Stayed when others left.** In Paul's last imprisonment Luke alone remained with him. *2 Timothy 4:10–11*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links. Luke's Antioch origin and later life are tradition only.

Old Testament

Echo: 1 Kings 11:41	Kings, like Luke, points to earlier written records
Echo: Proverbs 17:17	"A friend loveth at all times"

New Testament

Colossians 4:14	"Luke, the beloved physician"
Philemon 24	"Lucas" among Paul's fellowlabourers
2 Timothy 4:11	"Only Luke is with me"; Paul's authorship debated
Luke 1:1–4; Acts 1:1–2	Both addressed to Theophilus: one work in two parts
Acts 16:10–17; 20:5–21:18; 27:1–28:16	The "we" passages
Tradition	Some identify him with the unnamed brother of 2 Corinthians 8:18

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What does Luke say about his method in Luke 1:1–4?
2. *Understand:* Why might it matter that the Gospel's writer had "perfect understanding of all things from the very first" (Luke 1:3)?
3. *Apply:* Luke stayed with Paul when others left. Who needs a friend who stays?
4. *Apply:* What skill of yours could you offer to your church or community?

169 Philemon and Onesimus

A master and his slave, both brought to Christ through Paul, and a letter asking one to welcome the other.

Paul's shortest letter is a personal appeal about two men. Philemon was a believer, probably in Colossae, who hosted a church in his home. Onesimus was his slave, who had left him and possibly wronged him. Somehow Onesimus came to Paul in prison, became a believer, and was a real help to Paul. Paul sent him back asking Philemon to receive him "not now as a servant, but above a servant, a brother beloved," and offered to pay whatever he owed. We are not told how Philemon responded. The gospel reaches into the most unequal relationships and calls for reconciliation.

At a glance

Names	Philemon; Onesimus, "useful" or "profitable"
Philemon	A "fellowlabourer" whose house hosted a church (Philemon 1–2)
Onesimus	Philemon's slave, who had left him (Philemon 15–16)
Home	Probably Colossae, in Phrygia (Colossians 4:9, 17)
When	c. AD 60–62, in a Paul imprisonment (place debated)
Key people	Paul, Timothy, Apphia, Archippus, Tychicus
Main passages	Philemon; Colossians 4:7–9
Later mention	"A faithful and beloved brother" (Colossians 4:9)

"Not now as a servant, but above a servant, a brother beloved."

Philemon 16, KJV

The life of Philemon and Onesimus

Dates are approximate (AD). Most place the letter during Paul's imprisonment in Rome, c. AD 60–62. Some prefer an earlier imprisonment at Ephesus or the one in Caesarea.

Earlier
Probably Colossae

Philemon believes

Philemon comes to faith, apparently through Paul, who reminds him that he owes Paul "even thine own self." A church meets in his house. *Philemon 1–2, 19*

Before the letter

Onesimus leaves

Onesimus, Philemon's slave, is parted from his master. Paul hints that he may have wronged Philemon or owed him something. *Philemon 15–16, 18*

c. AD 60–62
With Paul in prison

Onesimus believes

Onesimus comes to Paul and becomes a believer. Paul calls him "my son Onesimus, whom I have begotten in my bonds." He becomes dear and useful to Paul. *Philemon 10–13*

c. AD 60–62
Sent home

Carrying a letter

Paul sends Onesimus back with Tychicus and calls him "a faithful and beloved brother, who is one of you." *Colossians 4:7–9; Philemon 12*

On arrival

Philemon's choice

Philemon must decide how to receive him. Paul is confident he will do "more than I say," and asks him to prepare a room for Paul's hoped-for visit. *Philemon 17–22*

Group notes

Key activities

Christians have read this letter in different ways. Paul does not directly command Philemon to free Onesimus, though some read "thou wilt also do more than I say" (verse 21) as a hint. Both sides of later debates over slavery appealed to it.

1. **Philemon refreshed the saints.** His love and faith encouraged believers: "the bowels of the saints are refreshed by thee, brother." *Philemon 4–7*
2. **Philemon opened his home.** The church met in his house. *Philemon 2*
3. **Onesimus came to faith.** In Paul's prison he became Paul's spiritual son. *Philemon 10*
4. **Onesimus served Paul.** Once "unprofitable," he was now "profitable," a play on his name, and Paul wanted to keep him. *Philemon 11–13*
5. **Onesimus went back.** He returned to the master he had left, carrying Paul's letter. *Philemon 12; Colossians 4:9*
6. **Paul appealed instead of commanding.** "Yet for love's sake I rather beseech thee." *Philemon 8–9*
7. **Paul asked for a brother's welcome.** "If thou count me therefore a partner, receive him as myself." *Philemon 17*
8. **Paul offered to pay.** "If he hath wronged thee, or oweth thee ought, put that on mine account." *Philemon 18–19*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; neither man is named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: Deuteronomy 23:15–16	Do not hand an escaped slave back
Echo: Genesis 44:32–34	Judah offers himself in Benjamin's place
Echo: Genesis 50:19–21	Joseph forgives the brothers who wronged him

New Testament

Philemon 1–25	Paul's appeal for Onesimus
Colossians 4:7–9	Onesimus travels with Tychicus
Colossians 4:17; Philemon 2	Archippus named in both letters
Echo: Luke 15:20–24	The father runs to welcome his son
Tradition	A bishop Onesimus of Ephesus (Ignatius, c. AD 110); same man unproven

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What does Paul offer to do for Onesimus (Philemon 17–19)?
2. *Understand:* How would "a brother beloved" (Philemon 16) change how Philemon saw him?
3. *Apply:* Is there someone you need to welcome back or be reconciled with?
4. *Apply:* Where could you stand in the gap for someone who has fallen short?

170 Felix, Festus and Agrippa

Three rulers who heard Paul: one trembled, one scoffed, one was "almost" persuaded.

In custody at Caesarea, Paul stood before three powerful men. Felix, the governor, heard Paul speak of righteousness, self-control and judgment, and trembled. Yet he put off any decision, hoping for a bribe. His successor, Festus, proposed a trial in Jerusalem to please the Jewish leaders, so Paul appealed to Caesar. King Agrippa II heard Paul's story and answered, "Almost thou persuadest me to be a Christian." All three agreed Paul had done nothing deserving death, yet none is known to have believed.

At a glance

Felix	Roman governor of Judea, c. AD 52–59 (Acts 23:24–24:27)
Drusilla	Felix's wife, "a Jewess" (Acts 24:24)
Festus	Porcius Festus, governor of Judea, c. AD 59–62
Agrippa	Herod Agrippa II; son of the Herod of Acts 12
Bernice	Agrippa's sister, who sat with him at the hearing (Acts 25:13, 23)
Place and time	Caesarea, c. AD 57–59
Main passages	Acts 23:23–26:32

"Then Agrippa said unto Paul, Almost thou persuadest me to be a Christian."

Acts 26:28, KJV

The life of Felix, Festus and Agrippa

Dates are approximate (AD). Felix governed Judea c. AD 52–59 and Festus c. AD 59–62. The exact year Festus arrived is debated.

c. AD 52
Judea

Felix takes office

Felix becomes governor of Judea. Paul later tells him he has been "of many years a judge unto this nation." *Acts 24:10*

c. AD 57
Caesarea

Paul sent to Felix

After a plot to kill Paul in Jerusalem, the commander Claudius Lysias sends him under heavy guard to Governor Felix at Caesarea. *Acts 23:12–35*

c. AD 57
Caesarea

The hearing

The lawyer Tertullus accuses Paul for the high priest. Paul answers calmly. Felix, who knows about "that way," puts off the case until Lysias comes. *Acts 24:1–23*

c. AD 57–59
Caesarea

Felix trembles

With Drusilla, Felix hears Paul speak of "righteousness, temperance, and judgment to come" and trembles. He sends Paul away, but often calls for him, hoping for money. *Acts 24:24–26*

c. AD 59
Caesarea

Festus and the appeal

After two years Festus replaces Felix, who leaves Paul bound. When Festus suggests a trial in Jerusalem, Paul appeals to Caesar. *Acts 24:27; 25:1–12*

c. AD 59
Caesarea

Before King Agrippa

Agrippa and Bernice visit Festus and hear Paul "with great pomp." Paul tells his story; Festus calls him mad, and Agrippa is almost persuaded. *Acts 25:13–26:32*

c. AD 59–60
Caesarea

Sent to Rome

Agrippa says Paul could have gone free if he had not appealed. Paul is sent by sea to Rome under a centurion named Julius. *Acts 26:32; 27:1*

Key activities

Josephus, a first-century Jewish historian, tells much more about these rulers. He says Festus died in office. Before the next governor arrived, the high priest had James, brother of Jesus, put to death in AD 62.

1. **Felix kept Paul under guard.** He ordered Paul "to be kept in Herod's judgment hall" until his accusers came. *Acts 23:35*
2. **Felix delayed the verdict.** He put the case off, saying he would decide when Lysias came down. *Acts 24:22–23*
3. **Felix trembled but waited.** "Go thy way for this time; when I have a convenient season, I will call for thee." *Acts 24:25*
4. **Felix hoped for a bribe.** He sent for Paul often, hoping to be paid to release him. *Acts 24:26*
5. **Felix left Paul bound.** "Willing to shew the Jews a pleasure," he left Paul in prison. *Acts 24:27*
6. **Festus acted quickly.** Three days after arriving he went up to Jerusalem, heard the charges, then held court in Caesarea. *Acts 25:1–6*
7. **Festus granted the appeal.** "Hast thou appealed unto Caesar? unto Caesar shalt thou go." *Acts 25:12*
8. **Festus sought Agrippa's help.** He admitted he had "no certain thing to write" to the emperor. *Acts 25:14–27*
9. **Festus dismissed the resurrection.** He called Paul mad: "much learning doth make thee mad." *Acts 25:19; 26:24*
10. **Agrippa gave Paul a hearing.** "Thou art permitted to speak for thyself." *Acts 26:1*
11. **Agrippa stopped short.** He admitted he was almost persuaded, then rose and ended the hearing. *Acts 26:27–31*
12. **All agreed Paul was innocent.** "This man doeth nothing worthy of death or of bonds." *Acts 26:31–32*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; these rulers are not named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: Jeremiah 37:17; 38:14–20	Zedekiah asks for God's word but won't obey
Echo: Daniel 4:27; 5:17–28	Daniel speaks plainly to kings
Echo: Psalm 119:46	"I will speak of thy testimonies also before kings"

New Testament

Acts 23:23–24:27	Paul before Felix
Acts 25:1–12	Paul before Festus; the appeal to Caesar
Acts 25:13–26:32	Paul before Agrippa and Bernice
Acts 12:1–23	Agrippa's father kills James and dies in AD 44
Acts 9:15; Matthew 10:18	Christ's name carried before governors and kings
Echo: John 19:4–16	Pilate found no fault but gave way to pressure

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What three subjects made Felix tremble (Acts 24:25)?
2. *Understand:* Felix delayed, Festus scoffed, and Agrippa said "almost." What lay behind each response?
3. *Apply:* Felix waited for "a convenient season." What step of obedience have you been putting off?
4. *Apply:* How would you tell, in two minutes, how you came to faith (Acts 26:9–23)?